rally settle the matter amicably. For example, if land becomes much more valuable on account of a large bazár having sprung up in its neighbourhood, or of a railway passing through the district, the ryot will consent to an increase of rent; and, on the other hand, if the land becomes impoverished from overcropping, or from drought, the landholder will make a corresponding deduction from the rent.

"The system of agriculture undoubtedly appears very rude, but it seems to answer well, for the Bengalis get capital crops from their lands. They plough with bullocks, or occasionally buffaloes. The plough is a very light and ramshackle-looking affair, which the ploughman carries over his shoulders when going to and from his work. It is made of wood and bamboo, with a little iron at the point, and does not go more than a couple of inches into the ground. Some European indigo-planters have tried deep ploughing with steam-ploughs, but the result has not answered their expectations, the crops being no better than those produced by the surface-ploughing, while the expense is much greater. In fact, much of Bengal is so fertile that we may apply to it the saying of some one about rich land in other countries, 'Tickle it with a hoe, and it smiles a harvest.' The great crop is rice; but besides this the Bengali ryot cultivates sugar-cane, tobacco, jute, &c. All these latter are much more valuable crops than rice, and require more trouble and expense for their cultivation. The rice is cut with a short knife or sickle, and is threshed by being trodden by cattle. The threshing-floor is a circular space in the field, made bare and hardened by beating down. The cattle employed are never muzzled.

"I have no wish to enter into the merits of the

vexed question of the comparative merits of large and small systems of agriculture, or, in other words, of the system of large farms and that of small holdings. I can only say that the latter seems to work well in Bengal, and that I should be very sorry to see the Bengali ryot or cottier sinking into the condition of a hired labourer. There is no doubt that the feeling of being to a certain extent his own master is a great satisfaction to the Bengali peasant-proprietor, and fosters in him an honourable spirit of independence — makes a man of him, in short, and keeps him from many bad habits. As a general rule, the Bengali peasant is a sober, well-conducted, frugal man, fond of his home and his family, and contented with his lot. Indeed, the great fault that many people find with him is that he is too easily pleased, and they would like better to see him have more wants, so that he might be stimulated to greater exertion in order to satisfy them. The great majority are very poor, and their houses are dark, comfortless-looking places, with bare floors and no furniture, except perhaps a wooden bedstead and a stool or two. Their houses are, in fact, little more than sheds for sleeping and cooking; for they are out of doors nearly all day, and when they come home in the evening they are not long in retiring to rest. Instead of one house containing two or three rooms, as in this country, the Bengali peasant's house consists of one room only, so that he has generally two or three houses in his homestead — viz., a sleeping-house, a kitchen, and a cowhouse. The well-to-do ryots often have a fourth house, which they use as a parlour in which to sit and talk with their friends, or as a sort of chapel for worship. All these houses are constructed of bamboos, with a few wooden posts to support the

thatched roofs, and are movable, the peasant always carrying away at least the roof of his house when he makes a flitting. Of course, the comfortless appearance of the Bengali's house is in part explained by the simplicity of his habits and the warmth of the climate. . . .

"Such money as the ryot has he expends in buying ornaments for his wife and children, or in marrying his sons and daughters. These ceremonies are the only times when he becomes thoroughly improvident and extravagant. Undoubtedly the thoughtless expenditure of money on such occasions is very foolish, but it has always been an Oriental custom to spend largely at marriages; and it appears to me that the Bengali who spends his savings upon his son's marriage is not much worse than the man who ruins himself by horse-racing or a contested election.

"Although the peasantry of Bengal are generally poor, yet, except in the case of a famine, there is hardly anything like actual destitution among them. The small piece of land which each holds supplies sufficient rice to keep his family from starvation, and the climate does the rest, for warm clothing and substantial dwelling-houses are not required. Hence it is in great measure that the country manages to get on without anything in the shape of a poor-law or organised relief, and that there are not many perpetual beggars except those who are either too idle to work or who are led by religious motives to subsist on alms. The above are in great measure the causes of the absence of destitution, but there is another cause, and that is the charitableness of Hindus. It is not the habit of the Oriental to devote large sums to the founding of hospitals, or to other great schemes of charity, but he is very open-handed in the

distribution of food and clothing, and many rich men spend large sums yearly in relieving the poor at their gates. No doubt a great deal of this charity is indiscriminate, and must do harm; still it does some good, and often saves the lives of those who have become temporarily destitute from the failure of their crops or from other causes.

"In spite, or perhaps in some measure in consequence of the distinctions of caste, there is a considerable amount of sympathy between the rich and poor in India, and a mutual understanding of their respective trials and difficulties. I have said that this sympathy may in some measure be a consequence of caste, and though the statement seems paradoxical, it contains a truth; for it is plain that the very fact of the fixity of caste, the knowledge that a difference of caste can never be effaced, and that the Sudra can never marry the daughter of the Bráhman, or sit down at meat with him, must extinguish jealousy and make the high-caste man feel perfectly safe in being kind to those below him. The high-caste man in India has none of those fears which are said to haunt some of the great in this country; the fear, namely, lest the distinctions of rank and station become obliterated, and all persons be reduced to one common level. Moreover, there is no necessary connection between high caste and riches, and it often happens that a man of high caste is poor, while the low-caste Sudra is rich.

"Apart from all these causes there is also the fact that a feeling of sympathy and compassion for poverty and old age has always been a characteristic of the Oriental mind."

I may also quote from the same lecture some remarks on Bengali women :—

"Perhaps the most widely-known fact in this country about women in India is that of widows being obliged to burn themselves along with the bodies of their husbands. This horrid practice of *satí*, as it is called, was at one time prevalent all over Bengal, and there are still Europeans living in India who have witnessed the spectacle of a widow-burning, even in the neighbourhood of Calcutta. The custom is now strictly forbidden in British territory, and has become as obsolete as the practice of duelling among ourselves. The abolition of satí is one of the benefits which Hindus owe to Lord William Bentinck, and on the pedestal of the statue erected to that nobleman in Calcutta there is a bronze representing a Bráhman leading a young Hindu widow to the funeral pyre, but prevented from effecting his purpose by an officer of the British Government, while the mother of the dead man holds up her grandchild to her daughter-in-law and invites her to live for its sake.

"Nowadays Hindu widows are not only not burnt, but they are even allowed to marry again, and instances of widow-marriages are by no means uncommon. It is to be hoped that this reform will spread rapidly, for the lot of a Hindu widow is commonly a hard one. Often she is a mere child, for early marriages continue to be the rule, and a parent is thought to fail in his duty to his daughter if he does not get her married by the time she is eight or nine years of age. Soon after her husband may die, but she is bound by the laws of society to remain single, and to spend her days in perpetual widowhood for a husband whom she may never have seen. She must relinquish all her jewels and finery, eat only once a day, fast every new moon, and absent herself from every scene of festivity and social enjoyment. It is probable enough that many

a young and childless Hindu widow, finding herself stranded almost before she has entered on the current of life, may curse the humanity which has preserved her, and wish in the bitterness of her heart that the sharp but short pain of fire might relieve her of the burden of existence.

"Widows, however, are not the only women in India who are unfortunate in their lot. All women are considered as inferior to men, and therefore as subject to their control. As one of the Hindu law-books expresses it, 'In every stage of her life woman is created to obey. At first she yields obedience to her father and mother. When married, she submits to her husband and to her father- and mother-in-law. In old age she must be ruled by her children. During her life she never can be under her own control.'

"The wife never eats with the husband, but waits until he has done, or, as the same law-book puts it, 'What woman would eat till her husband has first had his fill?' Speaking of other duties, the same authority says, 'When her husband sings, she must be in ecstasy; when he dances, she views him with delight: if he speaks of science, she is filled with admiration; when in his presence, she must be always gay.' So the poor woman must have occasionally a hard time of it; and one wonders what Mrs Caudle would have said to some of these regulations. Fortunately, the Bengali husband is not much given to joviality; and if he ever dance, he does not do so with young ladies; and if he ever sing, he is not likely to indulge in such strains as 'we won't go home till morning,' a ditty which it would be too much to expect any daughter of Eve to listen to with equanimity, far less ecstasy. As a curious instance of the reserve which a wife maintains with regard to her husband, I

may mention that she is most unwilling to utter his name, and that when she is a witness in court, she generally fences with the magistrate a long time before she acknowledges whose wife she is. The Bengali husband has a similar delicacy in referring to his wife, and if he has occasion to mention her, generally describes her by some such circumlocution as 'the mother of my children.'

"'One touch of nature makes the whole world kin.' The Bengali matron resembles her British sister in her unwillingness to answer another question which the magistrate is sometimes obliged to put to her. She objects stoutly to mentioning her age, and generally takes refuge in the plea of ignorance. When addressing her husband in private, she calls him *náth—i.e.*, lord.

"The seclusion of women is a practice which does not appear to have been in force in early Hindu times, and which the Hindus are supposed to have learned from their Mahomedan conquerors. It is, however, almost universal now, and few Bengali women of respectability will consent to appear before strangers. The part of the house she inhabits is that farthest away from publicity, and is called emphatically the 'inner place.' In Scotch phrase, she spends all her time in the *ben*, and never appears in the *but*. When she is obliged to give evidence or to hold any communication with a stranger, she does so from behind a curtain or from within a covered palanquin. Some affect to be still more particular, and will not hold direct communication with any man, even though a curtain be hung between them. Such ladies insist upon the conversation being carried on through the intervention of a third party, generally a female servant, who carries the questions and answers from one to the other. The pomp and

circumstance of an interview conducted with these formalities sometimes contrast ludicrously with the silliness of the questions.

"When a native lady has occasion to travel, she does so in a covered palanquin or litter, or in a boat. Sometimes she travels on an elephant, the howdah being carefully covered over. Many now make use of the railway, and I have heard bitter complaints from Bengali boatmen of the loss of custom sustained from this cause. 'Formerly,' they said, 'a gentleman taking his family to Benares or Allahabad, or other place of pilgrimage, would hire a boat, and would be weeks or even months on the journey; but now he engages a carriage in the train, and the whole distance is performed in one day.' Of course no native lady ever thinks of riding on horseback, and next to their dancing with other men than their husbands, nothing in the conduct of our countrywomen seems to surprise them so much as their riding.

"The only time when a native lady has a chance of seeing the world is when she goes on pilgrimage, and doubtless this is one reason why pilgrimages are so popular. It is by no means entirely or even chiefly from religious motives that women crowd to Hurdwar or to Púrí, &c., and I think our missionaries are wrong when they refuse to see anything in pilgrimages but the degrading superstition of the Hindu religion. It is, of course, foolish and pitiable that Hindu women should suppose that bathing in the Ganges or Bráhmaputra will cleanse them from their sins, but the change of scene and the novelty must do some good. I am persuaded that many rich old women go to the Ganges or to Kámrup for much the same reason that rich women in England go to Brighton or Homburg. When

a Hindu widow has become advanced in years, and has either no children or they are settled in life, it is considered the proper thing for her to retire to the holy city of Benares, and to remain there till her death. Many old men do the same, and the good results of living and dying in Benares are said by some to be so great that even a Christian dying there has a chance of getting to heaven!

"Women in the poorer classes are of course unable to maintain the state of rigid seclusion I have described. They must go to the tank or the well to draw water, and they have to go on foot if they want to visit a temple or witness a religious ceremony. In all ranks, however, the marketing is done by men; the only women who are ever seen in the markets being poor widows who have no one to look after them or bring them home their food."

The following remarks on the subject of food I extract from the same lecture:—

"Speaking generally, the Bengali is one of the most temperate of men, and the large class of temptations to vice produced by strong drink have little hold over him. His chief drink is cold water, about the quality of which he is most fastidious; hence it is that the digging of wells and tanks is considered such a meritorious act. At the same time, the Bengali forms no exception to the general observation that every nation has some kind of stimulant, and he supplies the place of wine and spirits by tobacco and pán. Pán is a compound of lime, the leaf of the pán plant, and the nut of the betel or supari tree, with occasionally other ingredients in the form of spices. Both tobacco and pán are universally used by men, and all women chew pán, and not a few of them smoke also. These practices even enter into their

religious worship; for with the daily food of rice, &c., with which they supply their gods, they offer also pán, and in some cases tobacco and a pipe in which to smoke it. A Hindu seldom eats flesh except what has been offered in sacrifice, and therefore when he wishes to treat himself to a meat dinner, the orthodox way of doing so is to offer a goat or a buffalo to the goddess Kali, a goddess who delights in bloody sacrifices. The animal is killed at her shrine by beheading, some executioners being so expert that they can sever the neck of a buffalo at a single blow.[1] Most Hindus eat fish without scruple, though some Bráhmans are so particular as to reject even this kind of animal food. Fish are abundant in the rivers and tanks of Bengal, and are caught either by nets or with the rod. Some scrupulous people draw a distinction between these two modes of capture, and will catch fish in nets but will not bait lines for them. The reason they give for the distinction

[1] There is, however, some trickery in the way this is done. Not only is the buffalo selected for sacrifice generally only a calf, but it is not standing loose or only tethered when it is decapitated. The unfortunate animal's neck is placed in an upright wooden fork, and there secured by a bolt. Several persons then pull the hind legs and others the head until the latter is almost torn from the body, and the neck becomes tight and drawn, and almost as thin as a knife-edge. It is after these preparations that the beheading takes place. They take some time, and meanwhile the poor beast bellows with fear and pain, and is almost dead before the final blow is given. I have never witnessed the sight myself, but it has been described to me as being a most horrid one, and as calling for the interposition of the Legislature. No doubt some fixing of the head is necessary, and such a mode of executing a bull as is shown in Raphael's cartoon is probably an impossibility. At all events, the real circumstances of a sacrifice in ancient times were probably much less graceful than the painter has represented them to be. Still, if buffaloes and goats must be sacrificed, some less painful mode of killing them might be adopted. If this were done, there would be comparatively little evil in the practice, for the victims are generally eaten, so that a sacrifice is only a roundabout way of procuring animal food.

is that rod-fishing implies deceit and treachery, the fish being deluded into being caught by the fisherman's putting on the mask of kindness and pretending to offer them food. Fowls are an abomination to the Hindu; so when a Mahomedan and a Hindu are next-door neighbours, it is a frequent complaint of the latter that the Mahomedan's fowls have flown into his courtyard or kitchen and defiled it. Fowls' eggs are also regarded as unclean, though, strangely enough, many Hindus will eat duck and goose eggs without scruple. The main food of the Bengali consists of rice, which is generally prepared by boiling. He cooks only once a day, dining about midday; and if he takes a second meal, it is eaten cold, and consists of the remains of his midday meal. The Bengali eats with his fingers, using the right hand only, and considering it improper to touch his food with the left. As rice is not a nutritious food it is necessary to eat it in large quantities in order to obtain the requisite amount of sustenance. The constant use of one kind of food cannot be wholesome, and Bengalis are in consequence often dyspeptic. In some parts of Bengal, where the evils arising from want of change of food are aggravated by the badness of the water, the pangs of indigestion occasionally become so great as to drive the sufferers to commit suicide. There were several instances of suicide from this cause in the district (Mymensing) to which I was first appointed, and in every case a *post mortem* examination showed a quantity of undigested rice in the stomach. Very few natives use tea or coffee except in illness, when they are very fond of a cup of tea, and in the case of fever consider it a good remedy. Corpulence is considered by Bengalis a sign of health, and of a man's being at ease in his possessions. They say that when

a man is poor he is fretful and envious of the prosperity of others, and that these feelings keep him lean, but that when he gets on in the world his mind becomes tranquil and he grows fat. Certainly, whether from this cause or from want of exercise, wealthy Hindus are generally fat, and they take care to keep themselves so by consuming large quantities of melted butter, sugar, and sweetmeats."

The above remarks were written with reference to Bengalis in general, but they apply very well to the districts in Eastern Bengal, in which my experience has been almost exclusively gained. I shall supplement them with some further observations.

It is often said that drinking has become prevalent among the upper classes in Bengal, but I believe there is a good deal of exaggeration on this point. A desire to imitate the English has led some wealthy and indolent Babus to take to champagne and brandy, and the harder work, and change of hours for meals, &c., occasioned by attendance at our courts or by Government service, have led some lawyers and public servants to habituate themselves to the use of stimulants; but as a general rule, the educated classes are too poor to drink to any great extent, even if they felt inclined to do so. Those who do drink to excess generally confine their orgies to Saturday night, and they have then the whole of Sunday in which to recover from their debauch.

The Bengali professional men residing in Barisál have, I am sorry to say, rather a bad reputation for drinking. Formerly they drank rum, but several rum-drinkers having died suddenly, the topers have now taken to country spirit, which they consider more wholesome. This spirit is manufactured in the Public Distillery at Barisál, and there is also a distillery in each of the sub-

divisions. It is made from *gúr*—*i.e.*, native sugar—and is, I believe, a tolerably pure spirit, and is generally sold very weak. I believe some natives of Bákarganj excuse themselves for drinking on the ground that the salt air requires the use of stimulants; and all natives remark that Englishmen thrive better at places on the coast —such as Diamond Harbour, Chittagong, &c.—than natives. It is not improbable that a vegetarian diet is less suitable for the sea-coast than a meat diet. Women, I believe, never drink, except the prostitute class, which is a very large one in towns.

The excise system of the English Government undoubtedly tends to familiarise Bengalis with the subject of drinking, and to throw temptation in their way. In this respect our Government contrasts unfavourably with that of the Moguls, who seem never to have derived profit from an excise on liquor. The central distillery system is, no doubt, an improvement in many respects on the old out-still system, but it certainly mixes Government up more with the trade; and as natives are apt to believe that it is the duty of Government to teach morality, they may be led to think that Government approves of drinking, and this may have a prejudicial effect on their ideas. There is one way in which the central distillery system works badly, which has not, I think, been sufficiently noticed; this is the corrupting influence it exercised on the Government servants employed in it. The inferior excise officers are of necessity natives, and they are, I believe, always Hindus, for Mahomedans will have nothing to do with the liquor traffic. They are not very well paid, and have no prospect of rising to any lucrative or important employment. They are also looked down upon by their countrymen on account of their occupation. The natu-

ral consequences follow, that the excise department is officered by men of inferior ability and standing, who are less capable of withstanding temptations which are of a peculiarly seductive kind. They have to deal with a rather low class of men—namely, the vintners and *ganja*-sellers—and they have much opportunity for fraud. They have also the temptation to drink offered by its being possible to get liquor at little or no cost, and I fear that to many this temptation is too strong to be resisted. My experience has shown me that there is more drinking among excise officers than in any other class of Government servants.[1]

Ganja is consumed in considerable quantities by boatmen and others, and not unfrequently leads to the commission of crime and to insanity. It is imported into the district from Rajshye. The stricter sects of Mahomedans, such as the Ferazis, use little or no ganja, and as far as my experience extends, it is the Dacca boatmen who are most prone to the vice.

Opium is used medicinally and also as a stimulant by the Hindus, especially after they have passed middle age. They think that it is a preservative against rheumatism, and also that it is nourishing. It is sold at the Treasury in two-pound cakes at a cost of about £1, 3s. per pound; it is also sold in similar quantities at the central distilleries. It is of course only dealers who buy opium in cakes. They retail it in *tólas* (rupee-weights), or still

[1] The revenue in 1873–74 from country spirits in Bákarganj was Rs.17,910, against Rs.17,228 in the previous year. This is more than in Mymensing, another district of the Dacca division with which Bákarganj has several points of resemblance. On the other hand, ganja yielded in Bákarganj only Rs.28,457, against Rs.97,846 in Mymensing; spirits, Rs.18,364, against Rs.37,658 in Mymensing. The entire net revenue from excise in Bákarganj in 1873–74 was Rs.62,249, against Rs.154,095 in Mymensing for the same period.

smaller quantities, charging of course somewhat more than the wholesale price. Hence it is easy to see that opium is consumed only by the comparatively wealthy. I have already spoken of the almost universal use of tobacco by the male portion of the population. It is mixed with gúr, and smoked in the water-pipe or hookah, familiarly known amongst Europeans as the hubble-bubble. There is not much chewing of tobacco, nor is snuff largely taken, though pleaders and others who cannot always find an opportunity of smoking, occasionally carry snuff-boxes. Hardly any tobacco is grown in the district, and the wants of the people are almost entirely supplied from Kuch Behar and Rangpúr. Nalchiti is the principal mart of the trade. Tobacco is not allowed in the jail, and no provision in the jail code is more difficult to enforce than this. The prisoners have endless devices for procuring the drug, and it is probable that even in the best regulated jails they are occasionally successful. Even in jails in which discipline is most lax, the prisoners cannot however get their smoke regularly, and this is no doubt felt as one of the greatest hardships they experience in jail; it might therefore be a useful means of rewarding good conduct to grant permission to smoke. I may mention that I once knew the case of a native who had given up smoking altogether, because he lost the habit during a six months' imprisonment. Besides pán and tobacco, another form of stimulant is obtained from highly-spiced curries. Boatmen and others who are much exposed to the weather are notorious for the use of large quantities of red pepper in their curries.

There is in Barisál a large number of professional prostitutes, and there are some also in every bazár. They are chiefly Hindus. The destitute condition of many

Hindu widows no doubt often drives them to prostitution as a means of living, and when a Hindu woman has thus fallen there is no way open for her return to her home. On the other hand, among Mahomedans it is by no means uncommon for a man of respectable position to marry a prostitute, or, as the phrase is, to take his wife out of the bazár. Such an action is regarded as laudable rather than otherwise, as it restores a woman to virtue, and it is said that such women not uncommonly make very good wives. It is a singular illustration of native feeling that one of the most common words used to denote a prostitute is *peshagar*, which literally means a professional person, as if a woman's profession or trade must necessarily be an immoral one.

Amusements.—The peasantry of Bákarganj have not many pastimes. As a rule, the Bengali is a sedate and somewhat melancholy personage, and even Bengali children seldom let their high spirits run away with them. The cares of a family, which so early fall on a Bengali, undoubtedly tend to steady and even sometimes to depress him, and his low diet and the relaxing nature of the climate keep him from boisterousness or horse-play. At the same time, he is easily pleased, and has a childish delight in fireworks, *tamashas*, or shows of every kind, and in kite-flying, which is practised with great assiduity at one period of the year. All, whether Hindus or Mahomedans, take more or less part in the durga puja processions, and in the *navanna*, or harvest-home. The durga puja, indeed, is quite the Bengali Christmas. Every one who can afford to do so, and even very many who have to borrow money for the purpose, go to their homes at this time and entertain their friends. There is very little drinking or other

dissipation, but there is a vast amount of talking and eating and smoking, and very late hours are kept. A Bengali's power of sitting up at night on such occasions is wonderful, and he will listen with invincible patience to hours of monotonous singing. *Játras*, theatrical performances, *nátches*, are common at this season. Bengali women especially look forward to the coming of the durga puja, for the annual supply of clothes is bought at this time, and it is a pleasant sight to go into the villages and see men, women, and children in their new attire.

Boat-races take place at the durga puja and at the Bengali new year, and even the native Christians cannot resist the pleasure of joining in them. Curiously enough, horse or rather pony races are a favourite pastime in Bákarganj, especially among the Mahomedans of the south of the district. The ponies are ridden by boys across the wide open space left after the rice crops have been cut. I do not think that there is any betting on such occasions. Marriages take place chiefly in the cold season, and, except among the Ferazies, are celebrated with considerable pomp, firing of guns, beating of drums, &c.

At one time a gambling mania took possession of the people of Barisál, and this ancient and, so to speak, classic vice of Hindustan is still a good deal practised in the villages.

Professional men and Government servants generally make a holiday of the English Sunday, but the peasantry of course do not observe it. Neither, I think, do the Mahomedans particularly observe Friday, except perhaps that they say their prayers oftener and more publicly on that day. For Mahomedans, the great holiday is the Maharam, though the Sunies among

them do not much regard it. The Maharam is a movable feast; a circumstance which often causes a good deal of inconvenience. The durga puja is also a movable feast, and sometimes comes too early in the season to be enjoyable, at least by Europeans. The Mahomedans are strict enough in observing the fast of the Ramzán, and as it too is movable, their sufferings are often very great; for example, it is no light thing for a Mahomedan boatman to work, as he often will, from sunrise to sunset in an exhausting July day without eating or drinking, or even smoking. On the other hand, the fast is over as soon as the sun sets, and before it has risen again the Mahomedan has made two and sometimes three meals—that is, he eats a little as soon as the sun goes down, makes an ample dinner at about midnight, and gets up again at three or four in the morning and has his food and his darling smoke before the labours of the day begin.

It is not without pleasure that one sees how human nature asserts itself during the Ramzán, and proves too strong for the curbing influence of superstition. The fast was undoubtedly intended as a means of mortifying the flesh, but many turn it into an occasion for feasting, and it is notorious that all the best dinners are given at this season. It is at this time too that the sweetmeat-sellers make their greatest profits, and as soon as the sun has set the Mahomedans make haste to gorge themselves with all the delicacies they can procure.

Riots.—Bákarganj used to be famous for its riots. The *lathials*, or clubmen, however, who fought in them were in many cases inhabitants of other districts, especially of Faridpúr, which was formerly as much noted

for its lathials as Bikrampúr was and is for its clerks and *maharirs*. In many cases the riots were fomented by the zamindars and taluqdars, but many were also got up by the villagers themselves. This last circumstance has often prevented magistrates from nipping breaches of the peace in the bud, and thus helped to give Bákarganj its bad name. Before zamindars fight with one another, there are lawsuits and simmerings of various kinds before the actual outbreak, so that the authorities have time to be warned and to take preventive measures; but villagers break out into quarrels suddenly and unexpectedly. It is to the credit of the ryots that they are so independent and so prepared to assert their rights without seeking the aid of the zamindars, but the circumstance certainly damages the criminal returns.

It may be added that the definition of a riot in the penal code is so general that many comparatively trifling offences can be brought under it. Bengalis are gregarious in their mode of action; and their custom of two or three brothers, with their families, living in one homestead increases the number of persons interested in any quarrel. It takes only five persons to make a riot, and this number of men can be furnished from nearly every house in which two or three brothers live. The greatest and most notorious dispute in the district is that which culminated in the Singhkháli case, and as its history throws a considerable light on the genesis and development of riots, and on the state of Bákarganj some twenty years ago, I subjoin an account of it taken from official records.

Extract from the remarks of Mr Steer, Judge of Bákarganj, on the trial of Gogan Mia and others, 14th September 1854, and 5th January 1855 :—

"The chief person who figures in this case is Gourhunoodin, commonly and extensively known as Gogan Mia. He is charged with being concerned in eight distinct cases, chiefly of plunder, riot, and arson. The rest of the prisoners appear in distinct calendars, some in some and some in others. It will be advisable to give a brief history of past events which led to these crimes.

"Pargana Syedpúr belongs in portions of ten anas and six anas to Lalla Mitrajit Singh and Babu Birja Rattan. The pargana has, as is usual in this district, several valuable dependent taluqs in it. The desire of each of the two sharers seems to have been to get exclusive possession of as many of these valuable properties as they could each manage. Summary suits were brought unknown to and against the taluqdars, and all the tenures purchased in for a song. In some cases the old proprietors fought the purchasers, in others the purchase by one of the zamindars led to disputes with his co-sharer, and thus things continued to go on. At length the ten-ana proprietor seems to have resolved on taking vigorous measures to put down opposition, come from what quarter it might. For this purpose he secured the goodwill of two brothers, indubitably the most notorious turbulent characters to be found in this notoriously lawless district. These brothers were Gogan Mir and Mohan Mir (since not inaptly named the Gog and Magog of these parts). The means employed to gain them over to the ten-ana interest was a lease on easy terms of certain desirable properties; but this compact was destined to be of short duration, from the bad faith of the ten-ana proprietor, who, after receiving a great part of the purchase-money of one of the taluqs transferred to the Mias, refused to complete the sale by

the acceptance of the remainder of the purchase-money and the delivery of the deed of sale. The alliance before existing was thus cut asunder, and these parties became Mitrajit Singh's worst enemies. Innumerable were the *foujdari* (criminal) cases which these parties brought against each other; but the long purse of the Babu soon exhausted the small means of the Mias in this expensive and profitless warfare, and then the Mias changed their tactics. Leaving the Babu to the courts, the Mias gave him real cause to resort to them. They plundered the zamindar's cutchery, they robbed and oppressed all who professed to be favourable to him; and this course of life proved so tempting, from the plunder obtained, that the Mias were able, without any money of their own, to collect and keep together a force which Mitrajit's hired bands were not strong enough to cope with. Seeing that the Mias were such a match for his old opponent, Birja Rattan, the six-ana proprietor, moved by past wrongs, and hopeful that the utter ruin of his adversary would secure him from the like in future, joined hands with the Mias, who thereby felt so strong that they defied not only Mitrajit but the police. A fortified house was built, from which the rabble of that part of the country issued to plunder the inhabitants. Not a day passed that a report of some adventure did not reach the station; and at length the police, who made several ineffectual attempts to apprehend the Mias, reported that they were powerless, and entreated the Magistrate to take the field in person. And indeed it was time he should do so, for the district was in a state bordering on insurrection. The Magistrate, however, did not go in person, but he ordered three *darogahs* and the entire police of three thanas, with all their chaukidars, to attack the Mias' stronghold, and to cap-

ture them. The attempt made to do so hardly merits to be called an attempt. The cowardly police, so strong in numbers, hardly dared show their faces within sight of the Mias' stockade, and all fled on the first show of resistance. On the report of this discomfiture reaching the Magistrate, he determined to proceed in person to the spot. He did so, and found the fort deserted by its old defenders. Everything about the place gave evidence of the great concourse of men who had lately been assembled there. Weapons of various sorts, and gunpowder, and materials for making it, with remnants of plundered property, were found in plenty in and about the premises.

"The Magistrate having left the place, Gogan and Mohan of course soon returned, and the proprietors having in the meantime been induced to compromise their differences, the Mias no longer confined their depredations against the adherents of the ten-ana shares, but robbed and plundered every one without discrimination. A new species of toll, or rather black-mail, then first began to be heard of. This toll was called *luca* or torch salami; and if money commensurate with the demand was not paid by the owner, the torch was applied, and his house burnt down before his eyes. At length a high reward led to the capture of Gogan, one of the two Mias, and he has been made over in eight distinct cases, some of which occurred prior to the Magistrate's appearance before his house, and some subsequently to that event."

On this case coming before the judges of the Nizamat Adâlat, they severely remarked that the sobriquets of Gog and Magog, given to the two prisoners in the Sessions Judge's letter of reference, were quite out of place, and evinced a levity which was too indiscreet to be passed over without some notice. Mr Alexander,

the Magistrate, was resisted in an attempt to capture Mohan and to destroy his fortification. His letter of 19th December 1854 thus describes the circumstances: "We had to walk, I should say, upwards of two miles before we reached a khál at the end of a long avenue that leads direct to Mohan Mia's house. Having crossed the khál without meeting with any resistance or even seeing any opponent, we marched on towards the house through an avenue some five hundred yards long and not more than twelve or thirteen feet broad, lined on both sides with tall cocoa-nut and other trees, thick jungle, and a deep ditch. As up to this time I had not seen the darogah return, I imagined he had hitherto met with no opposition, and must have arrived at Mohan Mia's house. My astonishment, therefore, was great when, without any previous intimation of an attack, from sixty to eighty *sulfiwallahs*, or spearmen, each armed with a spear of about twelve feet in length, and defended by a shield, gun-shot and sulfi-proof, capable of covering the whole body in a stooping posture, according to their mode of attack, came rushing down the avenue to oppose our farther progress. They were evidently well-trained and determined men, for they came down without flinching, even when they saw us three Europeans in front of our party with guns in our hands. Four abreast they advanced in an orderly and compact body. As soon as we saw them we called out to them to retreat and disperse, but not to attack us. Instead of retreating they came on the faster, each man advancing in a stooping posture, with the whole of his body covered by the shield in the left hand, and brandishing the spear in the right hand. We again urged them to retreat, but they were bent on an attack. Being most desirous of avoiding bloodshed,

I desired our party to retreat gradually, with our faces towards the enemy and our guns levelled. In this manner we retreated about ten paces, when the assailants approached still nearer. A third warning proved equally ineffectual; they persisted in coming on, and there was not the least doubt that they intended to kill us. They approached to within ten yards of us, and in another second their spears would have been into us, when, seeing no hope of keeping them off by any other means, we each of us fired our double-barrelled guns, which was loaded with shot, at the sulfiwallah directly in front of us. About six of them rolled over on the ground, but as they were mostly only hit about the left leg, they managed to get up and limp off. Those in the rear, however, were not checked by this discharge, but rushed on as before. We were therefore compelled to make use of our second guns, which were loaded with ball. In this second volley some five men must have been killed. Upon this the whole body of spearmen retired in confusion, but stopped and took up their stand at Mohan Mia's house, some thirty or forty yards in front of us, where there was a reserve force of spearmen and gunmen. Thinking at first they had fled for good, we followed them up for about twenty yards, within which distance I myself saw three men lying dead. I ordered their bodies to be carried off by my police, but the confusion was such that my order was not executed."

Mr Alexander was on this occasion accompanied by two of the Messrs Morrell from Morrellganj, and the tradition is that Mohan Mia's people did not know that the Magistrate was present, and mistook him and his companions for Sibpúr Feringhies, whom they thought the zamindars had hired to attack them. Mr Alexander

retreated without securing any prisoners, and he mentions that some one in Mohan Mia's house had the audacity to fire a gun after them. Mohan Mia shortly afterwards surrendered himself to the authorities, and as he and his brother were each sentenced to fourteen years' imprisonment, the combination of rioters came to an end.

The visit to the house referred to in Mr Steer's judgment, was, I believe, one made by Mr Harrison, and took place before Mr Alexander's visit. Mr Harrison's letter contains an interesting description of the way in which the house was fortified. It is dated, I think, 28th February 1854.

Fairs.—There are several fairs held in the district, but none of them is of great importance. I do not think that any of them is attended by the inhabitants of other districts, and there is certainly none of them which can at all compare in importance with the Kartik Barani fair in the neighbouring district of Dacca. Nearly all the fairs are held in the cold weather, and the result of this sensible arrangement is that there is very little sickness at any of them. The Perozpúr fair, which is held on the occasion of the Dol Jatra (March), is the only one which takes place far on in the season. By far the oldest of all the fairs is that called the Kalisuri Mela. It is held at Kalisuri, a small village on the borders of the Baufal thana (Patuyakháli subdivision), in the month of Agrahan (December). It is said to have been established some two hundred years ago by a Mahomedan saint named Syed Al Arfan, and his tomb is still shown at Kalisuri. It lies at the foot of a very old banyan-tree, and is visited by great numbers of believers, some of whom sacrifice oxen on the spot.

I am told, however, that the number of worshippers has diminished of late years owing to the spread of Ferazi tenets.

The tradition is that Syed Al Arfan was a holy man who had the power of working miracles, and that one day, as he was floating down the river on his magical carpet, he saw a Hindu girl come down to the bank to wash rice. He asked her to cook some food for him, and when she said that she could not cook for a Mahomedan, he bade her look into the vessel in which she had been washing the rice. On her doing so, she saw that the rice was already cooked—a miracle which made her at once become a convert to the Syed's religion. She besought him to grant her a boon, and in reply he promised that the place where she was standing should become the site of a great annual gathering, and that it should be called after her name. As the girl's name was Kali, and she belonged to the Suri caste, the village and fair received the name of Kalisuri.

Kalisuri fair is by no means a gay or animated gathering. There is a grave air of business about it, and it is very useful to the country-people, as they buy their winter clothing, &c., at it; but as a spectacle it is nothing, and the impression produced on the casual visitor is one of very great dulness. The booths are chiefly occupied by Barisál shopkeepers, and the goods exposed are for the most part the same as those sold in any ordinary bazár. The only frivolities allowed are a merry-go-round, and perhaps an exhibition of a *banmanush* (ourang-outang) or a leopard. One most commendable feature in the management of this fair is that no prostitutes are allowed to practise their trade in it, nor do they visit it. In this respect Kalisuri offers

a most edifying contrast to the other fairs in the district, where prostitutes abound, and immorality assumes its grossest and most disgusting form. No doubt the semi-religious character of the Kalisuri fair keeps away the prostitutes. I do not think that any drinking goes on at Kalisuri, and there is not much at the other fairs, although a good deal of ganja is sold at them.

The other principal fairs are those of Kalaskátti, Jhalukátti, Banaripara, and Lakutia.

II. MAHOMEDANS.

I have already said that the majority of the inhabitants are Mahomedans. This preponderance of Mahomedans is a feature which is common to all the districts of Eastern Bengal, and which becomes most marked as we approach the seaboard. *A priori* we might have expected that the proportion of Mahomedans would have been largest in the neighbourhood of the Mahomedan seats of Government, but Mr Beverley has pointed out in his report on the census that the facts of the case are otherwise. "In Dacca, which for a long time contained the seat of Government, Mahomedans are very slightly in excess of Hindus. In Maldah, which contained the city of Gour, the Mahomedans form only 46 per cent. of the population. In Murshidábád they are scarcely 45 per cent. In Patna they only form 12 per cent. of the inhabitants of the district. On the other hand, in Bákarganj, Tipperah, Rangpúr, and Mymensing they constitute two-thirds of the population; and in Dinajpúr, Nadiya, Jessore, and Faridpúr more than half. This circumstance seems to point to the conclusion that the existence of Mahomedans in Bengal is not due so much to the introduction

of Moghal blood into the country as to the conversion of the former inhabitants, for whom a rigid system of caste discipline rendered Hinduism intolerable."

The causes of the preponderance of Mahomedans have been ably discussed by Mr Beverley, and he has pointed out that though the dislike of the Hindus to the sea may account for their being in a minority in some of the eastern districts, yet another explanation must be found for their numerical inferiority in such inland districts as Rajshye and Bograh. In Rajshye the Mahomedans are 77 per cent. of the population, and in Bograh they are proportionally more numerous than in any other district of Bengal, not even excepting Chittagong or Noakháli, and are upwards of 80 per cent. of the population.

Mr Beverley thinks that the preponderance of Mahomedans is chiefly due to conversion from the lower castes of Hindus, and that though in some cases persecution may have been employed, yet probably the low-caste Hindus were generally glad to change a religion of degradation for one which gave them independence and self-respect. In support of this view he refers to the fact that the Hindus who live in Bákarganj and other Mahomedan districts are chiefly of the lower castes, and observes with truth that these men are even now especially open to proselytising influences. It is among the Chandals of Faridpúr and Bákarganj that the Baptist missionaries have made nearly all their converts; and there are at this moment, I believe, more native Christians in Bákarganj than in any other district of Bengal, except Nadiya and the Twenty-four Parganas.[1] I may add also that the sup-

[1] It is probable also that many of the Christians in these two district have European blood in their veins.

position that the Hindus were forcibly converted to Mahomedanism appears to be negatived by the remarks already quoted about the paucity of Mahomedans in districts which contained the seats of Mahomedan Government, and more especially by the fact that the relative number of Mahomedans is less in Mahomedan cities than in Mahomedan districts. Thus in the Mahomedan cities of Murshidábád and Berhampúr we find that there are twice as many Hindus as Mahomedans; and in Dacca, which we habitually speak of as a Mahomedan town, and which appears to have been founded by the Mahomedans less than three hundred years ago, the Hindus slightly outnumber the Mahomedans (34,433 against 34,275 Mahomedans), although in the district as a whole there are more than a million of Mahomedans against less than 800,000 Hindus. Now, if persecution had been the agency employed in converting the Hindus, we should naturally expect that the result would have been greatest where the Mahomedan power and influence were most in the ascendant—namely, at the seats of Government.

One thing which we should not lose sight of in discussing this and other questions of a similar nature, is that our districts are for the most part artificial divisions of the country, and in many cases are of very recent origin. I am afraid that officials are apt to forget this, and that they endeavour to account for certain phenomena in a district as if it was an entity which had been separated off for as long a time as an English shire or parish. Bengal districts are subject to continual change, partly from diluviation and alluviation, but still more from the idiosyncrasies of their rulers. Thus within the last few years the proportion of Maho-

medans in Bákarganj was increased by the transfer of the intensely Mahomedan thana of Mulfatganj from Dacca to Bákarganj, and then it was again increased in 1873 by the transfer of the Mádaripúr subdivision to Faridpúr.[1] Similar changes have occurred in other districts, and perhaps the abnormal number of Mahomedans in Bograh, for instance, may be accounted for by some disturbing cause of this kind.[2]

But in addition to the agencies of conversion and of the Hindu dislike of the sea, there is another potent cause of the Mahomedanism of Bákarganj—namely, that many parts of it were not inhabited until the Hindu religion and polity had fallen into decay. Much of the district is of recent formation, and even the older parts of it were probably covered with jungle till a comparatively recent period. The northern part is the oldest, as being the farthest from the sea; and here we meet with some ancient names, such, for example, as that of Gournadi.[3] Chandradwip, however, which was the name formerly given to much of the district, implies that it was in or near the sea; and Selímábád, the name given to the western part of the district, seems to imply that the country was not redeemed from the jungle till the time of Prince Selim, the son of Akbar, who was afterwards Emperor Jehangir.

[1] Mulfatganj was included in the transfer to Faridpúr, but still the effect was to increase the proportion of Mahomedans in Bákarganj, for Kotwalipara is essentially a Hindu thana, and the proportion of Hindus is also very large in Mádaripúr.

[2] Speaking of Jessore, Mr Westland remarks, "The district is now of course far from conterminous with Rajah Pratápáditya's territories; but that is only because since 1786, the date of its establishment, it has been made to suffer changes of boundary so violent that only half of what then was Jessore is within the limits of the district as it now stands."

[3] Although the name still exists, Gournadi village has long since been carried away by the Arial Khan.

The recent origin of much of the district is shown by the fact that salt was manufactured some fifty or sixty years ago at places which are now far inland, and where the water is now sweet for the greater part of the year. Thus we find tafals or places for making salt at Sibpúr, Niamati, &c. The former nature of the country is also indicated by the word *kátti—i.e.*, cutting or clearing—which we find affixed to the names of so many villages. Thus we have Raikátti, or the clearing of the Raies; Jhalukátti, or the clearing of the fishermen; Sarupkátti, or the clearing of Sarup; Kánudasskátti, or the clearing of Kánu Dass, &c.

It is probable that when the stream of Hindu civilisation came in from the north, it spread itself chiefly over Western and Central Bengal, and only slightly sprinkled the eastern tracts, which thus became Mahomedan by right of civilisation and conquest: by civilisation, namely, by the driving out of the wild beasts and by clearing the jungle; and by conquest, in north-east Bengal from the aboriginal tribes of the Koches and the Assamese, and in the south-east from the Burmese and Portuguese.

It is true that Ralph Fitch describes Bákla as being a large Hindu city in 1586; and Sripúr, Chandecan, and probably also the lost city of Bengala, were in the possession of Hindu princes. But on the other hand, though the island of Sandwip was not conquered by the Moghals till 1666, it appears to have had a Mahomedan population a hundred years before this; for Cæsar Frederick describes the people as being Moors—*i.e.*, Mahomedans—in 1569. The Jesuit priests, also, who visited Bengal in 1599, state that nine out of the twelve bhuyas of Bengal were Mahomedans. However, even if we suppose that most of the inhabitants as well

as the Rajahs of Sripúr and Bákla were Hindus, and that also the Sundarbans had a much larger population formerly than they now have, it is clear that the original inhabitants eventually died out or left the country, which thereon relapsed into jungle, and was not cleared again till a comparatively recent period. Indeed, whatever was the condition of the Sundarbans some three hundred years ago, it seems certain that their present colonists have not been settled for more than fifty or sixty years. No doubt the great storm of 1584, in which we are told that 200,000 persons perished, did much to depopulate the country; and Grant, in a passage already quoted, ascribes the desolate condition of Bákla to this cause, and also to the subsequent ravages of the Mugs. Probably this last cause was more potent even than the inundation. The tradition is that it was the Mugs who compelled the Chandradwip Rajahs to forsake their ancient seat of Kachua, and we have already seen that Du Jarric describes the King of Arracan as having taken possession of Bákla in the beginning of the seventeenth century. Rennel's map also represents a large tract in the south of Bákarganj as depopulated by the Mugs.

It was only when a strong Mahomedan power was established at Dacca, and a fleet raised for the express purpose of combating the Mugs, that their inroads received a check. The Mugs were hardy and experienced sailors, and the Hindu princes were totally unable to contend with them. It is doubtful if they ever possessed any ships, and their notions about the impurity of boat-life, &c., were sufficient to deter them from the sea. Du Jarric says that the island of Sandwip belonged of right to Kedar Rai of Sripúr; but even if this were true, it is evident that he could not make good his right

to it without the aid of Carvalho and the Portuguese sailors, and neither he nor the Rajah of Bákla were able to resist Gonzales when the latter chose to carve out for himself an independent principality. I may note also that Kedar Rai's right to Sandwip could not have been of very long standing, for it was in the hands of a Mahomedan king when Cæsar Frederick visited it.

When the Mugs began to give trouble, the more respectable—*i.e.*, the more inert and unwarlike—Hindus appear to have left the country, and Mr Westland (p. 220) describes Khalia in the Narail subdivision of Jessore as having been established by men of the upper castes who had left their homes in the south on account of the incursions of the Burmese. Most of the Hindus who remained in Bákarganj probably became voluntary converts to Mahomedanism, and there is little doubt that the process was hastened by the fact that the mere circumstance of their living side by side with Mugs, Portuguese, and Mahomedans was sufficient to tarnish their caste in the eyes of Hindus of other districts, and so to deprive them of the social advantages of Hinduism. It is not improbable that some mixture of races took place, and local traditions seem to countenance the supposition. Thus the Dasses of Ramzanpúr char in the Arial Khan say that they lost their caste owing to a Mug having touched one of their women with the humane intention of saving her from drowning. He was passing along the river-bank while she was bathing, and she seeing a stranger dived under water in order to elude his gaze. The Mug thought she was drowning, and jumped in and brought her to land, the result being that she and all her tribe lost their status, and were no longer regarded as respectable Sudras.

We find also that to this day the Hindus of Western and Central Bengal look down on the inhabitants of Eastern Bengal, and call them Bangals. This word, though etymologically it only means an inhabitant of Banga—*i.e.*, Eastern Bengal—has acquired an opprobrious signification, and is used to mean a rough or bungling person. It thus resembles in its use the adjective "Hieland"—*i.e.*, Highland—which, in spite of fine theories about the civilisation and superiority of the Highlanders, is still used by the common people in the neighbourhood of Glasgow as a synonym for anything stupid or awkward.[1]

The existence of such sentiments would, of course, predispose the Hindus of Bákarganj to embrace Mahomedanism. Still I have no doubt that the excessive preponderance of Mahomedans in the southern part of Bákarganj is not so much due to conversion as to colonisation. In the Patuyakháli subdivision the Mahomedans are 80·8 of the whole population, and in the Gúlsakháli thana of it they are as much as 86·4 per cent., whereas in the Sadr or Barisál subdivision they are only 64·8 per cent. It is the pressure of population in other districts, and also the protection against robbers afforded by the British Government, which have led to the colonisation of Southern Bákarganj; and when the process began, the Mahomedans easily outstripped the Hindus in the race for taking possession of the new country.

[1] A curious illustration of the opprobrious use of the word "Bangal" was given a few years ago by a lathial, or clubman, when he was dying from the effects of a spear-wound inflicted in a Bákarganj riot. Professional lathials have certain rules among themselves, and do not take unfair advantage of one another, or inflict deadly wounds on each other if they can help it. But a clodhopper had disregarded this rule, and had, like Nicole in "Le Bourgeois Gentilhomme," given a thrust not authorised by science, and so the lathial died regretting that a *Bangal* had killed him.

Mahomedans are not nearly such "stay-at-homes" as Hindus. They have fewer local superstitions, and no local gods, while the principle of the family is less strong among them. The joint-family system is unknown to them, and the practice of polygamy is unfavourable to fixity of residence. There is also no doubt that Mahomedans are more enterprising than Hindus; and that their more generous diet fits them better to endure an unhealthy climate, and especially the salt air of the eastern districts. Hence we find that the chars and islands are almost exclusively peopled by Mahomedans. Where, as in Manpúra, there is a Hindu settlement, it is of people of inferior caste, who eat meat, and have otherwise broken with Hindu practices.

The Mahomedans of Bákarganj are nearly all Sunis, and do not particularly observe the Maharam. They are altogether stricter in their religious notions than the Shias of the Dacca district. They do not drink spirits, and indulge sparingly in ganja and opium, as is shown by the comparatively small excise revenue of the district. Very many are Ferazis—*i.e.*, observers of the law or Ferz—and are thus followers of Dudha Mia. Dudha Mia was born in thana Mulfatganj (now transferred to Faríd púr), and his sect is particularly strong in that neighbourhood. It originated with his father, Shariyat Oolah. The Ferazis have often been identified with the Wahabis, and there is undoubtedly a resemblance between their creeds. Both appear to aim at a sort of primitive Church movement, or return to the doctrines of Mahomed, and to attempt to abandon the superstitious practices which have gathered round the earlier creed by lapse of time and by contact with Hindus and other infidels. It does not appear, however, that the Ferazis

share the dangerous political views of the Wahabis, or that their revolutionary views extend beyond disputing their landlords' claims for rent. Hindu zamindars and alarmists generally are fond of representing the Ferazis as politically dangerous, but, I think, without sufficient reason. No doubt they are more vigorous and less tractable than ordinary Mahomedans, but this need not be a disadvantage in their character. They have no music at their marriages, they do not reverence saints, and they are distinguished somewhat from other Mahomedans by the arrangement of their *dhuti*, as they do not allow the end to fall down behind, but tuck it carefully up. They also, I believe, hold that it is not right to have mosques or places of public prayer in a country governed by infidels.

Many Mahomedans of Bákarganj call themselves followers of the late Karamat Ali of Juanpúr, but as far as I know, he had no distinctive theological tenets, being chiefly a preacher of morality.

The Mahomedans have adopted a number of Hindu customs from their neighbours. Thus they not only observe the *dusserah puja*, but keep the novanna, and are fond of talking of their caste.[1] There are several subdivisions among them. One class is called the *chákars*, or servants. They are the palki-bearers and punkah-pullers, and are in considerable number near Bari-

[1] Dr Taylor says in his "Topography of Dacca" that the boatmen worship a river-god named Budder. Budder or Badr is, I am told, a Mahomedan saint who is buried at Chittagong. The Bákarganj boatmen often chant the following Bengali verse :—

"Amra achhi pala pán,
Ulla hoilo nigahbán.
Gangar sire panch pír.
Budder, Budder."

The meaning being, "We are children, God is our guardian. There are five saints (sitting) on the head of the Ganges. Budder, Budder."

sál. They are somewhat looked down upon by other Mahomedans, who will not intermarry with them. The *nikáris*, or fishmongers, are another class by themselves. The largest class is that of the *bebajias*, or so-called gipsies. They live in boats or houses raised on piles, and subsist by selling fish-hooks, &c. They do not cultivate land, but keep ducks and poultry. Their largest settlements are at Amtolli and Bákarganj, but they are also to be met with at Jhalukátti, Kalaskátti, Sarikal, Dakhin Shahbázpúr, &c. They do not appear to be thieves.

Converts are occasionally made from Hinduism to Mahomedanism, but a love affair is commonly involved in the conversion. A Hindu widow perhaps, tired of her loneliness and poverty, adopts a neighbour's creed and espouses him; or a Hindu man falls in love with a Mahomedan woman, and changes his religion for her sake.

It has been said elsewhere that almost all the Mahomedans of Bákarganj belong to the lower classes. There are few families of distinction in the district. The great bulk of the Mahomedans are employed in the cultivation of the soil. Comparatively few are in the service of Government or belong to the professional classes. The pleaders, native physicians, traders, shopkeepers, barbers, carpenters, blacksmiths, potters, fishermen, and washermen are nearly all Hindus. The only quasi-literary occupation which Mahomedans much affect is that of the *mukhtar*, or attorney.

A striking feature in the character of the Mahomedan population is the frequency of cases of elopement amongst the women. The subject has attracted a good deal of attention, but, as might be expected, no legislative remedy has been adequate to cure the evil. It must

be admitted that the sexual morality of Bákarganj Mahomedans is low. Many of them are boatmen,[1] leading wandering and solitary lives. Like most sailors, they are an immoral class; and their wives, from being left to themselves so much, often fall into intrigues.

The Mahomedans of Bákarganj are, generally speaking, very ignorant, and have an aversion to Government schools. They are especially averse to the education of their daughters in schools, and rarely send them. On the other hand, it must be said that girls belonging to the upper classes are generally taught at home, and that a knowledge of reading and writing is more common among them than among Hindu girls of similar position.

The Bákarganj Mahomedans have been described by Mr Sutherland and others as peculiarly bad specimens of their class. I have had experience in Dacca and Noakháli, and did not find the Mahomedans of those districts superior to those of Bákarganj. If there is any difference perceptible between them, it may be due to the fact that the latter, being of more independent character, show their good and bad qualities with less restraint.

III. HINDUS.

There is not, in my opinion, much which is peculiar or interesting about the Bákarganj Hindus. Most of them belong to the Nama Sudra or Chandal caste, which is especially prevalent in the northern and western parts of the district which border on Faridpúr. They are a strong and hard-working class, and are sought

[1] According to the census, there were 27,662 boatmen (males only).

after as roadmakers and diggers of tanks. They are ignorant and rather stupid, and are in general peaceable enough, but occasionally form combinations to resist their landlords. They practise widow-marriage, or at least often live in adulterous intercourse with widows.

There are comparatively few Bráhmans in Bákarganj; they are most numerous in Idilpúr and Kotwalipara, and the latter is noted for the number of its pandits. There are great numbers of Kayasts,[1] and this is partly due, no doubt, to the fact that the Chandradwip Rajahs were of this caste. To the same cause is also due the circumstance that many of the Kayasts are of very good family. There are what are called Kulin Kayasts; and the Kayasts of Banaripara and Gabha, &c.—viz., the Thakurtas, the Ghoses, and the Guhas—rank high in Hindu society both in Bákarganj and other districts. There are large numbers of the Baidya or doctor caste; hence the number and celebrity of the *kabirajes*, or native doctors, in the district. No doubt the large number of Baidyas is in some measure due to the prominence in the last century of Rajah Raj Ballab Sein.[2]

The distinctions of caste have become a good deal obliterated, but there are two points on which they are still immovable—marriage, and eating and drinking. It is still impossible for a Bráhman to marry a woman of any other caste, or to eat with a member of a different caste. Even within the same caste there are distinctions in this matter, some families

[1] According to the census, there are 27,395 Kayasts.

[2] I find there was another Rajah Raj Ballab, who held the office of Ray Royan, and was the son of Dulabram. Sir Elijah Impey refers to him in a letter of 20th January 1776, and says that he had always understood the Company was much indebted to Dulabram.

refusing to associate with others, though all may belong nominally to the same caste. Hence arise frequent squabbles, which occasionally come into court, men having been known to bring actions against their neighbours because they would not come to dine with them. The ground of action in such a case was that by the refusal the neighbours implied that the hosts were not of a good caste, and thereby libelled them. It is usual to speak of caste as an unmixed evil, but it has its advantages. If it represses originality and invention by compelling a man to adopt his father's trade, even although his natural aptitudes may lie in another direction; yet, on the other hand, it fosters hereditary capabilities, and checks undue competition. It may also be said to supply the place of national pride or patriotism. Undoubtedly, too, it chimes in with the natural temper and disposition of the Bengalis, and indeed if it did not, it would not stand a day. The Bengali, like every Oriental, likes to do everything just as his father and grandfather did it before him, and does not like new-fangled ways.

The Brahma Samáj was established in Barisál some fifteen years ago.[1] It has a church, but does not flourish as it did formerly. Many educated Hindus hold the opinions professed by the Samáj, but do not avow them or contribute to its funds.

IV. BUDDHISTS.

The Buddhists of Bákarganj all belong to the Mug race, and reside in the Sundarbans. An account of them has been given in chapter v.

[1] Ashar 10, 1268, or 1783 Sak = 1861 A.D.

V. CHRISTIANS.

The number of Christians in Bákarganj is stated in the Census Report to be 4852. The number, however, must be considerably less now, as the Christians were most numerous in the northern part of the district, and especially in thanas Gournadi and Kotwalipara. Nearly the whole of Kotwalipara and much of Gournadi have now been transferred to Faridpúr, and several Christian villages have been transferred with them. It is probable, therefore, that the Christian population of Bákarganj is now under 3000 persons. The number, however, is still very large for a rural district in Bengal, and shows that missionaries have been exceptionally successful in Bákarganj. About 800 of the number are accounted for by the existence of the Portuguese colony at Sibpúr. These Christians belong to the Roman Catholic faith, and have been described at p. 110.

The remaining 2200 or so reside almost entirely in the north and north-west parts of the district, and were originally, almost without exception, Chandals, or low-caste Hindus. I believe that there has not been a single instance of the conversion of a Mahomedan inhabitant of Bákarganj, so that the Masalman religion is as great an obstacle to Christian missionaries now as Fernandez and Fonseca found it nearly 280 years ago. Some have ascribed the success of the missionaries in the north of Bákarganj to the previous existence of a deistical sect known by the name of the Kartá Bhojás, or worshippers of the Lord. I believe, however, that it was the oppressions of the landholders and their agents which gave the chief impetus to the movement, and that Christianity recommended itself to the Chandals by its socialistic and

insurrectionary doctrines, and by the fact that the Padre Saheb or missionary presented himself in some measure as a bulwark between them and their masters. It is at least certain that the landholders showed at one time great hostility to the movement; and as one of the most active among them was himself a Christian, it is not likely that religious bigotry had much to do with their conduct. This hostility reached its culminating-point in the abduction and subsequent confinement of some native Christian families about twenty years ago. This led to a trial, known as the Báropakhya case, which excited a large amount of attention in the district and in Calcutta, and also, I believe, in England. It was, I believe, true in the main, and I regret to say that the accused were acquitted by the appellate court.

The first preaching of Christianity in the district took place about 1830, in the time of Mr Garrett, who was Magistrate, and afterwards Judge, and who became a Baptist and was publicly dipped in a tank at Barisál. His Nazir or Sheriff, Mr Parry, was an active preacher for some time, and was afterwards a missionary in Jessore. He was succeeded, I believe, by a Mr Smith; and after Mr Smith came a Mr Sylvester Bareiro, who, I understand, originally came from Chittagong, and was schoolmaster in Barisál for some time. Mr Bareiro was greatly befriended by Mr Sturt (the Collector, who was afterwards degraded on account of defalcations in the treasury), and was made by him Superintendent of Stamps. He was a Baptist missionary for many years, but was at last removed on a charge of immorality. He then joined the Church of England, and set up an opposition mission, which still exists, and has a considerable number of adherents. It has been acknowledged and subsidised by the Bishop of Calcutta, although,

according to the Baptists, most of Mr Bareiro's adherents are persons who have deserted from or been turned out of their Church. Mr Page was a Baptist missionary who long resided in Bákarganj and made many converts. The late Mr Sale also resided in the district for many years, and was greatly esteemed by every one who knew him.

The principal mission stations of the Baptists are at Ashkar and Dhánshar in the Gournadi thana. Mr Bareiro's church is at Dhándhoba. There are not many cases of conversion nowadays, and I do not think that the missions can be regarded as being in a flourishing state. The impulse which once led many to become Christians has died away, and the missionaries scarcely attempt to do more than keep together the converts they have already made. They have been unable to do even this, for many have relapsed into Hinduism. These men are known by the name of *pherti* or turn-aways, and I have met several in the bíls. One of them told me that he had abandoned Christianity because the ten commandments were too hard for him. I believe, however, that in most cases persons have apostatised in order to get back into society, and especially in order to have their daughters married. According to law, native Christian girls cannot marry until they are thirteen years of age, and as this is later than the ordinary age for marriage among the Hindus, parents complain much of the restriction.

There are very few Christians near Barisál, and none at all in the southern thanas. The movement, in fact, has been from first to last exceedingly local in its character, and has been confined to the swamps of Farídpúr and north-east Bákarganj.

I do not think that the native Christians are at all

superior to Hindus and Mahomedans of a similar class, but native gentlemen have told me that they are more truthful.[1] They are generally very ignorant, and have still a hankering after Hindu customs and amusements, such as boat-racing, &c. They are cultivators and fishermen, and in the cold weather they migrate to various parts of the district and work at road-making and the digging of tanks.

Since writing this account of the Christians, I have found in the India Office Library a volume of the "Calcutta Christian Observer" for 1856, which contains a full account of the Báropakhya case. It is in the form of a review of a pamphlet by Mr Underhill, who was Secretary to the Baptist body, and who afterwards took a leading part in the denunciation of Governor Eyre. The precise date of the outrage was 1st July 1855 (C. C. O., vol. xxv. p. 397, 1856).

The same volume contains (p. 408 *et seq.*) a very interesting account of the sects of the Kartá Bhojás and of the Satya Gurus, apparently from the pen of Dr Wenger, and as it incidentally describes the origin of Christianity in Bákarganj, I have taken the liberty of making the following extract:—

"The next sect is that of the Kartá Bhojás or 'worshippers of the Lord.' Many of its members were originally Mahomedans. All of them profess to repudiate idolatry and caste; but their moral principles are not so pure as was at first supposed. It was among adherents of this sect that the movement in Krishna-

[1] The Hon. F. B. Kemp was the judge who heard the appeal in the Báropakhya case. On being censured for releasing the accused he wrote a defence of his conduct, in which he gave some damaging particulars about the morals of the native Christians.

ghur in favour of Christianity originally commenced; and Krishna Pál, the first convert of the Baptist Mission, is believed to have belonged to this or a similar sect before he began to listen to the gospel. An opinion has repeatedly been expressed to the effect that the Kartá Bhojá sect owes its origin mainly to the diffusion of certain fragments of Christian truth. It would be difficult to produce any historical evidence in support of this idea, whilst on the other hand there is much in it that is probable. Is it not possible that some Christian ceremonies (such as might be noticed by any humble native observer) may have been blended with some elements of Mahomedanism and some Sháktya rites by the founder or founders of the sect?

"The following account of its origin is from the pen of an anonymous native correspondent of the 'Upadeshak,' and appears in that periodical in the number for November 1847. The writer says that it is based upon information derived from frequent personal intercourse with Kartá Bhojás and others. 'In the village of Ulá, on the western bank of the Ganges (Bhagirathi or Hooghly?), there lived a man named Mahadeb, a cultivator of pán (usually called the betel-leaf plant). He was childless; but one day on going into his plantation of pán, he found a weeping infant, and looking upon it as a gift of God, determined to adopt the child for his own, a resolution to which his wife gladly assented. The boy grew up, but being somewhat silly, the neighbours called him Oula. For some years he assisted his father in cultivating and selling pán; but after a time he ran away, dressed only in the tattered garment of a devotee. He reappeared on the eastern bank of the river, gave himself out to be a *mahápurush* (or "great man" who has completely subdued the senses), or at

least a *guru* (spiritual teacher), and succeeded in gathering a company of twenty-two disciples.' (The names are all recorded, but need not be repeated here.) 'The *mantra* which he gave them was, "Satya bala, guru dhara, sange chala;" *i.e.*, "Speak the truth, cleave to the teacher, and come along with us." After this, he took them with him to the marshy district, near the Sunderbuns, where he set up as a worker of miracles, and succeeded in deluding many people.

"'After his death, some of his twenty-two disciples, imitating his example, began business on their own account. They would train some man to pretend deafness, until any sick person came to be healed, when, on receiving a blow, he was suddenly to speak. They would then strike the sick man also, and tell him, "You see this deaf man has been cured, but you have not yet sufficient faith, therefore you cannot be cured now. Eat some earth from under this tree, come every year to the master's house, and believe, then you will undoubtedly recover." In this way they have succeeded in deluding thousands.'

"At the close of this historical account the customary prayer of the Kartá Bhojás is given. As it is very interesting, and infinitely better than the preceding narrative would lead one to expect, we subjoin it here. After a brief invocation of 'the true one of Shiva and Rámballabh,' it goes on as follows: 'It is unreasonable to suppose that by studying any *shástra* a true knowledge of Thee can be obtained, for in the different shástras different religions are taught. Among this diversity of religions how can certainty be obtained? O Lord, we are ignorant and stupid; have mercy on us, and cause us to understand the truth, that we may be comforted. Further, great Lord, keep us from evil, and

grant us willingness, courage, and ability to do good. If such be Thy pleasure, let it be accomplished.'

"A similar sect, though small, and confined to Eastern Bengal, is that of the Satya Gurus. It originated about the year 1804 with a native who read the gospel narrative, and even had some personal intercourse with the Serampore missionaries, but who was animated with the spirit of Simon Magus. Giving himself out to be a modern incarnation of the true teacher, Jesus Christ, and able to work miracles, he succeeded in obtaining a number of followers, and when he died transmitted his dignity to one of his chief disciples, who still carries on the work of delusion. In this case the origin of the sect can be clearly traced back to the indirect influence of Christianity.

"In other parts of the country, men rise up every now and then, who, professing to have discovered the true way, or to have been instructed by the true teacher, succeed in drawing a number of disciples after them. It is impossible to tell how much or how little floating rumours regarding the gospel of Christ may have to do with the origin of these sects. They are generally characterised by a repudiation of idols, of the ministrations of Bráhmans, and of certain restrictions of caste, and thereby in some measure pave the way for the reception of the gospel. The origin of the native Christian community in the Backergunje district supplies an illustration of this remark. Kángáli, the leader of the first band who openly embraced Christianity there, had for several years been such a *mahant* or spiritual guide of numerous disciples, who professed to obey the Satya Guru or true teacher. But he was evidently not satisfied with his own discoveries. The account which he himself gave afterwards of the way in which he was

first led to Christianity, certainly shows a morbid state of the nervous system—probably the result of certain habits frequently found among Hindu ascetics—but it is nevertheless instructive. According to the impression left on his own mind, he once, whilst laid up with a dangerous illness, was favoured with a vision or visit from a resplendent person, who told him that he should recover if he called on the name of 'Eesoo.' Accordingly he did pray to the unknown being whose name was thus communicated to him, and recovered. Not only so, but the same result followed from such prayer in the case of a few other persons. Some time afterwards he met with a man who was returning from a market with a book in his hand. On inquiring after the contents of the book, he was told that it was only a book about 'Eesoo Christ,' and that he was welcome to it if he wished to have it. The coincidence of the name led him eagerly to accept the proferred tract, with the contents of which he made himself acquainted—as far as he could comprehend them—by means of one of his disciples who was able to read. The perusal of this tract proved to be the first dawn of Christian truth breaking in upon his dark mind. He succeeded from time to time in obtaining some fresh tracts, and at last felt a strong desire to seek out some one who could tell him more about the religion of Eesoo. In all these endeavours a number of his disciples sympathised with him. Their first impulse was to apply to the nearest European Government officials for instruction, but their courage failed them, and at length they were accidentally—or rather providentially—heard of and afterwards met with by itinerant native preachers from Barisál. Even after this long preparatory process nearly two years elapsed before they could make up their

minds to embrace Christianity openly. Such is the statement made by Kángáli nearly ten years ago. Since then many of those who were first have become last, and the last first."[1]

VI. OTHERS.

There are a few Koches in the Perozpúr subdivision. They appear to have come from the Madhupúr jungle in Dacca, and are said to have been brought in by the zamindars to act as fighting men. Their weapons used to be bows and arrows.

Near Barisál there is a small colony of Bunas. They support themselves by agriculture, and by selling firewood. According to one account, they were brought in by the indigo-planters in old times; and according to another, they came when the new police system was introduced.

There are a few men from Hill Tipperah, in the jungles of Idilpúr (217, according to census).

At Barisál there are a few Greek and Armenian and other Eurasian families, and there is a Jewish shopkeeper. The Portuguese or Feringhies of Sibpúr have been described elsewhere.

VII. RESULTS OF THE CENSUS.

Unfortunately, the figures given in the Census Report cannot be fully made use of, because the area of the district and the arrangement of the thanas have been altered since 1872. The enumerators' books are now at

[1] "Bengal as a Field of Missions," by Mr Macleod Wylie, Calcutta, 1854, contains at p. 100 an interesting description of Bákarganj and the mission, written by Mr Page. Mr Page there states that Mr J. Smith was the first missionary, and that Mr Bareiro was sent four years afterwards from Serampore to succeed him in the management of the school. Mr Page joined the district in 1848. The movement seems to have begun in Ramsiddhi, which was Kángáli's village.

Barisál, and they are, I believe, being collated and their details brought into accordance with the new boundaries. When this has been done we shall know many interesting particulars regarding the relative numbers of the various Hindu castes, the occupations of the people, &c. Meanwhile I proceed to note a few general facts.

The most striking results of the Bengal census may be said to be three in number. The first is the discovery of the great populousness of Bengal as compared with former estimates.[1] The second is the discovery of the large extent of the Mahomedan element.[2] The third is the discovery of the almost total absence of large towns. Perhaps to these we might add a fourth—namely, the discovery of the quietness and ease with which a census can be taken.

With regard to the third of these results, I have pointed out in the chapter on Barisál that even the few towns which exist have a very sparse population, and are made up more or less of scattered villages.[3] The average number of persons per square mile in Bákarganj was 482, and I do not think that this has been

[1] The total population of Bengal in 1872 was 66,856,859, and average per square mile 269, or more than double the average rate (110 per square mile) for Scotland (Census Report). In Bengal Proper the average is 389 per square mile.

[2] "Total number of Mahomedans, 20,664,775." The vast majority of these—namely, 17½ millions—are found in Lower Bengal; in Behar they hardly number more than 2½ out of a total population of nearly 20 millions. In Assam, Chota Nagpúr, and particularly in Orissa, they are very sparse. In Assam, indeed, they are perhaps more numerous than might have been expected, owing chiefly to the inclusion in that province of the district of Goalpara, which formerly formed part of Rangpúr. Rangamati, in this district, was for some years a frontier station of the Moghals, and large numbers of the Koches and other aboriginal tribes seem to have been converted by them to Islám (Census Report).

[3] It appears from Thucydides that the population in ancient Greece was at one time scattered over villages as it now is in Bengal, and that Lacedæmon adhered to this custom after the Greeks in other parts had gathered themselves into cities: *κατὰ κώμας δέ τῷ παλαιῷ τῆς Ἑλλαδος τρόπῳ οἰκισθείσα.*

materially lessened by the transfer of Mádaripúr. The density of the population is greatest in the northern and central thanas, and least in the south of the district. The most thinly-peopled thana is Khalsakháli, which contains a large extent of Sundarban forest. In it the average per square mile is only 122. In the Patuyakháli subdivision (to which Khalsakháli belongs) the average is 287, in Perozpúr it is 581, and in the Sadr subdivision (Barisál) it is as high as 738. The lowest subdivisional average is in Dakhin Shahbázpúr, where it is 270. This at first excites surprise, for the greater part of the island is richly cultivated, and seems in the northern and central divisions to be one continuous garden of cocoa-nut and supari trees, and studded with homesteads. The explanation, however, is simple enough. Much of the south of the island is composed of newly-formed chars and of extensive plains where buffaloes are grazed, and which are almost uninhabited. If we could have a separate census of the northern half, I am persuaded that the population would be found to be as dense as that of almost any other part of the district. Here I should note that when the census was taken, Dakhin Shahbázpúr was divided into two thanas—viz., Daulat Khan and Dhaniya Maniya —and that their boundaries ran from north to south, the east side of the island belonging to Daulat Khan and the west to Dhaniya Maniya. Hence each had about an equal share of the cultivated and uncultivated tracts, and therefore we find that their populations were very nearly equal, Daulat Khan having a population of 114,262,[1] and Dhaniya Maniya one of 106,775,

[1] Even this slight excess may be accounted for by the fact that it includes the population of the town of Daulat Khan and that of the island of Manpúra.

the total population of the subdivision being 221,037. The island, however, has since been divided from east to west, Daulat Khan thana containing the northern and Barhanuddin Hát the southern half; and if the areas are made nearly equal, there can be no doubt that Daulat Khan will have much the largest share of the population.

Throughout the district the males are slightly in excess, the ratio being 50·7 to 49·3. In thanas Gournadi, Kewari, and Jhalukátti the women are in excess, but in all the other thanas which now belong to Bákarganj they are in a minority, except in thana Nalchiti, where the proportions of the sexes are equal. The disproportion of males is greatest in Patuyakháli subdivision, where the ratio is 52·6 to 47·4. In thana Khalsakháli, already mentioned, there are 56·2 men to 43·8 women. I think that these facts are very interesting, for they concur with what we should expect from considering the nature of the country and of native society, and therefore they tend to show that the census was correctly taken. The proportion of Mahomedans is largest in Dakhin Shahbázpúr, where there are 82·8 Mahomedans to 17·2 Hindus. In Patuyakháli subdivision the proportion is 80·8 to 18·2 Hindus. The remaining 1 per cent. consists of the Mugs, who are Buddhists. The most Mahomedan thanas in the district are Dhaniya Maniya and Gúlsakháli, where there are 86·4 Mahomedans to 13·6 Hindus. We thus see that the Mahomedans are most numerous in the south of the district and in the islands. The Hindus are most numerous in the north and west of the district. They are especially numerous in the west, where there is a large settlement of low-caste Hindus. This Hindu element extends into Farídpúr, and apparently there

is something in the nature of the country, which consists for the most part of immense swamps, which has been peculiarly suitable for a Hindu population. Perhaps the large quantity of fish yielded by the swamps has attracted them, for this is the chief animal food of Hindus, and to this day most fishermen are Hindus. I am inclined, however, to think that no one would voluntarily occupy such a country. In the rains the country is almost one immense lake, in which the homesteads of the ryots appear as islands, and in April and May it consists of large treeless plains. The villages are never of very easy access; but things are at their worst at the beginning and at the end of the rains, for then there is neither enough water for boats nor sufficient dry land for foot-travelling. Add to this that the country swarms with mosquitoes, that there are numerous poisonous snakes, and that the ryots often lose their crops from overflooding, and it will be admitted, I think, that the country is not a desirable residence. It seems, therefore, probable that these low-caste Hindus, or Chandals, as they are called, were driven out from some other country, or that they left their homes in order to be free from oppression. The following account is given by Mr Wells, formerly Magistrate of Farídpúr, in a letter published in the Census Report: "The dreary and unwholesome swamps of the south are largely peopled by a highly interesting Chandal race. These Chandals were originally a complete Hindu community, consisting of persons of all castes from the Bráhman downwards, who, on having the misfortune to be cursed in a body by a vengeful Bráhman of unutterable sanctity in Dacca, quitted their ancestral homes and emigrated bodily to the southern wastes of Farídpúr, Jessore, and Bákarganj. There with great

perseverance and toil they raised in the centre of the swamps large hillocks from twelve to twenty feet in height, whereon they built their homesteads in the dry weather, in order to preserve their cattle and goods during the high inundations. In this place they are located to the present day, cultivating the swamps with rice and jute, and carrying on the occupations of fishing and bird-catching, varied with mat and basket weaving, and the cutting of grass for thatching roofs and for the consumption of their cattle. In the dry weather they often suffer considerably from scarcity of water, and at times almost die from thirst. As they do not preserve water in tanks, they are often reduced to what little they may have kept by them in their earthen vessels, and not unfrequently drink it when it has become quite thick and green. In the rains the whole country becomes inundated; the water rises over ten feet, and leaves their artificial mounds like so many islands in a huge lake. Locomotion then becomes impossible except by boat, while they have to collect all their cattle and keep them in their homesteads, feeding them on what fodder they may have stored up during the dry season, and on a grass which, like the rice, grows with the rise of the water, and in appearance very much resembles paddy. These cattle have often to remain for weeks standing up to their necks in water, and as their food has to be stored up for them in the homesteads, they are fed on the minimum amount necessary to support existence. Consequently by the end of the rainy season they are reduced to skeletons, and very many die in the process. It is this that renders it impossible to introduce a larger and less hardy description of cattle. Notwithstanding all the

difficulties this Chandal community have to contend against, however, they are strongly attached to the home of their adoption, and resist all inducements to abandon it. Efforts, for example, have been made to transfer some of them to the Sunderbuns, but with no measure of success. They prefer remaining in the region to which they have adapted themselves perseveringly and laboriously, where they are not likely to be envied their lot, and where they can dwell together a distinct community with their own Bráhmans, their own priests, castes, and traditions. Their occupations and their enforced practice of going about in boats during a great portion of the year have rendered the Chandals a hardy and muscular race, while they present a favourable contrast to their uncursed and therefore contemptuous neighbours in respect of ingenuousness and truthfulness."

The Hindu nature of the population of this part of the country is shown by the figures for Kotwalipara, a thana which has been nearly all transferred to Faridpúr. In it there were 59,582 Hindus against 23,122 Mahomedans. Kewari (now Sarupkátti) is the only thana in Bákarganj where the Hindus are in excess of the Mahomedans. In Jhalukátti they are nearly half the population.

In Patuyakháli subdivision the largest proportion of Hindus is found in thana Baufal, which was the site of the old capital of the Rajahs of Chandradwip.

There were in 1872 only twenty-seven Europeans in Bákarganj, and there were 127 Eurasians. There are other statements in the Census Report showing the numbers of the aboriginal tribes, and of the various castes, &c., but I do not think that the figures are cor-

rect, and therefore shall not make use of them. For example, I do not understand the entry of 2785 Nats. Nor do I think it likely that there were only 8989[1] Bráhmans in Bákarganj and 30,338 in Chittagong. The classification according to occupations is admittedly imperfect. The number of persons (males) engaged in agriculture or with animals is put down at 498,690, and 475,477 of them are said to be cultivators.

Vital Statistics.—Attempts have been made for some time to record the deaths all over the district, but the machinery employed (the village chaukidars) is altogether inefficient, and the results are totally untrustworthy. Although no official has ever pretended that the returns were even approximately correct, yet some have thought that the system should be kept up, as it could do no harm, and might prepare the way for a more perfect registration. This, however, seems an error. It cannot be said that the collection and tabulating of worthless statistics do no harm. Granted that nobody is deceived by them, still their collection involves some expense, were it only in postage, and a good deal of trouble, and it tends to demoralise every one who has to do with the work. Worst of all, however, it brings statistics into contempt, and will induce people to disbelieve our figures long after they have become trustworthy. Even now natives, as a general rule, do not believe in the results of the census, less, I think, because they know of inaccuracies in it, than because a long

[1] Especially when we find the number of priests or *purohits* in Bákarganj put down at 9450.

series of untrustworthy returns has made them regard figured statements of all kinds with suspicion. It is to be hoped, therefore, that Government will abandon the attempt to collect vital statistics for whole districts, more especially as the last Bengal Administration Report states that Sir George Campbell had come to the conclusion that the attempt was "hopeless at present" (p. 199 of Report for 1873–74).

The returns for the selected areas are more trustworthy, though even they are not yet quite satisfactory. There are four such areas in Bákarganj—namely, two town areas (Barisál and Daulat Khan) and two rural areas (Manpúra and Lakutia). The united population of the first two is given at 14,224, and the deaths in 1873 at 327, or 22·98 per 1000. The population of Barisál has however been increased since 1st January 1874 by the inclusion of additional area. The population of Manpúra and Lakutia is given at 13,652, and the deaths at 291 in 1873, or 21·31 per 1000.

Note.—The statistics of population given at p. 211 were prepared for me in the Collectorate, but the details leave 1133 unaccounted for, whereas the column "Others," in the Census Report, only gives 174. The fact is, I am sorry to say, that owing to changes of boundaries made since the completion of the census I am not able to state with accuracy the population of the district. The population of Bákarganj, according to Mr Beverley's Census Report, is 2,377,433, which are divided as follows :—

Mahomedans, ...	1,540,965
Hindus, ...	827,393
Christians, ...	4,852
Buddhists, ...	4,049
Others, ...	174
	2,377,433

Since then Mádaripúr subdivision has been transferred to Faridpúr. Its

population, according to the census, is 663,043, which are divided as follows :—

Mahomedans, ...	360,085
Hindus, ...	299,540
Christians, ...	3,375
Others, ...	43
Total, . . .	663,043

But this total cannot be deducted, as parts of thanas Gournadi and Kotwalipara in the said subdivision were not included in the transfer. Moreover, a corner of Faridpúr, lying east of the Baleshwar and near the mouth of the Saldaha, was shortly afterwards included in Bákarganj. The population of this tract was, I think, about 10,000. The figures in the text professed to take account of these changes, but the above remarks show that they are still not quite accurate.

CHAPTER IX.

PRODUCTIONS.

Rice is the staple of the district of Bákarganj, and the variety of it which is most cultivated is that called *aman*. Aman rice is grown all over Bákarganj, wherever there is low land. In the Perozpúr and Patuyakháli subdivisions very little of any other kind is grown. The ploughing of the ground commences as early as the latter part of February in the northern parts of the district, and continues in the south as late as the beginning of September. These late ploughings, however, are of land into which the rice is to be transplanted. The chief ploughings take place in April and May. They begin earlier in the northern parts of the district, as it is the first to be flooded, owing to the lowness of much of the Gournadi thana, and its proximity to the Arial Khan. Cattle are generally used for ploughing, but in Dakhin Shahbázpúr and the south of the district buffaloes are often employed. Aman is generally transplanted, but in chars and other places it is sometimes sown broadcast. It is not unfrequent, especially in the northern parts of the district, to sow aman and owsh—*i.e.*, early rice—together. It is not usual to weed aman, and the crop gives little trouble to the ryot after it has been transplanted. The process of transplanting, however, is a very laborious one, and the ryot often "homeward plods his weary way" after his back has been almost

broken from stooping for hours amidst mud and water, and after having been drenched with rain two or three times in the course of the day.

Irrigation is not regularly practised, and is seldom needed; but water-channels are frequently dammed across in order to keep the water in the paddy-fields. Also the water is often drained off when it is too plentiful, and to effect this the ryots do not scruple to dig trenches even across public highways. The putting up and the removal of the dams, or *bunds*, as they are called, are frequent sources of dispute among the villagers.

Rice is often damaged by insects, and loss from this cause appears to be especially common in Dakhin Shahbázpúr. Cloudy weather just before harvest is especially likely to breed insects, and is therefore regarded with great alarm by the ryots. Rice-fields near rivers are often injured by crabs and river-turtle, and brushwood and branches of the date palm are put round the fields at the water's edge to keep those animals out. In a report of 8th August 1791 special mention is made of the damage caused to the cultivated lands of pargana Buzurgumedpúr by an immense quantity of crabs being thrown upon them. Wild pigs do great mischief to standing rice, and unfortunately this is one evil against which the ryot is very helpless. He does not usually possess a gun, and the professional *palwáns* or *shikaries* (sportsmen) whom he sometimes employs find it difficult to carry on their handicraft, owing to the interference of the police and the stringent orders about licences for carrying arms. It is a common practice all over the district for the ryots to erect sheds, raised on a scaffolding of bamboos, in their fields about the time of harvest, and to spend their nights in them, in order to scare

away the pigs. These sheds are called *túngis*, and are a very marked feature in the Bákarganj landscape, especially where there is any jungle in the neighbourhood. The ryots also make gigantic rattles by splitting a bamboo and attaching a rope to one of the limbs at the top of the cleft. In Dakhin Shahbázpúr these rattles may be heard at night and at the early dawn going off with a noise like the discharge of firearms. The noise is made by the ryots in the túngis pulling the ropes and then letting them go again. Buffaloes, wild and tame, often damage the crops, and cattle-trespass is a perennial source of dispute among neighbours. As there are no hedges or walls, and as no land is reserved as pasturage for the cattle, it can easily be understood how frequent cattle-trespass must be. Broad kháls and dōnes are not sufficient protection, for the cattle all take to the water readily, and can swim great distances.

Aman is generally reckoned as yielding twelve anas, or three-fourths of all the rice grown in the district. The other fourth is chiefly made up by owsh, which is grown on the high lands, and especially in the northern parts of the district. There is also a little *boro* grown in the chars and bíls in the north of the district. Gournadi and Kotwalipara (now transferred to Faridpúr) are the chief seats of this cultivation. Boro is sown at the end of the rains, when the waters are beginning to recede. It is sometimes sown broadcast, but is, I believe, as a general rule, transplanted like aman. The sowings take place in October, the transplanting in December and January, and the harvest in April. Boro is a coarse red grain, and is only eaten by the poorer classes. It is prized by them because it ripens earlier in the year (the Bengali year) than any other kind of

paddy, and thus gives them food at a time when rice is scarce. Owsh is sown in Chait and Baisackh (March and April), and is reaped in July and August.

The bulk of the aman harvest takes place in Agráhan and Paus—*i.e.*, December and January—but there is some which ripens as early as Ashin, and hence it is called Ashini paddy. It is common to name rice according to the month it ripens in, and thus we have Ashini, Kartik, and Agráhani *dhan*, the last being by far the largest in quantity. In Dakhin Shahbázpúr and some other parts a kind of aman is largely grown which is called Lakhydigi, and ripens in October. It is said to derive its name from its being ready by the time of the Lakhy puja. On the occasion of the aman harvest there is a great festival called the Navanna or the new rice. It celebrates the first eating of the new crop. It is a movable feast, but commonly takes place in the month of Agráhan. The festival is primarily a Hindu one, but Mahomedans celebrate it also. It answers to the harvest-home or vintage feasts of other countries, and is a time when the scattered members of families and distant friends meet together. It is not peculiar to Bákarganj.

The average produce of rice per bigha (about two-thirds of an acre) is ten *mans* of paddy, representing about six mans of rice. In the southern parts of Bákarganj the ryot does not always, or even generally, cut his own rice. Bands of reapers come down from Faridpúr and other northern districts, cut the paddy and thresh it out for him. They are liberally paid, for they receive one-sixth, and more commonly one-fifth of the produce; formerly they received one-fourth. In the north of the district paddy is often threshed out by beating it against a plank, but in the south this

is usually done by cattle. The cattle which tread out the corn are almost always unmuzzled, which shows that the practice of allowing the cattle to pull at the straws occasionally as they go round is general in the East, and that a divine precept was not necessary for its observance. The ryots also tread the rice out with their feet sometimes. When paddy is cut in the south of the district, the heads only of the grain are generally cut. The straw is left on the ground and cut at a later period. This is done because the load to be carried to the threshing-floor is hereby lightened, and because the straw would be damaged if trodden by the feet of the cattle. The Faridpúr reapers come down in Agráhan, or December, and return in Magh, or February. Early in December fleets of small boats may be seen sailing down with the north wind to the southern parts of Bákarganj ; and two or three months after, they return loaded with paddy. Rice is sold by the ryots by measure, though in the bazár it is commonly sold by weight. When sold in the husk—*i.e.*, as paddy—the measure most commonly used in the south of the district is the *búdha*. This consists of four *káthis*, or baskets of thirty-two *sírs* each. This is *kachá* weight, and is equal to twenty-four sírs of *paká* weight. The káthi is a basket made of bent—*i.e.*, cane. In the north of the district rice is generally sold by the *katha*, or basket of twenty sírs. It thus appears that though rice be generally sold by measure, yet the measure is one founded upon weight. There is a weight in much use in the district called the Sahebganj or Bákarganj weight. It is larger than even the paká ordinary weight, as it contains ninety-six *tolas* to the sír.

Paddy is sold by the ryots chiefly to *paikárs* or middlemen, who come to their houses or to the local

markets for it. The paikárs are of two sorts—large and small. The former, who are also called *aratdárs* or brokers, have their offices at the principal bazárs, and ship the rice from thence to Calcutta. The smaller paikárs are called *farias*, and their business *fariámi*. They go about to the villages and to the petty háts to buy paddy and rice, which they take to marts such as Bákarganj, Niamati, and Nalchiti. Thus these marts are not fed directly from the threshing-floors; all the little háts in the country are feeders to them, and the marts are chiefly entrepôts where the rice brought into the village markets is collected and eventually shipped off to Calcutta.

A good deal of paddy is disposed of by barter, and goes off in this way to supply the wants of less grain-producing districts. Thus in the cold weather boats come from Dacca laden with earthen pots. These the boatmen sell to the villagers for paddy, filling up their boat with it as their trade progresses; and eventually after a cruise of a month or two, they return to their homes with a cargo of paddy. The reason why this trade in pots is so brisk is that the Bákarganj earth is in general saltish and not suitable for pottery, and therefore the inhabitants have to depend on other districts for their supply of pots for household purposes, and for the making of molasses, &c. The price of a pot is generally its contents in paddy. The husking of rice is generally done by women, and is probably the most laborious task they have to perform. Women in Bákarganj do very little out-of-door work, for the bulk of the population is Mahomedan, and that too of a rather strait and fanatical sort. Except widows, and others who have no man to help them, no women, or at least no Mahomedan women, are ever seen marketing or

working in the fields. I have scarcely ever seen women employed as reapers, and no doubt this is one reason why the Bákarganj ryot is obliged to have so much of his crop reaped for him. It is too much for him and his sons to reap and thresh out by themselves, and they will not allow their womankind to help them.

Rice Trade.—The rice export trade begins in November and continues till March. The principal marts are Bákarganj or Sahebganj, Nalchiti, Jhalukátti, and Niamati. They present a most animated appearance during the rice season, for boats come to them from all parts of Bengal. There is a great demand for silver during the rice season, and the local treasury is soon cleared by the presentation of currency notes and supply bills.

It is a curious fact that though Bákarganj is a great exporting district, it also imports paddy (during the rains) from the districts of Tipperah, Mymensing, and Sylhet. The chief seats of this import trade are Jhalukátti, Babuganj, and Mirganj. It is owsh paddy which is thus imported, and it has a sale because it comes in at a time when aman is nearly out of the market. The Bákarganj rice is of superior quality, and is therefore exported to such an extent that a sufficient stock of rice does not remain in the country for local consumption, and owsh comes in from the eastern districts to supply the deficiency. The communication, too, between Bákarganj and Calcutta is so exceptionally easy, owing to the number and largeness of the rivers, that rice readily flows out of the district, whereas Tipperah and other eastern districts are in some measure shut out from the Calcutta market by their remoteness and defective water communication.

The price of rice is of course much higher now than it was in former times. On 9th February 1797 the Collector writes to the Board that paddy used to sell at 3 mans the rupee, but that in that year it was selling in the Idilpúr pargana at 8 mans the rupee. Paddy is generally reckoned nowadays as worth Rs.1 per man. On 30th January 1875 rice was selling at Barisál at the rate of 17 sírs the rupee for best rice, and 21 sírs the rupee for common rice. A man of paddy, or 40 sírs, yields about 30 sírs of rice.

Betel-nut.—Next to rice, betel-nut is the most important staple of Bákarganj. It is grown extensively in Dakhin Shahbázpúr, and the northern and eastern parts of the district. Indeed nearly every homestead in Bákarganj has its few supari or betel-nut trees growing round it, and many a Bráhman or Kayast who is unwilling or unable to support himself by manual or mental labour gets his living by the produce of his betel-nut orchard. Betel-nuts are gathered in October, and the trade continues for a considerable part of the cold weather. The chief seats of the trade are Daulat Khan, Lálganj in Mendiganj, and Nalchiti. The Mugs and Burmese, and even a few Chinamen, come to Nalchiti in the cold weather to purchase betel-nuts for Arracan. There is a quarter of Nalchiti called Mugpara or Mug hamlet, because it is chiefly occupied by Mugs engaged in the betel-nut trade, and in the cold weather there is always a number of balam —*i.e.*, Mug—boats moored along the bank there. The betel-nuts are sometimes conveyed direct from Nalchiti to Chittagong and Arracan in balam boats, but more frequently, I believe, they are transported to Calcutta and shipped thence by steamer.

Betel-nuts are counted by tens or *gás*. One hundred gás—*i.e.*, a thousand nuts—sell for from three to four rupees. A betel-nut tree yields about a hundred nuts a year, and is reckoned as annually worth four anas. The annual value of a cocoa-nut tree is reckoned at one rupee. The wood of the betel-nut tree is used for planking, and it is also used for bridges, for handrails, and for posts. The gathering of betel-nuts is often a trade, and boys and men of light weight make a livelihood in this way. Many are so expert that they will gather the fruit of a grove of trees without ever descending. This they do by swaying the tree on which they are, and passing from it to the next one. The usual payment for gathering the nuts is ten nuts a tree, and for cocoa-nuts one nut a tree. If, however, the trees are exceptionally high, the payment has to be increased. The fruit of two hundred betel or of a hundred cocoa nut trees can be gathered in one day. Betel-nuts are prepared in three ways. 1st, The *Mugari supari*, so called because it is intended for the Burmese market. This is husked, steeped in water, washed, and dried. 2d, *Tátta suparis*. These are dried in the husk. 3d, *Maga suparis*. These are steeped in the husk. The freight for a cargo of suparis (betel-nuts) from Lálganj or Nalchiti to Calcutta is usually Rs.20 the hundred mans.

Cocoa-nuts.—A large quantity of cocoa-nuts are produced in the island of Dakhin Shahbázpúr, and most homesteads have two or three trees. The nuts are largely consumed within the district, but a considerable quantity is exported, and there is a local manufacture of cocoa-nut oil. In the cold weather sloops come over to Dakhin Shahbázpúr from Chittagong

laden with earth-oil, and take away cocoa-nuts in exchange.

Sugar-cane.—Next to betel-nut, sugar-cane is, I think, the most important staple of Bákarganj. It is grown all over the district where there is high land. Hence, as the banks of rivers are generally high, we find that sugar-cane is largely cultivated on them. The cultivation of the sugar-cane is laborious and expensive. The ground requires to be prepared with great care; the plants have to be bought in the market, and it is many months before the outlay can be reimbursed. The landholders, too, generally claim an exceptionally high rate of rent for land cultivated in sugar-cane. The mill for expressing the juice and the labour for working it are also expensive. Hence it is very common for sugar-cane to be grown on the co-operative principle, several ryots joining in the speculation. Bákarganj sugar has a high reputation in Bengal, and Jabar Amal sugar is considered the best in the district. Jabar Amal, which is the chief seat of the sugar trade, is a market and village on the Kacha, in the Perozpúr subdivision. The raw fruit of the date-tree is eaten and the juice of the tree (*tari*) is drunk; it is also used as a sweetmeat when inspissated into the form of a cake, but it is not much used for making sugar.

Timber.—Next to rice, betel-nut, and sugar-cane, the most important products of the district are probably timber and firewood. These are chiefly obtained from the Sundarban tracts in the south. The sundari is the most valuable tree, as it is universally used for making boats. Even sálwood boats have the parts which are under water made of sundari, as it appears to be the

only wood which resists the saltness of the water. The sundari, however, is by no means the most common tree in the Sundarbans. The kerua is the prevailing tree, at least on the chars and in the south-eastern part of the district, and the goma and bolye are also common. The kerua and goma are used for posts, &c., and the bolye is especially valuable for its inner bark, which yields a strong fibre. The bolye fibre is used by the ryots instead of string when making the roofs of their houses, &c., and it is also twisted in tethering ropes for cattle and buffaloes. The ashes of the bolye contain salt and potash, and are used by washermen in place of soap.

There are a large number of woodcutters in Bákarganj, though they generally combine agriculture with their trade. They are called *baüliés*, and their boats *baüli*-boats. These are strong open boats, and the sundari logs are both packed into them and lashed alongside. Unfortunately, the sundari is so heavy that it will not float. It is unnecessary to describe the woodcutter's trade, as it has been fully done by Mr Westland. The chief seats of the timber trade are Jhalukátti *alias* Maharajganj, Gúlsakháli, Amtolli, and Nalchiti.

Bent or cane is brought from the Sundarbans, and is much used for making baskets, &c. The *gólpatta* or wild cocoa-nut is an important plant, as the Mugs and the ryots generally in the south of the district thatch their houses with it. It is also said to yield excellent toddy.

The bíls and chars yield large quantities of reeds (*nal*, *hogla*, &c.), which are much used for mat-making, for the roofs of boats, &c., and are also largely exported to the surrounding districts.

A superior kind of mat, called the *sítalpati*, is made

from the outer covering of a reed called the *parita*. This reed has a branching and somewhat shrubby habit, and grows in damp places near homesteads. It does not appear to be really wild, at all events it is regularly cultivated by the ryots just as *san* or thatching grass is. The chief workers in sítalpati live at Rangasri and Helancha near Bákarganj, and it is there that the parita is most common. The workmen are called *paitiyas*.[1]

PÁN.—Pán is a good deal cultivated in the Gournadi and Baufal thanas, and in the Perozpúr subdivision. The Dacca market is to some extent supplied from Gournadi. Tarki, in that thana, is the chief mart. As it is necessary that the pán should arrive fresh at Dacca, pán-boatmen were long celebrated, and I believe are so still, for their dexterity as oarsmen. They are, I believe, all Hindus. Pán-gardens are only kept by Hindus—a curious instance of conservatism, for Mahomedans are just as fond of pán as Hindus. But we find the same thing in other trades, for most washermen, carpenters, and barbers are Hindus. The pán-gardens belong to the Baroi caste.

There is no indigo grown in the district. Some fifty years ago it was cultivated, and the remains of vats may still be seen at Panchakaran and Khagasura. These belonged to a Mr Nathaniel Monro, who was, I believe, originally employed in the Salt Department. It is said that the brackishness of the water prevented the success of the manufacture.

Scarcely any tobacco is grown in Bákarganj, and the requirements of the district are supplied from Rangpúr and Kuch Behar.

[1] A list of the principal Sundarban trees will be found in Gastrell's report.

(*Til sesamum*) is largely cultivated, and the amount of production appears to be increasing. It is grown for the sake of the seeds, from which an oil is expressed, which is used in cooking and also as a light. It is often mixed with mustard oil. It is grown in the northern parts of the district, and also in thana Mendiganj. It is not much grown in the south, as it appears to require high land, free from inundation.

Now that Mádaripúr has been transferred to Farídpúr, comparatively little jute is grown in the district. Some, however, is grown in Gournadi, Mendiganj, and Dakhin Shahbázpúr. The amount of cotton grown is inconsiderable, and is all consumed within the district. Thana Mendiganj and Dakhin Shahbázpúr are the principal localities for its cultivation.

Cold-weather Crops.—The cold-weather crops, the *dhulat—i.e.*, dry or sandy earth crops, as they are called —are not so important in Bákarganj as they are in the higher and drier districts of Western Bengal. Nevertheless, turmeric, melons, cucumbers, &c., are grown, especially on the high lands and chars. Linseed is grown to some extent in Dakhin Shahbázpúr. San, for making hemp, is grown on the chars in the Arial Khan, &c. It is stronger than jute, and is used for making nets.

Fruits, &c.—Abundance of plantains, tamarinds, ják fruit, &c., are produced, but the plantains are generally of rather inferior quality. The same must be said of the mangoes, of which a great quantity are produced in thana Gournadi. A few limes and oranges are grown in Mendiganj. The *manjit* or Indian madder (*Rubia cordifolia*) is cultivated in Oozirpúr and Shikarpúr in

the Gournadi thana, and the produce is exported to Calcutta. It is said to be a very profitable crop, and is locally known by the name of *malancha*.

Gáb-tree. — The gáb-tree (*Diospyros embryopteris glutinifera*) is very important, as the fruit of it yields a juice which is used for caulking boats. It is a handsome tree, with dark green leaves, and a compact dome-shaped habit. It does not, I believe, grow wild in the Sundarbans, but is commonly seen on the banks of rivers and in homesteads, both deserted and occupied. The fruit is sold by the score or by the basket. Sometimes there is a scarcity, and then the price of the fruit is eight anas, or even a rupee per basket; generally the price is from two to four anas a basket. Gáb is applied to boats four times a year, except in the case of Balam boats, on which it is not used at all. The caulking of a *kós* boat with gáb costs from two to three rupees a year. About 1000 gáb fruits are required for the caulking of an ordinary-sized boat. Fishing-nets are steeped in gáb juice, and this gives them their black colour and also preserves them. The fruit, which is round, and when ripe, brown, is pounded in a mortar or *dhenki*, then water is added, and the mixture is heated over a fire. It is then put into a jar, closed so as to exclude the air and also the mosquitoes, which are fond of eating it. If it is to be applied to boats, the ashes of the gólpatti or of any jungle are mixed with it. It is customary to apply fire to the outside of boats before the gáb juice is put on, in order to kill the worms.

Mineral Products.—The only mineral product is salt; but the Government rules about salt, and the

scarcity of fuel, do not admit of its manufacture. It is obtained from the sea, and can also be extracted from the earth. The soil of new formations in the district is impregnated with salt, and in some of the chars—for example, in parts of Dakhin Shahbázpúr—the salt efflorescence is sufficient to make the surface of the soil quite white, as if covered with hoarfrost. It has often been supposed that the illicit manufacture of salt is common in the district, and this has led to a stringent system of salt-passes, &c. It is, however, impossible that the manufacture can take place on a large scale, for, apart from all other difficulties, the want of a sufficient quantity of fuel must prevent this. It is on the chars that the soil is most favourable for salt-making, but these are now highly cultivated in most parts, and there is comparatively little jungle. For example, there is so little jungle now in the large island of Dakhin Shahbázpúr that there are no tigers in it, and hardly any leopards. In the days of the salt manufacture it was the jungle on the chars which supplied the fuel, and it was the necessity, imposed by the manufacture, of keeping so much land in jungle which retarded the cultivation of the chars for so many years. No doubt salt is illicitly manufactured for domestic consumption, but such proceedings are on so small a scale as almost to defy detection. A handful of earth from the chars will yield enough salt for a meal. The ashes of the branches of the cocoa-nut, of the plaintain, of the bamboo, &c., yield salt, and it is often said that widows and other poor people who live far inland get their salt from the cocoa-nut trees in their homesteads.

It appears strange that a country naturally so rich in salt as Bákarganj should have to depend on Europe for the supply of this necessary; and it is to be hoped

that some day it will be found possible to manufacture it locally, or at least nearer home.

Fish.—Bákarganj has always been famous for the number and excellence of its fish, and fish is the chief form in which the bulk of the population obtain animal food. Fish is exported to Calcutta from the Kotwalipara bíls (now mostly transferred to Faridpúr), and this trade is the chief support of many of the inhabitants of those swamps. The fish are conveyed in wells at the bottom of the boats. They are small-sized fish, and belong chiefly to the species called the *koï* and the *singhi*. The *khalisa*, the *saül*, the *gázar*, the *fali*, the *magur*, and the *chang* are also caught in the bíls and exported to Calcutta. The Deputy-Magistrate of Mádaripúr once estimated the annual value of the export at between Rs.15,000 and Rs.16,000. Upwards of fifty species of fish are enumerated as being caught in the district and used for food. The best known are the *hilsa*, the *bhétki* or *koral*, the *ruï*, the *pangás*, the *boál*, the *kátal*, the *silon*, and the *mango* fish. This last is, however, only caught in the rains, and is smaller than, and in every respect inferior to, the mango fish of the Hughli. The hilsa has given its name to one of the largest rivers in the district (the Ilsa or Hilsa), between Dakhin Shahbázpúr and the mainland; and the pangás has a river named after it in the Gournadi thana. The hilsa is sometimes salted, but generally it is either eaten fresh, or dried in the sun without the use of any salt. The drying of fish is an extensive trade in parts of the south of the district, and boats come from Chittagong and Jessore every year and take away large quantities of *sútkis*, as they are called. In general, I believe, the

drying and the exporting are done by the same people—viz., the boats' crews.

There is a small delicate fish called the *bánspata*, or bamboo leaf, from its resemblance to that leaf. The *puti* and the young puti, called the *titputi*, and the *isa* fish, are largely caught in the paddy-fields and ditches. Fish-fry or *pona*, which are chiefly the young of the *saul* and gázar, are also largely caught by herd-boys and others. *Chingris* or prawns are caught in abundance during the cold weather. The koï-fish,[1] already alluded to, is especially prized by Hindus, and there are many who do not care for any fish except the koï and the bíl-fish allied to it. It is made into soup, and is thought to be very nourishing. The koï is sold by number, twenty koïs fetching from three to four anas. Fish, when sold on the large scale, are sold by the man, and the price in Dakhin Shahbázpúr is about Rs.5 per man. The *potka* deserves mention from the fact that it is a poisonous fish, and that several accidents have occurred from eating it. It is a thick and curiously-mottled fish, and is common in the bazárs, as it is prized by the poorer classes for its oily richness. It has sometimes been proposed to prohibit the sale of it, but such a measure would be of no avail, as it would not prevent people from catching it for their own use. The poison is contained, I believe, near the ventral fin, and this part should be cut out before the fish is cooked.

Fish Oil.—Many ryots make an oil for lighting their houses from decomposed fish, but the oil is not an article of trade.

Fish are caught by nets, by cages, and by hooks.

[1] This fish is able to propel itself a considerable distance across country.

According to the census, there are 17,607 fishermen (males only) in Bákarganj. Most of them are Hindus, and belong to the Jaliya or Kaibart castes. The fishmongers—*i.e.*, those who buy fish from the fishermen and retail it to the public—are generally Mahomedans, and belong to a class called Nikaris and also Sikdars. There are several families of them near Barisál. They are a class by themselves, and are looked down upon by other Mahomedans, who will not intermarry with them. There is no close season in Bákarganj, and no precautions are taken to preserve the fish in the rivers. It is customary to stock tanks with fish, and the right of fishing in them is jealously guarded. It is common to see bamboos stuck here and there in a tank with the object of preventing night-poaching, the stakes preventing the throwing of nets. During the rains trenches are cut between the tanks and rivers, so as to allow fresh water and fish to enter the tanks. Tanks are often let for the sake of the fishing, and yield a considerable sum. There are several valuable tanks in Kewari thana, and the Barisál municipality have lately derived a small revenue from the letting of the rod-fishing in the public tanks. Fishing is a very favourite amusement of the Bengalis, and is dignified by them with the name of *shikar*. There are only four fisheries belonging to Government, and none of them is of much value.

Notwithstanding the apparently great abundance of fish, natives are frequently heard to complain of their scarcity and dearness. This is especially the case in the south of the district, though from the number and largeness of the rivers there, one would have thought that fish would have been most plentiful. This complaint is partially explained by the circumstance that professional fishermen, like other Hindus, are somewhat scarce in the

south of the district. The best explanation, however, is that by far the largest proportion of the fish caught in the district is never brought to market, as it is taken by peasants and other amateur fishermen for their own consumption. Every ryot, young and old, is something of an angler, and his inexhaustible patience, and abundance of leisure at certain seasons, well fit him for the occupation.

CHAPTER X.

MANUFACTURES AND PRICES.

I. MANUFACTURES.

Bákarganj is not at all a manufacturing district. There are no mills or other large works, and the great bulk of the people are engaged in agriculture. In old times the district was a very important seat of the salt manufacture; many descendants of the salt molunghees still reside in it, and the names Baipari, Góldar, Jamadar, have become patronymics in many families, especially in Dakhin Shahbázpúr, from their having been at one time connected with the salt trade. The introduction of Liverpool salt, and the cultivation of the islands and chars, have put an end to this industry. A few Mahomedan families in the village of Bilgaon, near Palardi police station, make a little country paper, but it is very coarse, and the trade is dying out. *Chalas* or *ghani* bags are made by the Kapali caste in Patihar and other villages of the Gournadi thana, and these have a good sale among the sugarmakers, &c. Opposite Nalchiti, at a place called Kalupara, or Oilman's hamlet, a good deal of mustard oil is made, the seed being brought from the north of the district. The production of sugar at Jabar Amal, &c., has already been referred to. Sítalpati mats are made at Chirapara, Rangasri, and Helancha; and hogla mats are made in great quantities all over the district. Cocoa-nut oil is made at Daulat Khan, Nal-

chiti, &c. Lime is made from shells at Chawalakátti and other places in the bíls, for home consumption only. Uzirpúr and its neighbourhood have a local reputation for the making of *dáos* and other iron implements. Large jars for holding rice, &c., are made at Madupúr, near Nalchiti, and pots and dishes are made by potters at various places in the Kotwali thana, &c. Nets are made at Ghanteshwar. Perhaps one of the most skilled crafts in the district is boat-making. This is carried on at Debaikháli and Shampúr in the Mendiganj thana, where the best kós boats are made; at Ghanteshwar, near Agarpúr, where the best *pansways* are made; and at Barsakátti in the Perozpúr thana. At this last place very large cargo-boats are made. A few canoes are hollowed out of kerua wood by the Mugs in the Sundarbans, and *dinghis* of sundari wood are made all over the district, but especially at Jhalukátti. Kaliganj, Bákarganj, Phalagar, are also boat-building places. There are weavers in the district, both Hindus and Mahomedans, but their trade is not a profitable one. The census gives the large number of 14,146 weavers (males only). Brick-making is carried on to a considerable extent in the neighbourhood of Barisál.

The largest workshop in the district is the Barisál Jail, but it does not produce anything worthy of much notice. It may be remarked that dexterity with the fingers is much more characteristic of the Hindu than of the Mahomedan population, and that as Bákarganj is pre-eminently a Mahomedan district, much artistic skill is not to be looked for. I have no doubt that the superior dexterity of the Hindu is in great measure to be explained by the doctrine of hereditary aptitudes, as the system of caste makes generation after generation follow the same trade.

II. PRICES, ETC.

The subject of prices is one about which it is difficult to give precise information. It is sufficiently established that there has been a considerable rise of prices within the last eighty years, and probably this rise has been most marked during the last decade, but I cannot exhibit it step by step. All I shall attempt to do will be to give a few facts, which I have collected from the official records and other sources.

In 1790 the average earnings of a blacksmith were reckoned to be Rs.3 a month, and in 1796 the *manjhis* of the patrol-boats received Rs.4, and the rowers Rs.3 per month. (It must be remembered that the rupees were sicca.) This was, I fancy, better than the ordinary pay of boatmen, and was given probably on account of the danger of the service. In the statement of the *dák* establishment, 30th August 1809, the pay of the manjhis is reckoned at Rs.3, and that of the rowers and the hire of the boat at Rs.2-8 a month. In 1802 the wages of spearmen (employed in the escort of treasure, &c.) were Rs.2-8 a month. In old times the prisoners in the jail did their own marketing, and received a certain amount of cowries daily for this purpose. In 1805 the daily allowance to each prisoner was three puns of cowries, equal to about three-fourths of an ana. Their monthly expenditure per head was reckoned at about Rs.1-6, of which 15 anas went for the purchase of rice. Of course this did not include the charges for guarding, for lights, for medicine, or for blankets. There is a letter from Mr Collector Armstrong, dated 9th February 1797, in which he says that in the Idilpúr pargana paddy used to sell at three maunds for the rupee,

and was then considered cheap, but that at the time of his writing it was selling at the rate of eight maunds for the rupee. (The maund was of 82 sicca weight.) In 1807 bamboos sold at Rs.3 the 100, and in 1820 they sold at Rs.4 the 100. Lime was Rs.35 the 100 maunds, and iron was Rs.6 the maund.

On 19th March 1811 the Collector writes that "the price of rice has risen to a very unusual height; instead of one man for a rupee, it is now twenty-five sírs." On 27th March 1824 the price of salt is said to be Rs.4-8 per man when bought in quantities larger than a man, and Rs.5 a man for smaller quantities, so that the price was then about the same as now.

In a letter of 29th August 1799 it is reported that there was not a sicca rupee in Bákarganj. I presume there were Arcot and other rupees. The copper coinage was not introduced till 1814.

In 1861 paddy sold at one man and at 36 sírs for the rupee, and rice at 26 sírs for the rupee. Sugar-cane sold at 64 stems for the rupee, or about the same as now. Raw sugar sold at 10 sírs for the rupee, and milk at 12 sírs. In 1866 the price of rice rose on account of the Orissa famine, and was 15 sírs for the rupee in January, and even, it is said, as high as 8½ sírs in October. The average price for the year is given at 12 sírs for the rupee. On 30th January 1875 the price of good rice in the Barisál bazár was 17 sírs the rupee, and of inferior kinds 21 sírs for the rupee. At the same time salt was selling at 2 anas a sír, and firewood at 100 sírs a rupee.

Freights to Calcutta vary from Rs.20 to Rs.30 the 100 mans. Often goods are shipped on co-operative principle, the *mahajan* or shipper and the boatmen dividing the profit. When this is done, the mahajan

generally gets 8 anas or one-half of the profit, and the other half is divided among the manjhi and his boatmen, he getting 10 anas and the boatmen 6 anas. When boatmen receive wages, they are also fed by the manjhi. It is very difficult to make any statement regarding the rates of rent paid by cultivators. A fact is always a difficult thing to lay hold of—it is so slippery, and has so many sides to it; but this is especially difficult when the question is one of prices, or of cognate matters, as so many theories and prejudices and interests are intertwined with it. However, I may state that the general rate of rent for rice-land seems to be about a rupee a bigha. Homestead-land and sugar-cane-land, or any land cultivated in a particular crop, generally lets at a much higher rate of rent.

PART III.

CHAPTER XI.

ENGLISH ADMINISTRATION.

THERE is no doubt that Bákarganj early attracted the attention of the English on account of its facilities for trade. It has always been productive of rice, and in the old days of the salt monopoly it was perhaps even more important in the eyes of the Government on account of the salt manufactured in it. Selímábád was long a chief seat of this manufacture, and I have elsewhere noticed Mr Barwell's (the Chief of Dacca) dealings with the salt-farm of this pargana and of Dakhin Shahbázpúr. There was also some exportation of lime from the district before the Sylhet lime quarries were worked, or at least before their produce was readily available for the Calcutta market. The lime was shell-lime, and was made by burning the shells found in the bíls and swamps. The rivers of the district were also then, as now, the highway of communication between Calcutta and Dacca and the other eastern districts. More than a hundred years ago the bazár of Bákarganj was spoken of as being a place of great trade; and as the letter in which this is mentioned gives an interesting, though rather painful, representation of the state of matters in the district in those days, I shall here give it in its entirety.

The letter was written by one Sergeant Brego from Bákarganj, on 25th May 1762, and was addressed to the Governor (Mr Vansittart). It is printed at p. 111 of vol. ii. of Vansittart's "Narrative" (London, 1766).

"The situation of affairs at this place obliges me to apply to your Honour for instructions for my further proceedings.

"My instructions which I brought here were, that in case any Europeans or their servants committed any disorders, they were to be sent to Calcutta, notwithstanding any pretences they shall make for so doing.

"Notwithstanding the rigour of these orders, I have ever made it my business (when anything trifling happened) to endeavour by gentle means to persuade the gentlemen's several gomastahs here to act in a peaceable manner, which, although repeated several times, has had no effect, but, on the contrary, has occasioned their writing complaints of me to their respective masters that I obstructed them in their business and ill-used them; and in return I have received menacing letters from several gentlemen, threatening, if I interfere with their servants, to use such measures as I may repent; nor have the gentlemen only done this, their very gomastahs have made it public here, that in case I stop them in any proceeding, they will use the same methods; for the truth of which I have good proofs.

"Now, sir, I am to inform you what I have obstructed them in. This place was of great trade formerly, but now brought to nothing by the following practices. A gentleman sends a gomastah here to buy or sell; he immediately looks upon himself as sufficient to force every inhabitant either to buy his goods or sell him theirs, and on refusal (in case of non-capacity) a flogging or confinement immediately ensues. This is not suffi-

cient even when willing, but a second force is made use of, which is to engross the different branches of trade to themselves and not to suffer any persons to buy or sell the articles they trade in, and if the country-people do it, then a repetition of their authority is put in practice; and again, what things they purchase, they think the least they can do is to take them for a considerable deal less than another merchant, and oftentimes refuse paying that, and my interfering causes an immediate complaint. This and many other oppressions, more than can be related, which are daily used by the Bengal gomastahs, is the reason that this place is growing destitute of inhabitants. Every day numbers leave the town to seek a residence more safe, and the very markets, which before afforded plenty, do hardly now produce anything of use, their peons being allowed to force poor people, and if the zamindar tries to prevent it, he is threatened to be used in the same manner.

"Before, justice was given in the public cutchery, but now every gomastah is become a judge, and every one's house a cutchery; they even pass sentences on the zamindars themselves, and draw money from them by pretended injuries, such as a quarrel with some of their peons, or their having, as they assert, stole something, which is more likely to have been taken by their own people; but allowing they were robbed, I believe no gomastah's authority extends so far as to take his own satisfaction on the Government.

"Having thus far acquainted your Honour with the behaviour of the gomastahs here, I am to request your Honour's interest, that in case I am to put your orders into execution, I may be borne harmless therein. Now I beg leave to conclude, being, with all respect," &c.

An extract from this letter is given in a note to Mr

Mill's "History of India," vol. iii. p. 330 (ed. 1830); but Mr Mill wrongly describes it as a letter written to the Nawab by one of his officers. In fact the letter was written to Mr Vansittart by an officer whom he had sent down with six sepoys to Bákarganj at the request of the Nawab, and in order to assist the zamindar of Bákarganj. This circumstance raises the importance of the letter by showing that its representations come from one holding a presumably independent position, and not from one of Mir Kassim's servants. The letter, however, not only shows the distracted condition of the country, but also the feebleness of the remedies applied. It almost provokes a smile to find Mr Vansittart unable to do anything more vigorous than to send a common sergeant (apparently, from his name, not even a European) with six sepoys to a large mart like Bákarganj, when such oppressions were going on. The orders, too, which were given to the poor sergeant—viz., to deport the Europeans and their servants to Calcutta—seem ludicrously out of keeping with the means of coercion placed at his disposal, and justify Macaulay's remark, that Vansittart, with fair intentions, was a feeble and inefficient ruler.

The following extract from a letter of the Nawab (Mir Kassim) to Mr Vansittart gives another picture of the state of matters. It appears to have been written on 26th December 1762, and is printed at p. 167 of the 2d volume of Vansittart's "Narrative:"—

"As the Company's gomastahs make salt at Sundeep, &c., I desire you will write to them not to make any more there, but, like other merchants, to purchase it from the molunghies at the market price. . . .

"In the parganas of Gopalpúr and Dakhanbárpúr [Dakhin Shahbázpúr], and other districts where salt is made, the people of the Company's factory work the salt-

pans; and they take possession of all the salt which the molunghies of other parganas have made, by which means I suffer a very great loss. Moreover, they oblige the ryots to receive money from them for purchasing rice, and by force and violence they take more than the market price affords, and the ryots all run away on account of these oppressions. For many years it has been customary for the Cashmere merchants to advance money at Sunderbund, and provide molunghies to work the salt-pans there: they paid the rents for the salt-pans at the several parganas; and the duties on the salt, which were paid at Burry-saul Chokey, belonging to the Shahbunder, amounted to near Rs.30,000. At present the people of the factory have dispossessed the Cashmere merchants, and have appropriated all the salt to themselves."

In Long's "Selections," p. 55, there is an extract from the Government Consultations, dated 12th February 1755, stating that several boats loaded with rice had been stopped at Bákarganj by an order from Dacca (apparently issued by Rajah Raj Ballab), and that the stoppage had occasioned a great scarcity and dearness of grain in Calcutta. In consequence of this stoppage a Lieutenant Harding was sent with a small party of troops to clear the boats and take them under his protection. When the great famine of 1770 took place, help was sought for from Bákarganj,[1] just as in the

[1] It is mentioned in a memorandum by Sir George Campbell that a gentleman was despatched from Dacca to Bákarganj in 1770 to purchase grain. The fullest reference to the subject, however, is to be found in Hunter's "Rural Annals," Appendix B, p. 407, &c. Mr Sumner was the gentleman deputed (p. 419, Consultation of 3d April 1770). 33,913 mans had arrived from Bákarganj (p. 412). The rice from Bárkerganje (*sic*), Mr Becher observed, arrived at a most critical time; and "the Company has reaped a considerable benefit by the measure, which proved a general relief to the immediate dependants on the English here [Murshídábád],

famine of 1873–74 it was regarded as the chief source from which the distressed districts were to be supplied.

Probably the Portuguese were the first Europeans or quasi-Europeans who engaged in the Bákarganj trade. They came from Bandel and Goa, and settled at Sibpúr, about five miles from Bákarganj, towards the middle of the last century. As I have stated in another chapter, the Portuguese had dealings with the district of a less peaceful character—namely, in the beginning of the seventeenth century, when Sebastian Gonzales and other Portuguese pirates came from Chittagong and elsewhere, and in conjunction with the Burmese or Mugs, plundered the Sundarbans and the islands in the Meghna. The first British settler in the district was apparently a Scotchman, named William Robinson, who established himself at Madhupúr, in the neighbourhood of Baroikaran and Nalchiti, in 1766, and lived there for about thirty years. He described himself in 1794 as having embarked on board the ship "Falmouth" in 1765, and as having been cast ashore east of Saugor Sands in June 1766, from whence he had come up to Madhupúr by boat, and had been engaged in trade there ever since. His descendants still reside in the district, and his tomb is still to be seen in Barisál, in Mr Pereira's compound. There was also a Mr Frazer, who described himself in 1794 as having been for ten years at Baroikaran in the employment of Mr Gill.

In these days Nalchiti, which is now so large a mart, does not appear to have existed, or at least it was less

and tended to preserve order and regularity; otherwise the greatest confusion must have ensued." Rs.60,000 were given to the Dacca Council for the purchase of grain. If this were all the money spent at Bákarganj, the arrangement must have been very successful, for on 1st February 1771 the committee report that the sale of the Bákarganj rice produced a profit of Rs.67,593 (Appendix B, p. 419).

important than its neighbour Baroikaran, which is now almost deserted. Local tradition points to Baroikaran as the old headquarters of the district, and this is supported by a reference in the decree for the resumption of Baroikaran char to a piece of land therein which had originally been Mr Christopher Keating's cutchery. This is the Mr Keating of Hunter's "Annals," who, before he went to Birbhúm, was Civil Judge of Bákarganj in 1785. The ancient importance of Baroikaran is also shown by the fact that it was the site of the police station, which was not removed from it to Nalchiti until 1824.

Dacoits.—The great trade of Bákarganj, and the facilities for escape offered by its rivers and jungles, rendered it a favourite haunt of dacoits or gang-robbers, and the English Government was early obliged to take notice of their depredations. As far back as 1764 we find that an English gentleman named Mr Rose was murdered by dacoits near Bákarganj, and that the Nawab of Murshídábád was called upon to make the landholder refund the money and goods plundered, and to take such vigorous measures that the parts might be entirely cleared of robbers and murderers (Long's "Selections," p. 361. See also pp. 382, 383, and 385). The letter about Mr Rose given at p. 361 of Long's "Selections" is in answer to one from the Governor, dated 14th November 1764. The latter is interesting as a recognition of the practice of impaling, the Nawab being requested to order the Naib of Dacca to impale the robbers. I therefore quote it in full: "I have already by word of mouth represented to you, that as Mr Rose, an English gentleman, was travelling in a boat with some money and goods, the boat-people

murdered him near Bákarganj and carried away the money and goods, and took shelter in the zamindari of Sitaram. In order to inquire into this affair, I sent an Englishman to the said zamindar, but he would not regard him. I have therefore enclosed for your observation an account of the money and goods that were plundered, and request that you will write an order to the Naib of Dacca to make the zamindar refund, and inflict such punishment on him as may prevent all such proceedings in future. The number of murderers and robbers in the neighbourhood of Báckerganje is daily increasing, insomuch that trading people are now afraid to pass backwards and forwards, wherefore I request that you will give orders to the Naib of Dacca to send some of the factory sepoys along with some of his own people to apprehend the said murderers and *impale* them, which will be very serviceable to traders." Mr Rose is elsewhere called Captain John Rose and also Mr Ross, and apparently it was his own boatmen who murdered him. The whole of his property, including Rs.5800 in cash, was estimated at Rs.13,000. Among his property were four slaves, who were reckoned altogether as worth only Rs.240. Other instances of the depredations of dacoits are given in Seton-Karr's "Selections," p. 269 *et seq.* In 1788 they killed a Mr Burgh between Kulpadi and Gournadi.

They also attacked Mr Willis, the Collector of Sylhet, on his way through the district, and he had to run his boat ashore in order to escape from them. In a private letter printed at p. 273 of Seton-Karr's "Selections" the writer says, "I am happy to tell you that most of the dacoits who attacked Mr Willis in the Sundarbans have been taken. It appears they have been roving about the Sundarban rivers for eighteen months

without any settled habitation. They were chased by some armed boats, fitted out by Mr Day for the express purpose, below the island Sundeep, almost out at sea; and during the chase the pursuers and pursued were all nearly swallowed up by the high bore of the Meghna. There was skirmishing from time to time for a day and a half before the dacoits surrendered. They have since been brought to Dacca, and it is to be hoped that their fate will be an example and terror to others."

One Mahomed Hayat, a notorious dacoit, was sentenced by the Naib Nazim to perpetual imprisonment in 1790. The Governor-General ordered that he should be transported to the Prince of Wales Island. He returned in 1806.

I have noticed these dacoities here, because it was apparently in consequence of them that Government first took active measures for the administration of the district. An officer was appointed, called the Commissioner of the Sundarbans, who had his headquarters at Bákarganj. Unfortunately the Bákarganj magisterial records do not extend farther back than 1792, and I am unable to say at what date the office of Commissioner was established. Apparently Mr Lodge was the first Commissioner; he was succeeded in 1790 by Mr Hyndman ("Calcutta Gazette," 16th December 1790), and the latter by Mr Middleton.[1] At a still earlier date, however, there was a civil judge, first at Baroikaran and afterwards at Bákarganj. The first judge was

[1] The "Calcutta Gazette" of 6th December 1792 contains the following announcement: "The Governor-General in Council has been pleased to appoint Mr Samuel Middleton Commissioner in the Sundarbans for suppressing the depredations of dacoits, in the room of Mr William Hyndman deceased."

The same paper contains the announcement of the death of Mr Hyndman, "lately at Bákarganj."

apparently Mr Wroughton. He acted in 1782, and got into trouble with Mr Holland, the Chief of Dacca, about the execution of a process. The Governor (Warren Hastings) ordered him to be brought to trial about this, but I do not know what was the result. He was succeeded by Mr Keating, who was apparently succeeded by Mr Lodge. These facts are taken from some papers lent me by the Board of Revenue. Mr Lodge also held the office of Collector of Buzurgumedpúr, which was a zila or collectorate district long before Bákarganj. It appears from a letter of Mr Lodge, dated 12th August 1786, which is preserved in the office of the Board of Revenue, that the parganas of Chandradwip, Selímábád, Jaffirábád, Syedpúr, Arangpúr, and Azimpúr were attached to the zila of Buzurgumedpúr. Buzurgumedpúr apparently remained a separate charge till 1787, when it was annexed to the Collectorate of Dacca (Seton-Karr's Selections, p. 185).

CHAPTER XII.

REVENUE ADMINISTRATION.

I HAVE said that the magisterial records of Bákarganj do not extend farther back than 1792. The Collectorate records are not much older, the earliest being a letter dated 6th January 1790, which recommends the making of advances to the proprietors on account of the severe famine of 1787. It should also be noticed that the early Collectorate records are merely copies, the originals being at Dacca. The copies were obtained by Mr Hunter, the first Collector of Bákarganj, who came to Barisál in 1817 (see his letter to Board, 24th March 1819). They are not always perfect, and contain lacunæ as well as errors; but, on the other hand, they are probably in better preservation and more legible than the originals now are.

Next to the formation of the Permanent Settlement, the most important event in the history of Bákarganj during the last century was probably the famine of 1787. This appears to have caused a very great loss of life, especially in the northern parts of the district. It was the result of floods, not of drought; and indeed it may be said that the destruction of the crops by floods is the only possible cause of an extensive famine in Bákarganj. The country is so well watered that it is little in need of irrigation, and should the rain fail, enough water is brought into the southern parts of the districts

by the tides in some measure to supply its place. I have not been able to find any detailed description of the famine, but the following reference to it is made by Mr Douglas in a letter to the Board of Revenue, dated 6th April 1790. The occasion of Mr Douglas's writing was his having to report on the proposals for the Decennial Settlement of the district. "However unwilling I am," he writes, "to animadvert on Mr Day's proposed plan of a ten years' settlement, yet a regard for my own character, and from a perfect conviction that I cannot conclude the Settlement with many of the mahals at the jama recommended by him, impels me to deliver my sentiments freely on the subject, relying on the Board's candour for putting a favourable construction on the motives by which I am actuated. It is necessary to observe that Mr Day did not send down his proposed plan of settlement for upwards of six months after this district [Dacca Jalálpúr, which included Farídpúr and Bákarganj] had been visited by the most dreadful calamity ever remembered by the oldest inhabitant of the district, and which deprived it (by Mr Day's calculation) of upwards of 60,000 of its inhabitants, who either miserably perished, or were reduced to the painful necessity of forsaking their habitations in search of a precarious subsistence. Mr Day visited some of the parganas when the famine raged with the greatest violence, and had ocular proofs of the extreme misery to which the wretched inhabitants were reduced. He saw the parganas inundated, whole crops destroyed, and cultivation totally neglected. He had the mortification of beholding hundreds of the poor wretched inhabitants daily dying without the means of affording them the smallest relief. After a local investigation of the cruel effects of the

inundation, after a full conviction of the very heavy loss many of the principal parganas sustained both in their inhabitants and crops, and the consequent decline of cultivation, it is a matter of great surprise that Mr Day should, in many of the parganas which had suffered so materially by the inundation and loss of tenants, recommend an increase to be taken in the ensuing year's Settlement. That gentleman observes that his plan was founded on the 'Idea of a Ten Years' Bandobast.' Admitting of this, can it be supposed that districts which had been deprived of one-half of their natural resources, could in the short period of one year so far recover as to yield the customary revenue, much less bear an increase which would have added to the miseries they had already suffered, and in all probability have obliged the remaining ryots to desert their habitations and seek refuge in more favourable districts?"

Elsewhere the Collector reports of the pargana Idilpúr, that he has been told from respectable authority that the northern part of this zamindari lost three-fourths of its inhabitants in the dreadful calamity of 1194 B.S. (1787). It will be seen that Mr Douglas's words, "the most dreadful calamity ever remembered by the oldest inhabitant of the district," imply that Bákarganj did not suffer from the celebrated famine of 1770, which desolated so many districts in Bengal.

The famine of 1787 no doubt chiefly affected the northern and eastern parts of the district, and the more westerly and central portions probably escaped in great measure, for then, as now, the northern and eastern parts were especially exposed to being flooded. They are the first to feel the effects of the risings of the rivers, and they are full of low-lying lands and swamps. A great part of Faridpúr and of the Gournadi thana consists of

swamps, and it is seldom that a year passes without their suffering some loss from floods.

The early Collectorate records are chiefly occupied with the preparations for the Permanent Settlement. I have inserted in the Appendix the most important of them. As a general rule, the correspondence is of an uninteresting character, and it is only rarely that one comes upon anything worthy of being quoted.

It is evident enough that the system of collecting the revenues before the Permanent Settlement was a very hand-to-mouth one, and that everything depended on the personal qualities of the Collector and his subordinates. Estates were let in farm from year to year, and if the farmers, as was often the case, fell into arrears, they were imprisoned, or their farms were placed under the management of a sazawal or other Government officer. The following extract from a Collector's letter, dated 8th October 1790, gives some hint of the state of matters: "The Board observing in almost all the accounts *jama kharach*, a charge made for diet to prisoners, desire to be informed of what description they are, and upon what grounds the charge is admitted into the sazawal's account. This is an allowance for diet made to ryots and others who, upon proving refractory or dilatory in paying their rents, are put under restraint or confined for a time in the sazawal's [house ?]. They have no other means of subsistence. It amounts in all the accounts to about Rs.10 or Rs.12 for the whole year." In another letter (14th July 1790) the Collector writes, "I have confined the farmer for the balance due on account of *mahai* [fish] and *bajantri* [music] mahals, and trust to recover the same in a few days." A letter of 19th July 1790 notices the depredations of wild elephants in Kassimpúr and Bhowal, and reports that Birmohan is infested with tigers,

and that the Collector has in vain endeavoured to encourage the tiger-killers to repair to the pargana. On 9th August 1790 the Collector reports that he has, agreeably to the Governor-General's orders, done away with the gázar duty—*i.e.*, duty on washermen. It yielded only Rs.60 a year, which seems to show that washermen were even more scarce in the district in former times than they are now.

There were other mahals belonging to the sayer, such as the *dúmdari*, which was collected from bird-catchers, monkey and bear dancers, faqirs, snake-dancers, conjurors, &c. (9th August 1790). This farm yielded in one year Rs.1444, and the bajantri or music farm yielded as much as Rs.3102. There was another farm, called *mushrat kotwali*, which was composed of collections from artificers—*i.e.*, brickmakers, &c. *Púnya* charges, or the charges for the ceremonial of the first receipt of rent for the year, were disallowed by the Board, though the Collector says they were invariably incurred and included under the head of chakla expenses (12th April 1792). In another letter the Collector writes about the charge for guarding treasure: "Your Board deem the sum of Rs.550 on account *barkandazes* excessive, and expect I will considerably reduce them. I trust you will deem this sum indispensable, when you are informed that the barkandazes are entertained as guards over the Mofussil cutchery and treasure; that they always escort the revenues to my treasury; that for that purpose it requires a strong guard to prevent the boats conveying the treasure from being plundered by the dacoits who infest the Meghna river. Were not the barkandazes regularly kept at the Mofussil treasury, it would be liable to be attacked and robbed by the dacoits who inhabit the Sundarbans, to which Selímábád pargana is adjoining, and indeed

forms part of the Sundarbans. The established rate of boat-hire from Selímábád to Dacca is Rs.9."

A letter of 16th February 1792 records an attempted insurrection of one Bolaki Shah, a faqir, who had collected an armed force, and proclaimed to his followers that the reign of the Feringhies or Europeans was at an end. He was said to have erected a fort at Subandia; and a revenue peon who was seized by him reported that he saw at his place seven cannon, twelve ginjals, and five or six muskets, two spears, and two men employed in making gunpowder. A Naib and forty-eight sepoys were sent to apprehend him. I have been told that it was this faqir who removed the old cannon which used to lie in Sujábád Fort.

It was part of the arrangements of the Permanent Settlement that the zamindars should give their ryots pattas or leases, and Mr Douglas was called on to report what progress had been made in this matter. On 6th December 1792 he reports as follows :—

"Some zamindars object to giving pottahs. The zamindar of Nurallapúr says that, by the ancient custom of the country, pottahs are not granted to the old-established ryots, that they paid according to the rates fixed on their respective villages, or by a measurement. That any new ryots delivering in proposals for cultivating jungle-lands, to such ryots pottahs are granted, and they paid according to the quantity of land they annually cultivated. Others, again, do not take out pottahs for cultivating the jungle-lands, the demands from them are regulated according to the rates paid by other ryots who cultivate jungle-lands. That ever since the commencement of the current year he has been busily engaged in drawing out pottahs, framing accounts in conformity to the regulations; but his lands are much

scattered. He finds it extremely difficult to carry into immediate effect the orders of Government. Besides, the old-established ryots obstinately oppose the receipt of pottahs, and threaten to leave their lands.

"The zamindars of Rasulpúr, Baikanthpúr, Sultanábád, Ratandi Kalikapúr, have delivered in similar representations with the above. As it appeared to me very extraordinary that any ryot should object to the receipt of pottahs which would secure him from any arbitrary demands, I called several of them before me to state their grounds of objection, which they did as follows: That they enjoyed the same lands possessed by their forefathers; that they cultivate the same, and pay the same revenue; that their ancestors never received pottahs; that their acceptance of them would be disgraceful, as it would betray a mutual want of confidence on their and the zamindar's part; that they should lose the honorary title of being called old-established ryots, and thereby become degraded by being styled new ryots. When I consider the prejudices of this people—how bigoted they are to old-established customs, and how extremely averse they are to any innovation which militates against former usage—I am the less surprised at the objection started by the ryots for receiving pottahs; but being convinced it will ultimately redound to their ease, comfort, and benefit, by carrying into effect the regulation, I have again issued peremptory orders to the landholders for granting pottahs to every description of ryots, and directed those who have not yet delivered to me forms of pottahs, to do so immediately. Many of the landholders have granted pottahs to their ryots, according to the forms approved by me."

There are a few letters among the records about the

weavers and the salt manufacture. One forwards a petition from some ryots in Rajnagar complaining that the Commercial Resident at Lakhypúr forces advances on them as weavers, although, in fact, they never had woven anything. Another letter, dated 2d October 1790, states that the ryots are seized by the agents of the Salt Department to act as smiths, and that not only were they seized, but they were made to pay *piadgan*, or the fees of the *piada* who seized them! This piadgan is a well-known zamindari charge in the present day, and is one which must strike even the apathetic Bengali with a sense of injustice. It seems so iniquitous first to drag a man away from his home, and then to make him pay for the outrage which has been committed on him.

Bákarganj was, as I have said, a great seat of the salt manufacture. The establishments on the islands of Hattia and Dakhin Shahbázpúr were managed from Noakháli, or Bhulua, as it is also called; but that in Selímábád, &c., was managed from Jhalukátti, which appears to be identical with Rai Mongal, and also with Jainagar. The last-mentioned place was situated near the Ghosal Rajah's seat at Gurudham. The name of Mr Ewart, who figures in Mr Westland's "Jessore," is still remembered at Jhalukátti. He had a large house there, and is said to have been so magnificent as to have had a European baker and a European barber.

As appears to have been the case everywhere, the salt manufacture in Bákarganj led to oppressions and lawlessness, and to consequent disputes between the salt officers and the Magistrates. In 1826 the Magistrate of Bákarganj was called upon by the Board of Customs, salt and opium, to state the result of the suits brought by and against the salt officers, and replied as follows:

"I beg leave to state that the issue of the suits since my taking charge of this district has been generally proved against the salt officers for atrocities and oppression of every description, and I do not hesitate in giving my opinion that the greatest coercion is had recourse to in order to force advances on the molunghies by the *baiparies* or salt contractors, many of whom have been found guilty and punished, and nine have been lately committed for trial before the Judge of Circuit, convicted, and sentenced to seven and six years' imprisonment, besides many who have been punished both by the former Magistrates and also by the Court of Circuit" (12th June 1826).

The remissions made to the zamindars of Dakhin Shahbázpúr and Selímábád and other places, on account of lands used for the salt manufacture, were a fruitful source of correspondence at various times (see an elaborate report by Mr Collector Sutherland, 13th June 1866).

The first Collector of Bákarganj was Mr Day. He was succeeded by Mr Douglas, who made the Permanent Settlement, and then followed Messrs Thompson, Armstrong, and Massie. All these, however, and their successors up to 1817, resided at Dacca, and scarcely ever visited Bákarganj. Mr Hunter, the first independent Collector of Bákarganj, received charge of his office on 8th December 1817. The Collectorate was established partly from an idea that the cultivation of the Sundarbans would thereby be facilitated, and apparently Mr Hunter was chosen on account of his supposed aptitude for such duty. (He was one of those who afterwards set about reclaiming Saugor Island.)

Bákarganj was not, however, entirely without resident revenue officers before Mr Hunter's arrival. In 1814

there was an Assistant-Collector at Barisál who had charge of the treasury, and who, I believe, also tried summary suits for rent. He was subordinate to the Collector of Dacca, but also corresponded directly with Calcutta. There was a similar officer at Faridpúr. The first officer appears to have been Mr E. Bagge. He was succeeded by Mr E. Lee Warner, and he in his turn was succeeded by Mr Pigou and by Mr Frazer. It was Mr Frazer who gave over charge to Mr Hunter. These Assistant-Collectors were also assistants to the Magistrate.

On 18th April 1818 Mr Hunter sent a list of the establishment proposed by him for the collectorship, and this was corrected by a subsequent letter dated 27th May. His pay was Rs.1500, and the cost of the proposed establishment was, including this, Rs.2458 a month.

Mr Hunter remained in charge of the Collectorate till 6th November 1819, when he made over charge to Mr Barlow, who was succeeded on 5th April 1820 by Mr Lara. Mr Hunter, however, took charge again on 30th October 1820, but finally made over charge to Mr Maxwell on 22d January 1821.

Mr Hunter was engaged actively in collecting information about the chars or alluvial formations which had been formed since the time of the Permanent Settlement, for this was the time of resumptions. He visited the remote parts of the district, including the island of Kúkri Múkri, and he employed a Mr Jackson to make a sort of survey of the Sundarbans.

After the Permanent Settlement was fairly completed, the work of the Collectorate became tolerably easy, and consisted chiefly in the trial of rent suits. After the passing of Regulation 11 of 1819, the work of resumption

became considerable, and the number of islands and chars resumed in the district was very large. These resumptions also led to numerous Government suits, which the Collector had to look after. Notwithstanding this, it is probable that a Collector's work continued to be tolerably light until the passing of Act 10 of 1859, and the subsequent combination of the offices of Collector and Magistrate.

CHAPTER XIII.

PROGRESS OF THE CRIMINAL ADMINISTRATION AND GENERAL HISTORY.

The Civil Judges of Bákarganj had, I believe, magisterial powers also. I do not know the exact nature of the office of Commissioner of Bákarganj, but I believe he had at first only preventive powers, and did not acquire judicial powers until 1794. These seem to have been conferred by the repealed Regulation 9 of 1793, the preamble to which gives a *résumé* of the various judicial systems. The same Regulation (sect. 40) makes Bákarganj one of the stations of the Dacca Court of Circuit. The office of Commissioner was abolished by Regulation 7 of 1797, which divided Dacca Jalálpúr into two divisions—"the northern to be denominated the zila of Dacca Jalálpúr [now Farídpúr], and the southern division the zila of Bákarganj." Section 1 states that one object of the Regulation is "to provide for the more effectual administration of justice in the Sundarbans and the district adjacent, heretofore included in the jurisdiction of the Commissioner of Bákarganj, who was invested with the powers of a Magistrate, but was not authorised to exercise any civil jurisdiction."

Mr Middleton is said to have removed the offices from Baroikaran to Bákarganj. Probably this was in 1792, when he was appointed Commissioner. Mr Middleton remained at Bákarganj till 1800, when he

was succeeded by Mr Spedding, who again was succeeded by Mr Wintle who removed (1801) the offices to Barisál. Mr Middleton does not appear to have been a very efficient officer, and more than once incurred the censure of Government. Indeed, if he had been a good officer, it is not likely that he would have been sent to so disagreeable a place as Bákarganj, or kept there so long as eight years. One of Mr Middleton's most extraordinary proceedings was his sending one Alliar Khan, a notorious *goinda* or informer, to the island of Dakhin Shahbázpúr with a general warrant to arrest dacoits and suspicious characters. I believe this was done in consequence of a Mr Paliologus, the servant of a Mr Demetrius, a Greek salt merchant, having been speared and killed by dacoits while in the island. Alliar Khan brought in no less than 314 persons to Bákarganj (see letter of 22d January 1801), and Mr Middleton's successor was a good deal puzzled to know what to do with them. However, this happened near the end of Mr Middleton's tenure of office, and we must not be too hard on a man who had breathed for eight years an atmosphere which makes one feel as if only "half-alive" (letter of Mr Wintle). The Government of the day took a lenient view of the case, and ascribed Mr Middleton's action entirely to his zeal for the public service (5th March 1801).

In these early days ships came up to Bákarganj and traded there in rice. Mention is made in the records of the "Eliza," which was at Bákarganj in August 1794, and of the brig "Maria," which was there on 26th November 1808. The Civil Surgeon, Mr Harper, appears to have been in partnership with Mr Gill as a boatbuilder, and to have employed (in 1794) a Frenchman named Antoin Piaji. In consequence probably of the famine of 1787, Government took to storing rice at Bákarganj, and had fifty-

two *golahs* or granaries there. It may be noted that in former times Government had no scruple whatever in carrying out a policy which was considered by many so monstrous in 1873-74, and that there are several instances in the official records, and in Seton-Karr's "Selections," of Government's stopping the exportation of grain.

Formerly it was the custom to execute criminals at the scene of their crime, and such an execution took place at Ram Prasad Hát on 7th July 1794. It seems also to have been the idea to make executions as public as possible, instead of, as now, hiding them from the public eye. I find an instance of a hanging which took place at Bákarganj at one o'clock in the day.

There is nothing in the records to show the kind of life led by the officers at Bákarganj. The society was very small—apparently Messrs Middleton and Harper were the only English officers of their day; and the only fact of interest that I have been able to discover is that Mr Middleton's wife resided with him at Bákarganj. On 8th April 1795 the Nizamat Adálat sent Mr Middleton a cat-o'-nine-tails, and informed him that he would be furnished with a new cat whenever the one now sent to him became unserviceable.

The town of Bákarganj stands on a small river called the Srimantapúr khál. The situation can never have been very healthy or pleasant, and it became worse in consequence of the formation of a char in front of the cutcheries. Its advantages were that it was central, that it had a large market, and that it was near the Golabari, where the tahsildar of Buzurgumedpúr had his cutchery, and the Portuguese settlement of Sibpúr. Very few remains of the old buildings now exist. The cutcheries appear to have been situated where the thana

now is, and there is still a brick terrace there. The jail was higher up the khál, and on the bank of a small stream which is still called the Jailkhana khál. There was a good deal of correspondence about the change of site. Mr Middleton recommended Mohanganj, but eventually Barisál was fixed upon. A letter of the Nizamat Adâlat, dated 1st May 1801, directs the Magistrate to remove to Barisál, which was the place recommended by the Dacca Court of Circuit. See also letter of 29th April 1801 to the Governor-General. It must, I think, be admitted that the new site was well chosen, and that it has stood the test of time very well, as Barisál is about the healthiest and most conveniently situated town in the district.

There are two orders of Circuit Judges preserved among the records, which are worth quoting for their singularity. One is an order of Mr Bayard, dated 26th December 1800, directing that three men should be imprisoned for fifteen days for "declining to come to my assistance in an embarrassing situation when required, and refusing me those attentions which as a Judge of Circuit I have a right to command from all descriptions of persons in travelling through this district." Another is a similar order of Mr Crisp, dated 27th July 1800, directing that some palki-bearers be imprisoned for fifteen days for contempt of court, in refusing to associate with other bearers who had carried him to the jail.

The great point looked to in the commencement of the Bákarganj criminal jurisdiction was the suppression of dacoities. There were fourteen stations and fourteen boats, and the river patrol was the subject of much correspondence. It is certain that the Magistrates had very daring dacoits to deal with. Two of them—viz.,

Mahomed Hayat and Ainudeen Sikdar—were men of property, and were ringleaders or *sardar* dacoits. They were transported and their lands confiscated—a measure which led to almost endless correspondence on the Collectorate side, as the zamindars and the dacoits' families concealed the ownership of the lands, so that it was exceedingly difficult to identify them.

I can find nothing remarkable in the early official history of Bákarganj. None of the Magistrates appear to have been above the average in point of ability. I am afraid, indeed, that Bákarganj has been from the earliest times what a friend of mine once called it, "the dust-bin of Bengal," and that no officer was sent to it except as a punishment, or because he was not thought good enough for a better district. Mr Garrett, writing to the Secretary to Government in 1827, says, "I scarcely think there is any need of expatiating to you on the circumstances of this district, its situation, the litigious character of the inhabitants, and the general dislike evinced by the gentlemen of the service to accept the situation of Judge and Magistrate of Bákarganj. The last confirmed Judge who joined this station was Mr A. Mackenzie. This gentleman quitted it in 1817, since which period there has been a succession of officiating Magistrates. Though no less than four gentlemen were fully appointed, none of them ever joined. The prejudice against this place is not without foundation; the duties are certainly laborious, and the climate bad." There is a report by Mr Gardner on the police system, dated 19th February 1805, from which it appears that the total annual cost of the police was Rs.33,360. At that time Gournadi was not under Bákarganj, it having been transferred in 1806, nor was Idilpúr pargana a part of the district. On the other hand, Kachua (now

in Jessore) belonged to Bákarganj, and also Hattia and Dakhin Shahbázpúr. The latter islands belonged to Bákarganj up to 1822, when they were transferred to the newly-established district of Noakháli. Dakhin Shahbázpúr was retransferred to Bákarganj in 1869. In course of time various changes were made in police arrangements. Thus thanas Kotwalipara and Mirzaganj were established in 1812, the Kotwali or Barisál thana was established in 1820 (it had hitherto been part of Bakainagar thana), and the Baroikaran thana was removed in 1824 to Nalchiti.

In February 1812 there was a serious outbreak in the jail during the magistracy of Mr Battye, and twelve prisoners were shot before it was suppressed. Mr Battye was attacked on this occasion, and was only saved by the bravery and self-devotion of one of the sepoy guard. In September 1817 the Magistrate reports the occurrence of an epidemic (cholera ?), and on 28th February 1818 the *cholera morbus* is reported to have reappeared.[1] On 16th April 1820 the Magistrate asks for cholera medicines, and says that the disease is very prevalent in every part of the district. On 6th May 1822 cholera is reported to be prevalent. It again broke out in August 1825, and this was its most deadly manifestation; 24,960 persons are said to have died of it in the district, besides 90 who died in jail—total, 25,050. All these deaths are said to have occurred between 22d August and 10th September, within which short time twenty women performed satí. On 19th August 1820 the Magistrate forwards Rs.268, collected as a contribu-

[1] In the "Lettres edifiantes" there is a letter from a Père Papin, dated Bengal, 18th December 1709, in which he refers to the *mordechin* (?) or *cholera morbus* as being common in the country. He says the native treatment for it was to keep the patient from drinking water and to burn the soles of the feet.

tion towards a monument of Warren Hastings, late Governor-General of India.

The great event in the history of the district in this century was the inundation of the 6th June 1822, which is still well remembered by the people as the *banya* or flood of 1229 B.S. It was this inundation which swept over the island of Hattia, in the Noakháli district, and destroyed nearly every inhabitant. Mr Cardew was Collector of Bákarganj at the time, and on 9th June 1822 he reported as follows: "It is my painful duty to report, for the information of the Board, the dreadful state to which this district has been reduced by a most violent hurricane and inundation, which has extended its ravages through the whole district. This office was many feet under water, and I am sorry to say that a great part of the records have been swept away, including the whole of the kanungo's papers, the Bhulua papers, and the greatest part of the stamps. In fact, the mischief has been so great that as yet I am unable to state what has actually taken place. On the 6th I held a sale for arrears of revenue, which I was unable to complete." Mr Cardew adds that as the whole of the amlahs' property had been destroyed, he had advanced them two months' pay as *hawalat*. A *rubakari* or vernacular proceeding was drawn up about the affair. It recorded that "on the 6th June a sale of estates was fixed, and some mahals were disposed of. In the evening of that day it began to blow violently, and soon after the waters rose to a dreadful height, so that to escape with life became difficult. The destruction was terrible, &c.

"On the 9th June the hurricane became less violent, and the river subsided. A little after this time the *serishtadar*, &c., came into the Presence and stated what had happened in their offices. It was then impossible

to hold cutchery; but the acting Collector proceeded with the above-named officers to the office, when he found that about four feet of water had risen in the cutchery, and that many bags of papers had been carried out of the office, while others were scattered about wet and covered with mud, and that some *almirahs* had been driven from their places." A rubakari, drawn up on the 18th July 1822, gave lengthy details of the papers which had been lost. Unfortunately, neither of the above rubakaris has been preserved, and I have only seen a condensed abstract of the first of them. 39,940 persons—namely, 20,125 males and 19,815 females—are said to have lost their lives in the inundation. In Khalsakháli thana alone 22,422 lives are said to have been lost, and 10,984 in Baufal; and according to my notes, the deaths in these thanas are not included in the total of 39,940. Also 98,834 cattle are said to have been lost, and Rs.1,326,691-11-8 of property are said to have been destroyed; but Mr Collector Phillips very reasonably objects to a list which professes to give even anas and gandas. A letter dated 9th July 1822 gives translations of the reports of the *darogahs*. The Baufal darogah's report was as follows: "At midday on the 6th June 1822 a storm commenced, and increased by degrees. After nine o'clock at night it was so violent that men, cattle, and property were washed away. Many persons were drowned, and some having got on *choppers* [roofs of houses], were driven from one village to another. Others ascended large trees and remained there all night. Next morning it decreased, but the storm continued for seven or eight days. Sir, having made inquiries in this thana, I have ascertained that there are sixty-three villages; in those situated in the eastern part, on the other side of the large river, many men, cattle,

and property were destroyed. In the western side of the thana the inundation was less. It is difficult to find out the names in a short time, but by inquiries it has come to my knowledge that in the villages within this thana 4932 men and 6052 women—in all, 10,984 persons—and 9700 bullocks were drowned; besides which, the property of the population has been destroyed to an amount that is impossible to guess."

The notice that the storm began at Baufal at midday is interesting, as it shows how long the storm took to travel from Baufal to Barisál, where the storm commenced in the evening. Baufal is south-south-east of Barisál, and from the fact that it and Khalsakháli thana and the islands in the Meghna suffered most, it appears that the storm came from the south-east. "I am happy to say that the effects of the late inundation have not been so severely felt by the district in general as I had at first supposed. To the west and north-west there was very little water. The thanas of Tagra [now Perozpúr], Kachua [now in Jessore], Baroikaran, and Burirhát have suffered only from the violence of the wind. The chief brunt of the inundation appears to have fallen on the thanas Chandia [Dakhin Shahbázpúr,] Khalsakháli, Baufal, Bakainagar [in which Barisál was situated], and Mendiganj" (21st June 1822). The Collector also adds that he has great pleasure in being able to inform the Government that rice, which was a few days ago selling in the bazár at the enormous rate of ten sírs of sixty sicca weight per rupee, has been reduced to very nearly its former price, and that this has been occasioned by the meritorious and active exertions of Mr Dawes, the acting Magistrate of the city of Dacca, in inducing the merchants of the district to forward supplies. Government took notice of the catastrophe, and sent in rice

through the great house of Palmer & Co. A committee was also formed in Calcutta, which despatched a Major Stewart to distribute relief. Rice was also received from Jessore, from the assistant to the salt agent. On 9th July the Collector reports that constant supplies of grain arrive from Dacca and elsewhere, and that the station and the neighbourhood continue healthy. On 11th August he reports that rice and other necessaries are procurable in Barisál and the neighbourhood at lower rates than those stated in the invoice from Messrs Palmer & Co. No details appear to have been ever given of the loss of life in Manpúra and the other islands, but the Collector writes that most of the inhabitants of Manpúra and the other islands had been swept into eternity. With regard to the jail, the Magistrate writes on 25th June 1822 that he had great difficulty in procuring food for the prisoners until the arrival of the very opportune supplies from Dacca and Narainganj, and that he had been obliged to feed the prisoners upon damaged rice. However, no evil effects had followed, and the jail had never been healthier, there being only one man in hospital.[1]

The following notice of the inundation appears in the "Asiatic Journal" for 1822, p. 620: "A most violent storm burst over Calcutta on the night of Friday last [7th June], which must have disturbed the sleep of the soundest. The furious peals of crashing thunder reverberating immediately overhead were truly appalling, and in the pauses between each peal of the 'artillery of heaven' the mind naturally reverted to the thousands who were exposed to the utmost terrors of the tempest on the great deep. Accounts from Dina-

[1] The Barisál gale is marked on Piddington's chart, vol. xvi. A. S. J., 1847; see also his "Sailor's Horn-Book," pp. 57, 59. The storm was too far at the head of the Bay to come in the track of ships.

púr mention that boats without number have been lost in the Ganges, and that the Patna shores were covered with wrecks. Several lives must have been lost, though no particulars have yet reached us. In the lower provinces the hopes of the indigo-planters have been bitterly disappointed. These, however, are but trivial effects of the late storm in comparison with the tremendous detail of devastation and misery which it is our painful duty to notice. What are we to expect from the next shipping accounts, when we are told that in one place on the land 100,000 lives have been lost? It is truly dreadful to think of such a terrible misfortune. The source of our intelligence upon this melancholy occasion is from the following extract of a letter from Jessore: 'Ten days ago my indigo prospects were promising beyond anything I could have calculated upon; since that period the most violent hurricane ever remembered in this quarter, accompanied with a deluge of rain, has destroyed full one-half of our plants, and rendered the recovery of a great part of the remainder precarious. The storm lasted forty-eight hours, and swept houses and everything before it. Many trees were torn up by the roots and carried to a distance of several feet. I never witnessed such a scene of devastation as this place presented. The rain continued almost without intermission for four days after the storm had ceased, so that the whole country is under water. I have just seen a letter from the acting Magistrate of Barisál, about 120 miles to the eastward of this station, detailing the effects of the late storm, which commenced there on the afternoon of the 7th. I scarcely ever perused a more melancholy account. Barisál is situated on the banks of the Meghna, which river, from the fury of the winds, broke over its boundaries in every direc-

tion, and inundated the whole country to an alarming depth. The river rose so rapidly that on the 8th, at night, they had upwards of five feet of water in their houses, and the current was so strong that the doors and windows were burst open, and a regular rush of water set in through the houses. This gentleman says he contrived to get two palanquins to the top of his house, and retreated thither with his wife and children as a last resort. The registrar and doctor's houses were carried away, or at least fell in from the violence of the storm. Nearly the whole property of the residents of the station was destroyed. Had this been the extent of the damage, however, it would have been of little consequence, comparatively speaking; but alas! the sufferings of the native inhabitants are not to be described. No fewer than one lac of lives are said to have been lost on this occasion, together with the whole of the cattle and grain of every description, both in store and what was on the ground. The dead bodies were floating in every direction, and carried with the current through the houses. The writer states that no rice was to be procured even for the prisoners, and that he felt he would be obliged to release them from jail, otherwise they must starve. From what information he could obtain, he believed that the district could not supply food for ten days' consumption to the inhabitants who had escaped this dreadful visitation. I should think the writer meant to include in the lac the lives of the cattle lost, although I should certainly infer from the letter that 100,000 human beings perished. I have not heard whether the storm reached beyond this district to the northward and westward.'"

A meeting for the relief of the distress in Bákarganj was held in the Calcutta Town Hall on the 19th of

June, and another on the 22d idem. A subscription was opened, and eventually upwards of Rs.18,000 were collected. (According to the latest reports of the committee, Rs.18,433 sicca.) Major Stewart volunteered his services, and was sent to Bákarganj to distribute relief. The "Calcutta Monthly Journal," speaking of his having finished the good work upon which he had entered with such philanthropic alacrity, says that the zeal and judgment displayed by him in its performance reflected on him the highest honour.

In the "Calcutta Journal" for 1822 (p. 192) the following curious incident is mentioned: "One of our correspondents mentions that at Ratandi he saw a child, who being only a few weeks old, his curiosity was excited to know how it had been preserved during the tempest and inundation. In reply to his inquiries, he was told that it was born in a tree when the whole surface of the country was covered with water; and its mother was then questioned, and corroborated this tale. The surprise of the inquirer was still further increased, however, when he came to learn that so far from this being a singular event, there were from thirty to forty females, some of whom having reached the period of natural delivery, but many more having the birth accelerated by terror and alarm, who gave birth to their infants in this dreadful situation, and yet so providentially is the wind tempered to the shorn lamb, that most of these individuals with their offspring lived, presenting a picture of misery and distress unprecedented, we believe, even in the imagination of the painter or the poet, and certainly without a parallel, as far as we remember, either in fable or in history. . . .

"The servant of a gentleman in Calcutta, whose family live at Hattia, says that out of four brothers and their

families only one of the brothers was found after the storm and inundation, and he was blown across the river to the northward upon the top of a chopper" (roof).

The following appears in Sandeman's "Selections," dated Thursday, June 20, 1822: "On Sunday last we received an account of the awful calamity with which the civil station of Burrisol has been afflicted. It is brief, but the facts are of the most melancholy description, and require not detail to awaken feelings of the liveliest pity and commiseration. The sufferings of thousands—men, women, and children—during the terrible night of the storm must have been truly dreadful.

"The storm commenced on the evening of the 6th, and before midnight the body of water had overtopped the Bund, which runs along the margin of the river, and was approaching the gentlemen's houses rapidly. Mr Cardew, the Registrar,[1] had just sufficient time to send a palanquin with some food in it to the top of the house for his wife. Immediately after, his dining-room was three feet deep in water, the current carrying everything before it with irresistible violence. In another house there was five feet water in the dining-room, and dead bodies, washed from the native huts, floating about the room, in which only a few hours before dinner had been served. One thousand lives were lost in the bazár alone, and the loss throughout the district is not to be calculated. A famine was apprehended as inevitable. No provisions were procurable for the prisoners, in consequence of which they were released on the second day."[2]

It was probably the inundation which induced Government to build new cutcheries at Barisál. Formerly the Magistrate held cutchery in his own house, and received

[1] He was acting Collector and Magistrate.

[2] The criminal prisoners, at all events, were not released.

an allowance on this account. This arrangement continued to 1829. (See letters of May 25, June 20, 1826, &c.)

Mr Garrett appears to have been the first Magistrate who did much for the improvement of Barisál. He was Magistrate from 1827 to 1830, when he asked to be relieved, saying that he had been three and a half years at Barisál, and that he could not work so hard as formerly. He appears to have been the first officer who established a school (31st March 1828), and he also dug tanks and made other improvements. Government assigned to him Rs.1500, and Rs.925 were subscribed in the district for improvements at Barisál. In his time there were only three roads in the district—one of four miles, and two of two miles in length (5th June 1830). On 15th March 1828 he recommended the removal of the Gournadi police station to its present position at Palardi. Mr Garrett, I believe, left the district for a time, but he did not finally quit it till May 1832; so that he must have spent about five years in it. He acted as Judge as well as Magistrate. What partly led to his departure was, I believe, that he became a Baptist, and insisted upon being baptized in a tank in the station. His *nazir*, Mr Parry (he was dewani or judge's nazir), was one of the first to preach Christianity to the natives. Mr Parry afterwards became a regular missionary and went to Jessore. The practice of satí was abolished in Mr Garrett's time, and on 1st March 1830 he writes, "I am heartily thankful that the horrible practice of suttee has been put a stop to. It has been attended with no trouble, I am happy to say, in this jurisdiction. It must be a great ease of mind to all magistrates." In a previous letter, dated 17th August 1829, he writes, "The business is often harassing, but the subject most painful

to me is the frequency of suttee. The number that have taken place this year up to the end of July amount to sixteen. I was induced the other day, thinking it my duty, to be present at one not very far from here, conceiving I might possibly do some good, but I regret to say it was not in my power, the poor creature appearing perfectly determined." For several years previous to the abolition of satí, Government had been endeavouring to check its occurrence; and on 14th December 1818, Mr Harrington, the Magistrate, reports that satís have diminished since the Government orders of 4th October 1814. It was the practice to have reports from the police of the number of satís in their jurisdictions. In 1825, the year of the cholera, there were as many as sixty-three; in 1824 there were twenty-three satís; in 1826, forty-five; and in 1827, twenty-nine.

Among the East India papers in the Indian Library there is a volume on the subject of Hindu widows, and it gives some curious statistics about satís. The details of the Bákarganj cases for 1824 and 1825 are given in it. Of the sixty-three cases in 1825, it is recorded that in twenty-three cases the husbands were rich, and that in the others they were poor. One case was what was called *anumaran—i.e.*, the husband died away from the wife, who burnt herself along with two strings of beads which had belonged to him. On an average, the widows in the sixty-three cases were middle-aged; one was over ninety, and only one was under twenty years of age. Satís were singularly few in Dacca. In Dacca city and Dacca Jalálpúr districts the numbers were as follows: Dacca city, 1823, fourteen; 1824, seven; 1825, eighteen; 1826, twelve. Dacca Jalálpúr, 1823, two; 1824, two; 1825, two; 1826, three.

The explanation seems to be that Mr Cracroft, the Judge of the Dacca Circuit, ruled that persons of the Baidya caste were not entitled to the privilege of satí. The relations of a Baidya widow appealed to the Nizamat Adâlat against this ruling, and the court ordered that the widow should be allowed to burn herself. (It was a case of *anumaran*.) However, I am glad to say that the delay had a good effect, and that the Magistrate (Mr Morrison) was able to report that the widow had changed her mind. The volume contains some curious correspondence between Mr Cracroft and the Judges of the Nizamat.

In 1845 there was a notable case of embezzlement in the treasury. Mr Sturt was then Collector; he appears to have been a careless and indolent officer, and to have left everything to his subordinates. The result was that in August 1845 he had to report that some Rs.50,000 were missing from the treasury, and that the treasurer had absconded. A lengthened investigation took place, first by the Commissioner, and afterwards by Messrs Ricketts & Samuells, of which the upshot was that Mr Sturt was degraded, and the treasurer brought to trial and sentenced to, I believe, seven years' imprisonment. A portion of the money embezzled was realised from the treasurer's securities, who were entirely ruined. I believe Mr Sturt was originally in the navy. He married a native lady, and used to give great entertainments, and even to have the swinging festival—*i.e.*, the *charak puja*—celebrated in front of his house.

A remarkable crime was committed in Bákarganj in 1847. Kali Prasad Kanjhi Lall, the gomasta or servant of an indigo-planter named Dunlop, whose factories were situated in the Mulfatganj thana, was attacked by the ryots and carried off in a boat to the south of the dis-

trict, and finally murdered at Maudobi, in the south of Khalsakháli thana. It is said that the body was cut in pieces and thrown into the sea; hence the proverbial expression of making a Kanjhi Lall of one's enemy. (See Magistrate's letters of 20th February and 20th July 1847.) The reasons for Kanjhi Lall's being carried off were that Dudhu Mia, the head of the Ferazis, whose residence was at Sibchar, in the Mulfatganj thana, had disputes with Mr Dunlop, and that the ryots considered that Kanjhi Lall oppressed them. Mr Dunlop's factory at Panchchur was burnt at this time. Although Bákarganj was the scene of the murder, neither Kanjhi Lall nor his murderers were connected with the district. The circumstances of the attack on Mr Dunlop's factory, which occurred on 5th December 1846, are fully detailed in the printed report of the trial of the rioters. Dudhu Mia was tried before Mr Swetenham, Judge of Faridpúr, and convicted, but was acquitted by the Nizamat Adâlat. (See also Mr Latour's evidence before the Indigo Commission.)

The Indian mutiny had little or no effect on the district, and, as far as I am aware, the inhabitants showed no signs of sympathy with it.

As there are no indigo-factories in the district, there was no agitation at the time when the ryots of Nadiya and Jessore threw off the cultivation of indigo.

In 1865 cattle disease broke out very severely in Bákarganj, and some 40,000 cattle are said to have perished. The disease entered from Jessore, and was most severe in the Perozpúr subdivision. It is said that 13,199 cattle died in Tagra thana (Perozpúr) alone. (See Mr Sutherland's letter of 14th September 1865; also see Selections from Government Records (Bengal), No. 43, 1869.)

In 1869 an income-tax assessor was beaten in Dakhin Shahbázpúr, but I believe the attack was caused by his own misconduct.

Of late years the rent question has excited a good deal of attention, and there has been a considerable degree of bad feeling between the ryots and zamindars, but without any important outbreak.

The census of 1872 was taken without the least attempt at disturbance. It was commenced on the 15th of January, and nearly completed in twenty-four hours.

During the present century the district has undergone many changes in its administration and in its boundaries. In 1815 or 1816 its area was enlarged on the north by the addition of the Idilpúr pargana, which was then transferred to it from the jurisdiction of the city of Dacca. Lately this arrangement has been reversed, by the transfer of the pargana, together with the Mádaripúr subdivision, to Faridpúr.

In 1822 the islands of Hattia and Dakhin Shahbázpúr were transferred from Bákarganj and included in the newly-created district of Noakháli. In 1869 Dakhin Shahbázpúr was retransferred to Bákarganj, partly because the Títulia is a less formidable river than the Meghna, but chiefly because the civil and criminal jurisdictions were thereby made conterminous, for the Munsif of Dakhin Shahbázpúr had always been subordinate to the Judge of Bákarganj. For many years, indeed, the munsif held his court on the mainland, in thana Mendiganj ; and it is only for about twenty years that his court has been held at Daulat Khan.

In 1863, or thereabouts, Kachua police station and that portion of Bákarganj which lay east of the Baleshwar were transferred to Jessore, and annexed to the newly-created subdivision of Baghahát.

In 1873 the area of the district was greatly circumscribed by the transfer to Faridpúr of the whole of the Mádaripúr subdivision, with the exception of thana Gournadi. On the other hand, a small portion of Faridpúr was transferred to Bákarganj, and included in Perozpúr. Unfortunately these changes were made after the completion of the census, and have thrown considerable confusion into its results.

At present the district of Bákarganj is divided into four subdivisions, as follows :—

Subdivisions.	Thanas.	Population of Subdivisions.
1. Barisál or Sadr . . .	Barisál, Gournadi, Nalchiti, Jhalukátti, Mendiganj, Bákarganj,	711,180 (?)
2. Dakhin Shahbázpúr . .	Daulat Khan, Barhanuddin Howaladar Hát,	221,037
3. Perozpúr	Perozpúr, Sarupkátti, Matbária,	363,426 (?)
4. Patuyakháli	Mirzaganj, Gúlsakháli, Khalsakháli or Galachipa,	418,747

The boundaries of the subdivisions are detailed in the "Calcutta Gazette."

Dakhin Shahbázpúr is the oldest of the four subdivisions, and indeed is one of the oldest in Bengal, having been established in 1845. It owes this distinction to its insular position, and to its importance in connection with the salt manufacture.

The Perozpúr subdivision was established in 1859. Its headquarters are somewhat unfortunately situated, as they are now on the extreme verge of the jurisdiction. Their position was more central before the transfer of Kachua and Morrellganj to Jessore.

Patuyakháli was established in July 1871. It includes the greater part of the south of the district.

STATISTICS OF CIVIL JUSTICE.

In 1873, 12,149 suits were instituted in the regular courts, and 12,746 were disposed of; 1185 were instituted in the Small Cause Courts, and 1201 disposed of. Value of suits instituted in 1873, Rs.1,152,451. The number of rent suits instituted was 7680, and of the Small Cause Court class of cases, 3675. Altogether there were 13,334 institutions, and 13,947 disposals in 1873. There were 49 suits for the enforcement of matrimonial rights. Of the 13,947 institutions, 3396 were withdrawn, compromised, &c.; 7401 were disposed of *exparte*, and 3150 were contested. 3540 decrees were wholly, and 8525 were partially, executed; and the total amount realised was Rs.427,233. 427 decrees were satisfied without execution, and Rs.25,113 realised.

There is a Civil and Sessions Judge at Barisál, and an additional judge visits it occasionally. In 1873 there were eleven munsifs employed in the district. The total cost of the Civil Courts for the year was estimated at Rs.128,525, and the realisations from stamps and court fees were 157,476, so that there was a surplus of Rs.29,000 (nearly). It must be remembered that Mádaripúr is included in all these statistics. There are generally two subordinate judges at Barisál. One or more munsifs are stationed at each of the subdivisions, and two or more at Barisál.

The average duration of contested cases before the munsifs is said to be three and a half months. (See High Court's Report on Civil Courts for 1873.)

STATISTICS OF REGISTRATION.

The number of deeds registered in Bákarganj is inordinately large, and in order to cope with it a number of rural registrars have been appointed. In 1873 there were altogether thirteen registration offices, and 25,200 deeds were registered affecting immovable property; 17,693 were deeds in which registration was compulsory, and 7517 in which it was approved. The total value of property transferred was twenty-three lacs, and the total amount of fees realised Rs.15,449. Of the compulsory deeds no less than 10,658 were perpetual leases, and 5123 were temporary leases. In the same year 2140 deeds affecting movable property were registered. The total receipts of the department were Rs.30,758, and the expenditure was Rs.19,625.

The above information has been taken from the Bengal Administration Report for 1873-74, and the tables there given show, moreover, that the receipts in Bákarganj were larger than in any other district, that the number of registration offices was greater than in any district except the Twenty-four Parganas, and that the number of compulsory registrations was greater than in any district except Chittagong. I must again remind my readers, however, that the figures include Mádaripúr.

SURVEYS.

The district has been trigonometrically surveyed, and there are now two towers in it—viz., one at Gangapúr in the Mendiganj thana, and another at Bháttra in Gournadi. There was a third at Khalishpúr, but it has been carried away by the river.

The revenue and topographical survey of the district was completed in 1863.

CHAPTER XIV.

POLICE SYSTEM.

This has already been touched upon in the chapter on the criminal administration. Bákarganj has been from the earliest times a troublesome district for the police; and the Magistrates' records are full of reports of crimes, and of the inefficiency of the efforts to stop them. It has been said in one account of the district that dacoity was put down in Bákarganj in 1814;[1] but this statement seems to have been premature, for later on a magistrate reports that there were at least thirty-one dacoities in the district in 1816. It is probable that our Hindu and Mahomedan predecessors had also trouble in putting down crime in Bákarganj, and indeed there are allusions to the prevalence of river-dacoity in the letters of the Jesuit priests who visited the country in 1599 and 1600. Two causes contributed to the existence and

[1] On 29th November 1814 the Government of India wrote as follows to the Court of Directors :—

"The Sunderbuns having been ordinarily regarded as the natural harbour of dacoits, it will be particularly satisfactory to your Honourable Court to observe the progress made in the suppression of gang-robbery in that part of the country. We cannot deny ourselves the gratification of transcribing the following passage from the letter of the Judge of Circuit on that subject: 'It does not occur to me as necessary to offer any further observations on the state of the Buckergunge district. It appears to be in that state of security from violent depredation which a few years back it would, perhaps, have been considered a vain hope that it could ever arrive at; and with respect to offences of other descriptions, they do not appear materially to prevail.'"—*Judicial Letter from Bengal, India Office Library.*

continuance of dacoity and other serious crimes in the district. In the first place, the district was in old times chiefly composed of jungle tracts such as the Sundarbans, &c., and it was therefore such an unpopular place of residence that almost no one resorted to it except criminals and men of bad character or desperate fortunes. Hence the district had to a certain extent a criminal population to start with; and these people continued and flourished in it, because the configuration of the country was eminently favourable to the commission of crime with impunity, and because it was at the same time the highway of communication between the eastern districts and Calcutta. In old times a strong force of patrol-boats was kept up in order to guard the rivers; and the records are full of suggestions from the Magistrates, the Courts of Circuit, and the Nizamat Adâlat about the best way of employing these boats, &c. In 1818 there were fourteen patrol-boats, with fourteen manjhis and 168 rowers—*i.e.*, there were one manjhi and twelve rowers to each boat. The manjhis got Rs. 4 a month, and the rowers Rs. 3, so that the monthly cost was Rs. 560.

In 1812 there were eleven thanas or police stations. The Magistrate's letter of 8th February 1812 refers to the establishment of a twelfth thana—viz., Mirzaganj—which shows that cultivation and population had been increasing in the south of the district. The same letter mentions that Gournadi was transferred to the Bákarganj district in 1807, and recommends that Nalchira—*i.e.*, I presume, the present Agarpúr outpost—be transferred to Mendiganj. In Mr Sutherland's account of the district an extract is given from a magistrate's letter, dated 20th February 1811, showing the names and positions at that time of the eleven thanas. The

list there given singularly illustrates the changes which have taken place in the administration, for the sites of six of the thanas have been changed since then, and a seventh—viz., Kachua—has been transferred to Jessore and reduced to an outpost.

The old police stations were all placed on the banks of the large rivers, as the chief object had in view was the suppression of river-dacoities. Inland places were thought to be less in need of protection, and were left to shift for themselves. I do not wish to pass the least censure on this arrangement, which was undoubtedly the best possible, and was also recommended by the fact that it was necessary that the police stations should be on the banks of rivers, as these were then the only means of internal communication. I would only observe, that as there were then no subdivisions, and not even any village chaukidars,[1] the zamindars and ryots must have been left very much to themselves, and that it is to their credit that they seem to have managed to get on pretty well together.

At present there are fifteen thanas and ten (?) outposts in the district. In the Barisál or Sadr subdivision there are six thanas—viz., Gournadi, Barisál or the Kotwali, Nalchiti, Jhalukátti, Mendiganj, and Bákarganj. Gournadi has been lately transferred to the Sadr subdivision from Mádaripúr. Its outpost of Agarpúr had been some time previously placed under the Barisál thana. Nalchiti and Jhalukátti are too near one another, but it is difficult and expensive to make alterations of sites. Mendiganj has under it the outpost of Srírámpúr. The station of Mendiganj is now at Pátarhát, but it has been proposed to remove it to Alliganj. Bákarganj, which is by the

[1] Mr M'Neil tells us in his report that there were no village chaukidars in Bákarganj in 1818.

country-people often called Angaria,[1] from the circumstance of the station's formerly having been there, has an outpost called Niamati.

Perozpúr subdivision contains the three thanas of Perozpúr (formerly Tagra), Sarupkátti, and Matbária. Perozpúr has subordinate to it the outposts of Nazirpúr and Bhandaria. Sarupkátti is a new thana, and is in part composed of the old thana Kewaria.

Patuyakháli contains the thanas of Mirzaganj, Gúlsakháli, Khalsakháli or Galachipa, and Baufal. Gúlsakháli contains the outpost of Phuljhuri, and Khalsakháli contains that of Chalitabunia.

Dakhin Shahbázpúr contains two thanas—viz., Daulat Khan and Barhanuddin's Hát—and the three outposts of Ghazipúr, Tamizuddin, and Taltali. The first two outposts belong to Daulat Khan and the last to Barhanuddin. These statements must, however, be taken with reservation, for the thana arrangements of the district have long been in a confused state, and I do not know if they have yet received their final adjustment. The Daulat Khan thana was formerly at Chandia, and hence the thana is often called by that name.

In 1873 there were 626 policemen of all grades in the district, and the total cost of the police administration was Rs.119,438. The force consisted of 1 district superintendent, 1 assistant-superintendent, 6 inspectors, 24 sub-inspectors, 76 head constables, and 518 constables. Two of the force were Europeans, 3 Eurasians, and 621 were natives of India. Divided according to religion, there were 16 Christians, 170 Mahomedans, and 440 Hindus. The above cost of the police is much greater than it was in old times; for instance, in 1805,

[1] Angaria seems an old name, and appears to be marked on De Blaev's map.

when Mr Gardner could report that the total cost of the police was Rs.33,361. But in those days there were no district and assistant superintendents, and no inspectors, scarcely any travelling expenses, and no officer, I believe, receiving more than Rs.15 or Rs.20 a month. The figures for 1873 also include the jail and treasury guards and their pay, and are for the district before the transfer of Mádaripúr.

In old times the constables, or *barkandazes*, as they were called, got only Rs.3 a month, now they get Rs.6 and Rs.7 and upwards, and the superior officers receive salaries ranging from Rs.10 to Rs.200 a month. Still it is true, I regret to say, that it is almost impossible for a policeman to live on his pay. The expenses of living and travelling have greatly increased, and at the same time so much more is expected of the police.

Undoubtedly the police system is the opprobrium of our administration, and I fear that it will continue to be so. A larger expenditure of money would do much to improve matters, especially in the direction of supplying the inferior police with adequate means of locomotion; but even this would not do everything. The number of village chaukidars in Bákarganj in 1873 is said to have been 5172, and their emoluments to have been Rs.186,192. There are municipal police in Barisál, Nalchiti, Jhalukátti, Perozpúr, Baufal, Bákarganj, and Daulat Khan.

In 1873 there were 5793 cases cognisable by the police reported. 2952 were declared false, and only in 596 were convictions obtained. In the same year there were 8031 non-cognisable cases: processes were issued against 6077 persons; 3220 appeared, and 1910 were convicted. The proportion of convicted to the population was about 1 to 1244.

The number of arrests by the police in 1873 was 1504, and by orders of the Magistrate 1405. 1426 persons were convicted by the Magistrate, and 100 by the Court of Sessions. 1202 were acquitted by the Magistrate, and 108 by the Court of Sessions. Percentage of acquittals was about 46. In the same year Rs.28,765 worth of property was stolen, and Rs.6002 recovered.

There were twenty cases of murder.

The return of unnatural and accidental deaths in 1873 is as follows: Suicides, 61; drownings, 622;[1] snake-bite, 217; tigers, leopards, &c., 52; alligators, 48; other causes, 67:[2] total, 1042.

[1] The greatest number of cases of drowning are of children, and take place in the moats which surround the homesteads. Cases of drowning and also of snake-bite are most common in the rains.

[2] Of "other causes," 10 were lightning, and 28 falls from trees.

There were also during the year 64 cases of homicide, and five persons were hanged.

CHAPTER XV.

THE JAIL.

The jail was originally at Bákarganj, the old head-quarters of the district, and for some time was under the Naib Nazim, who managed it through a *faujdar*. The oldest letter in the Magistrate's office (27th October 1792) refers to the prisoners confined by the Naib Nazim, and the next oldest, dated 23d November idem, enjoins that the prisoners should be supplied with blankets. The jail was situated on the banks of the Srimantapúr or Bákarganj creek, a little higher up than the cutcheries, and a small stream which flows into the creek here is still known by the name of the Jailkhana khál. It appears from a petition of one Panchanand Datt of Rangasri, forwarded by the Board of Revenue on 17th April 1802, that Mr Lodge, the Judge, had built a jail on his taluq of Bista Narain Datt in 1193 B.S. (1786), but I presume this was only a civil jail. On 3d April 1793 Mr Middleton, the Magistrate, was called upon for a list of prisoners suitable to be sent to the Andamans. By this time the Magistrate had charge of the jail under the control of the Nizamat Adâlat. From a letter of the Nizamat Adâlat, dated 15th October 1795, it appears that the prisoners had been deprived of the use of tobacco, but that as the want of it had proved injurious, they were to be allowed to have it again. The jail at Bákarganj proved very unhealthy, and Mr Wintle

mentions in a letter of 7th September 1801 that 242 prisoners had died in it in the last twelve months. He does not mention what proportion this bore to the number who were confined during the year, but it must have been about one-third, as he states that the number of the prisoners at the time he was writing was 750. The jail was a thatched one, and was of course insecure. There are two letters from the Nizamat Adâlat, dated 23d April and 15th May 1795, about the tattooing of prisoners, and directing that this should be done on the forehead. Only the life-prisoners were tattooed, and the object was to facilitate recapture in the event of their escape. The jail was removed to Barisál in 1801. A *kacha-paka* jail—*i.e.*, a jail with a thatched roof and brick walls—was erected there by the Magistrate, Mr Gardner, in 1804. It was flued, was surrounded by an outer wall, had a bomb-proof dungeon, and was calculated to hold 800 prisoners, and yet only cost Rs.2302-5-9. The amount sanctioned for its construction was Rs.3681-3-7. The lime with which it was constructed was brought from Sylhet. The following description of the jail is given in the estimate: "Account of expenses attending the erection of a foujdari jail at Barisál zila, Bákarganj, consisting of apartments for 800 prisoners, packa-walled, well raised and flued, an infirmary very highly raised, completely packa, beamed and terraced, a bomb-proof dungeon, and two guard-rooms, the whole enclosed with a surrounding packa wall twelve feet in height, and four packa sentry-boxes at the corners thereof." This jail, however, did not last long, or at least was found insufficient, for in 1812 the prisoners broke out and burnt the roof, and in 1817 the jail was replaced in whole or in part by a masonry building, erected under the superintendence of Mr Gardner, the

Civil Surgeon. The amount sanctioned for its construction was Rs.35,119. It was reported to be completed on 20th September 1817, and the surrounding wall was finished in the following year. In a report of Mr Lee Warner (the Magistrate), dated 18th April 1818, it is stated that the criminal jail was built in 1816, the surrounding wall in 1818, the hospital in 1811, and the magazine in 1802. The prisoners seem always to have been more numerous in the early days of our administration than they now are. Probably this was owing to the greater number of dacoities in those days, and to the more ready seizure of suspected persons. Something also was due to the delay in the jail-deliveries, owing to the Judges coming on circuit only once a quarter. In 1806 Mr Oswald writes that there are seldom fewer than from 800 to 900 prisoners in confinement. This was on 1st February, and on 12th July of the same year the Magistrate writes that the jail is not capable of containing more than 700 prisoners, and there are above 750. In the same letter he speaks of an additional jail which is to be built, and which, like the present, will have the walls of brick and mortar, and the roof thatched. The number of persons imprisoned for debt was much greater formerly than now, when indeed the civil jail is often altogether empty. In 1806 the Magistrate writes that there are seldom *more* than sixty or eighty persons in the debtors' jail. On 7th May 1807 an estimate is given for repairing the jail. Bundles of straw are estimated at Rs.4 a thousand, and bamboos at Rs.3 a hundred. On 15th May 1819 there were as many as 982 prisoners in the jail, and the Magistrate considered that it was capable of holding 2000. In 1873 the average strength of the jail, including the lockups, was only 520, of whom only 6½ were females. It must be remem-

bered, however, that the number of prisoners in the Bákarganj jail is now systematically kept down by transfers, and that no life-prisoners are allowed to remain in it. Prisoners were occasionally transferred in old times, and I find that in February 1809 two hundred were sent to Dacca, but there were no rules on the subject, and probably they were only sent away when there was an unusual pressure. The prisons also were for a long time burdened with the life and long-term prisoners who had been sentenced by the Nawab Nazim, and as late as 25th June 1819 a list had to be made out of such prisoners.

The prisoners used to do their own marketing, and for this purpose they were paid in cowries, which were distributed by a *poddar* monthly, and for which he was reimbursed at the current rate of exchange (31st December 1811). He got a daily list of the prisoners before he distributed the diet-money. On 26th April 1820 the poddar is described as getting two puns of cowries per rupee as his remuneration. In 1805 the allowance to each prisoner was three puns of cowries, or about three-fourths of an ana, each day. Some remarks appear to have been made about the allowances to the prisoners being excessive, and on 15th August 1805 Mr Oswald writes as follows: "The observations of the third Judge of the Murshidábád Court of Circuit, regarding the cheapness of living and the low wages of labour in that division, do not appear to me applicable to this station, where the ordinary or average price of rice is fourteen anas a maund, of sixty sicca weight to the seer, and where the wages of the most common labour are in general six puns, and never less than five puns of cowries per diem. Allowing each convict one and a half seers of rice a day, of the above-mentioned weight, or forty-five seers a month, it will be found that his expenditure in the article of

rice alone amounts to fifteen anas a month—rather more than two-thirds of his whole allowance. With the remaining third he has to purchase fuel and cooking utensils to dress his victuals, a little salt to season them, and to provide himself with clothing."[1] In the year 1811 the total cost for the prisoners' food was Rs.9253-15-4 (sicca).

From a letter written in 1809 in appears that previous to that date there was no separate accommodation for females.

Apparently the prisoners were chiefly employed in road-making, and in a letter written in 1815 it is said that prisoners were not formerly exempted from labour on the Sundays.

On 16th February 1812, at 11·15 A.M., there was an outbreak in the jail, in which Mr Battye, the Magistrate, nearly lost his life, and was only saved by the devotion of his subadar. (At that time both the jail and the treasury were guarded by a detachment of the Provincial Battalion.) The prisoners set fire to the thatched roof of the jail and attacked Mr Battye. The subadar flung himself in between the Magistrate and his assailant, and was cut desperately over the head. The subadar, the havildar, five sepoys, and one barkandaz were wounded, and twelve prisoners were shot before the riot could be quelled. In the newspaper account of the great cyclone of 1822, published in Mr Sandeman's "Selections," it is said that the prisoners were released on the second day afterwards for want of food. From the official reports, however, it appears that this statement is incorrect.

[1] In 1803 it is reported that 4000 kahuns of cowries were required each month for the prisoners, and that they had to be collected from all parts of the district.

The land originally taken up for the jail and for the Provincial Battalion, and which is still in the possession of Government, lies in the middle of the Barisál town, and amounts to about nine kanis, or between forty and fifty bighas. It is held on a permanent lease from the Rahamatpúr Chakrabarties, and the rate of rent is only Rs. 5 a kani, though the land is worth very much more at the present day. The Rs. 5 are sicca, and the old rent in sicca rupees was Rs. 45-5. It is now Rs. 48-5-4. The police lines are situated on this land, and another portion is let out to householders, and yields about Rs. 96 a year. Another small portion in a corner of the jail garden has been let to a shopkeeper as a woodyard for Rs. 48-5-4, so that in reality the jail site may be considered as rent-free.

The Barisál jail has always been damp and unhealthy. This is partly owing to its position, and partly to defects in its construction. It is nearly surrounded by a tidal khál, and the water is close to the surface throughout the jail compound. The amount of garden-ground is also very limited. It is a curious fact that the proper mode of building a jail for Bákarganj seems to have been best understood when the first one was built, and to have been lost sight of afterwards. At least the hospital, which was built in 1811, if not earlier, is by far the driest building in the jail, a circumstance which is due to its being raised on arches, through which the air can freely circulate. Of late a good deal has been done to improve the jail, and the erection of double-storied wards and of arched floors has been commenced. Some solitary cells have also been built. The jail has three lockups attached to it—viz., those at Perozpúr, Patuyakháli, and Daulat Khan, though the prisoners from the last have been temporarily sent to Noakháli.

The prisoners are employed in brick-making, in weaving, and in making mats and chairs, but there is nothing special in the industries of the jail. The great majority of the prisoners are Mahomedans.

In 1873 the average daily number of prisoners was 520. This, however, includes those in the subdivisional lockups. The average mortality for the ten years ending 1873 was 12·22 per cent., which of course is very high.

CHAPTER XVI.

EDUCATION.

I CANNOT pretend to treat of this important subject as it deserves, and must refer the reader to the educational reports, &c., for fuller information. The first attempt, I believe, to introduce English education into the district was made by the Magistrate, Mr Garrett, about 1830. Mr Sherring, however, in his "History of Protestant Missions," says that a school was established at Barisál by the Serámpúr missionaries in 1829. The lease for the present site of the Barisál school was obtained by Mr Sturt in 1842, and the school was made a Government institution a few years later. The school is what is called a higher English school, and is a very good one of its class. It has an average daily attendance of 278 boys. There is a vernacular school adjoining it. There is also a so-called higher class school at Basanda, but it does not really prepare boys for the entrance examination. Basanda is a small village about two miles from Jhalukátti; and it would be better if the school were removed to Jhalukátti, and the latter made the seat of a deputy-magistracy and of a munsif's court. There is a middle-class English school at the headquarters of each subdivision, but I do not think that any of these can be said to be in a very efficient condition. The best of them (and the remark is also applicable to the Barisál school) is still more or less of an exotic, for it is

mainly attended by the children of professional men, who are only temporary residents in the neighbourhood. Altogether, there were in the year ending 31st March 1874, 365 schools under inspection in the district, and 12,110 pupils, so that about 7 per 1000 of the population were at school. The number of Hindus was, however, disproportionately larger, for though they only form about a third of the population, there were (in round numbers) 7500 Hindus at school, against 4600 Mahomedans. This, of course, is in great measure explained by the fact that the Mahomedans chiefly belong to the poorer classes, and are least numerous in the towns and bazárs. Something, however, is due to Mahomedan pride and apathy, and to their preference for a home education and Arabic studies.

Female Education.—This has made very little progress as yet. There is a pretty good girls' school at Barisál, and there are one or two in other parts of the district, but they have not yet taken firm root. In some of the primary schools girls and boys are taught together. Hinduism, Mahomedanism, and early marriage are commonly said to be the great obstacles to female education, and I have no wish to deny their influence. I am sorry, however, to say that the Feringhi Christians of Sibpúr are almost as unwilling to send their daughters to school as any Hindus are. No doubt the difficulty of getting about, especially in the rains, is a great drawback to the success of schools, and, physically speaking, the children are perhaps better at home. Of late years a great stir has been made about primary education, and many new *patsalas* or primary schools have been established, and many old ones have been subsidised. No doubt good has been done, and the very

agitation of the subject has had a quickening effect on the bucolic mind; but in the south of the district, where 80 per cent. of the inhabitants are Mahomedans, the experiment has been a failure. The peasants do not care for education; and besides, they need their children to gather their betel-nuts, to row their boats, and above all to herd their cattle.

The worst of the change which has been effected is that in very many cases the villagers have given up paying fees to the village teacher, as he now gets paid by Government. In fact, therefore, the teacher's position has not been improved, there having been only a change of paymasters. The fact is, I believe, as I have stated it, and I confess that it is one for which it is not easy to see a remedy.

The accompanying table, which is taken from the inspector's report, gives many particulars of the state of education in the district in 1873–74. In the same year the receipts, including grants from provincial revenues and Rs.9872 of subscriptions, were Rs.44,941, and the expenditure was Rs.44,280.[1]

[1] The early state of Bákarganj in regard to education is described in Mr Adam's Report on Education in Bengal, 1835.

Return of Schools and Students in the Backergunge District for 1873-74.

Class of Institutions.	Government Institutions.										Aided Institutions.										Unaided Institutions under Inspection.										Grand Total of Institutions.	Grand Total of Students on the 31st March 1874.	Grand Total of—			
	Number of Institutions.	Number of Students on the Rolls on the 31st March 1874.	Average Daily Attendance.	Number of Students on the 31st March learning—			Religion of Students as on 31st March.				Number of Institutions.	Number of Students on the Rolls on the 31st March.	Average Daily Attendance.	Number of Students on the 31st March learning—			Religion of Students as on 31st March.				Number of Institutions.	Number of Students on the Rolls on the 31st March.	Average Daily Attendance.	Number of Students on the 31st March learning—			Religion of Students as on 31st March.						Christians.	Hindus.	Muhammadans.	Others.
				English.	A Classical Language.	Vernacular only.	Christians.	Hindus.	Muhammadans.	Others.				English.	A Classical Language.	Vernacular only.	Christians.	Hindus.	Muhammadans.	Others.				English.	A Classical Language.	Vernacular only.	Christians.	Hindus.	Muhammadans.	Others.						
Normal Schools—																																		
For Masters	1	22	14	...	...	22	...	15	7	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	1	22	...	15	7	...
For Mistresses ...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...
Schools of Art.																																		
Other Technical Schools.																																		
Schools for Boys—																																		
Higher English ...	1	381	278	381	81	...	6	349	26	...	1	56	40	56	29	...	...	56	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	2	437	6	405	26	...
Middle English ...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	14	1071	778	511	91	486	...	1015	56	...	4	233	153	100	...	133	...	203	36	...	18	1304	...	1218	86	...
Middle Vernacular	3	112	82	...	...	112	...	41	71	...	27	1446	1070	16	1	1429	...	1319	127	...	4	179	149	...	...	179	...	163	13	3	34	1737	...	1523	211	3
Lower Vernacular ...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	235	6678	4548	...	513	6492	8	3203	3464	3	69	1852	1155	...	57	1842	...	1047	805	...	304	8530	8	4250	4269	3
Schools for Girls—																																		
For Natives	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	3	35	26	...	...	294	...	35	...	...	3	45	23	...	...	45	...	45	...	...	6	80	...	80	...	...
For Europeans and other foreign races ...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...
Total ...	5	515	374	381	81	134	6	405	104	...	280	9286	6462	583	634	8701	8	5628	3647	3	80	2309	1480	100	57	2199	...	1458	848	3	365	12,110	14	7491	4599	6

CHAPTER XVII.

ROADS AND COMMUNICATIONS.

Sabhi Khan (see p. 48) was probably the first road-maker in the district. His roads, or jangáls, as they are called, are to be found in the northern and north-western parts of the district, especially in thanas Gournadi and Kotwalipara (now transferred to Faridpúr). They were very broad and high, and though now broken and even obliterated in many places, they are still used by the country-people. A section of one of these may be seen near the Palardi police station, and it has been made part of the modern road from Barisál to Gournadi.

Sabhi Khan was in all probability a man of energy and public spirit, and I have no wish to depreciate unduly his merit, or that of the other Mahomedans of like stamp who made roads in Bengal in the old days of the Moghal empire. I am not sure, however, that the decay of his roads is not a proof of the comparative uselessness of merely individual effort, and of the evanescent character of improvement for which the time is not ripe. I suspect that Sabhi Khan's jangáls would never have fallen into decay if they had been really wanted. At least it is difficult to see how they could become covered with jungle if people were daily in the habit of traversing them. Probably many of the old Mahomedan roads were made for military purposes, and their usefulness ceased when these purposes had been

accomplished.[1] It is but fair to notice that Sabhi Khan, on making his roads, appears to have made provision for the physical and spiritual wants of wayfarers, for he dug tanks by the roadside at Sabhi Khan's Pár and elsewhere, and he erected a handsome mosque at Ramsiddhi. Of course I cannot positively say that the tanks and mosque were made by him, for natives have a habit of ascribing every improvement to one distinguished man.

Major Rennel in his "Memoir on Roads in Bengal" has given a list of routes in Bákarganj, and his map (republished by Colonel Gastrell) shows a road passing from Bákarganj to Kótarhát, Sutaluri, Gournadi, and then across the swamps to Khulna and Maxadpúr. No doubt this route is in part composed of Sabhi Khan's jangál, but I suspect that much of it was merely a track across country, and only open in the cold season, or rather just before the rains; for thanas Gournadi and Kotwalipara, and indeed Bákarganj generally, are most traversable in the months of April and May. Kótarhát is now a deserted place, but the name seems to imply that it was once a place of importance, and there are remains of an old road (now repaired) which led from it to Bákarganj in the days when the latter was the headquarters of the district. In old times there was a munsif's court at Kótarhát. Sutaluri, as the name implies, was an old seat, I believe, of the weaving or of the thread trade. It is situated on the road from Barisál to Jhalukátti, and is near Gurudham. It still contains some ornamented ruins, and there is a *mat* or funeral monument in it, which, though the top has

[1] One great cause of the destruction of the Mahomedan roads was the absence of sufficient water-way. Lime and skilled labour were scarce, and hence, though large bridges were put up here and there at important places, there were few or no culverts, and the height of the earth-way was the chief thing relied on for resistance to the floods.

fallen off, is still, I believe, the loftiest structure in the district.

The oldest roads made during the English administration were probably those leading from Bákarganj to Sibpúr, and to the Golabari and Kótarhát. The Sibpúr road is about five miles long, and still is in tolerable repair, and has several bridges. The headquarters of the district were removed to Barisál in 1801, and the oldest road in that neighbourhood, I believe, is one which led from Barisál to a market (now deserted) known as the Khazanchi's (treasurer) Hát. It is about four miles long, and has been repaired, and is now known as the Dapdapia road. It is part of the road to Bákarganj. The road from Barisál to Madhabpásha (about seven miles) is also an old one, and is due to the liberality of a Hindu lady (Parbati Chaudharine).

The following remarks on roads, &c., in Bákarganj appear in a volume entitled "East India Affairs," and printed by order of the House of Commons, 1819: "The nullahs and ditches which intersect the town of Barisál require deepening to admit the tide and carry off the stagnant water. The only road about the station has been lately repaired, and the prisoners are now engaged in making bricks to lay on it. A road is intended to be made near the station, by which much jungle will be cleared. A road from Barisál to Gournadi, which is on the route to Dacca, would be very advantageous, merchants being at present prevented from resorting to Barisál from apprehensions of the risk attendant on navigating the large rivers between it and Dacca."[1]

The road which Mr Sage desiderated so long ago has

[1] Mr Sage, in Appendix E to Superintendent of Police's Reports, 15th May 1816, p. 239.

only recently been made. It is very useful for foot-passengers, but is not adapted for carriages. None of the district roads, indeed, are readily traversable by carts, and it is not necessary that they should. The rivers will always furnish the readiest mode of transporting heavy goods. There are perhaps some forty or fifty carts in or about Barisál, and there are a considerable number in Dakhin Shahbázpúr (where the ryots use them to bring home their grain from the fields), but, speaking generally, there are no carts in Bákarganj. The numerous rivers and kháls in the district, and consequently the great number of ferries or expensive bridges required in order to make the roads suitable for carriage traffic, are a most insuperable obstacle to the making of carriage-roads.

The road to Gournadi goes *viâ* Lakutia, and consists so far of a very good road, made by Ram Chandra Rai, zamindar of Lakutia. This same gentleman also made a very good khál for boats alongside of the road. The other principal roads are Barisál to Jhalukátti, Barisál to Nalchiti, Barisál to Bákarganj, and Barisál to Táltolli.

Of subdivisions, Dakhin Shahbázpúr is the one which is best supplied with roads. There are a road and canal across the island from Bhola to Daulat Khan, and there are footpaths to Ghazipúr, Dhaniya Maniya police station. In Perozpúr subdivision there is a towing-path, and a road from Kumarkháli to Raierkátti. In Patuyakháli there are no roads, except a footpath for a few miles along the bank of the Patuyakháli dōn.

It has often been said that every man in Bákarganj has his boat, and that roads are not required. This, however, is a mistake. It is very far from being the case that every ryot has his boat, and even those who have, often find it much quicker and easier to walk than

to row against the tide, &c. Women and children also often travel, and they neither have boats nor can they afford to hire them. The amount of walking which is done in the district is in fact very great, especially in the dry season. In some large tracts of the district—the island of Dakhin Shahbázpúr, for instance—there are no rivers, and consequently hardly any boats, and nearly everybody walks. Roads, then, are wanted in the district, but they should be merely raised footpaths, and, above all, the kháls which intersect them should be bridged. For this purpose wooden bridges, and even bamboo bridges, are quite sufficient. The number of bamboo bridges, or *chárs*, as they are called in the district, is very great. Every village has two or three, and in some parts every homestead has one.

Towing-paths also are much required, especially on the highway from Barisál to Calcutta, and I am glad to say that these have been in part supplied. There are no towing-paths in the Sundarbans, and navigation there is almost entirely dependent on the tides.

Not much has yet been done towards the canalisation of the district. However, channels have been made from Bhola to Daulat Khan, and from Barisál to Lakutia. The Jhalukátti khál has been deepened, &c.

Now that the road cess has been introduced in the district, we may expect that many canals and roads will be made.

The Government ferries are Rahamatpúr, Dwarika, and Shikarpúr, on the road to Gournadi; Jagua, on the road to Nalchiti; and Kalijiri, on the road to Jhalukátti. There are also ferries at Perozpúr station, and between Daulat Khan and Hattia, and Tamizudin and Manpúra. The Barisál town ferry belongs to the town committee. There are numerous private ferries.

CHAPTER XVIII.

BARISÁL.

Barisál, the largest town in the district, and the seat of the principal courts, is situated on the right or west bank of the Barisál river,[1] and is 183 miles nearly due east from Calcutta, and about 75 miles south of Dacca. It is, however, only accessible by water from either of these places, and the voyage from Barisál to Calcutta occupies from four to seven days, and from Barisál to Dacca about three days. Barisál did not become the seat of the courts till 1801, but Rennel's map shows that it was a place of some consequence many years before that time. I have also quoted in another chapter a remark of Mir Kassim, which shows that Barisál was an important salt *chauki*, or place where the salt tax was paid, in the middle of the last century. In Rennel's time the town seems to have been confined to the south side of the Jailkhana khál. The town is composed of the five villages of Barisál, Bogura, Amanatganj, Alikandi, and Kaunia. The village of Barisál is a very small one, and lies in a pargana of its own called the Gird-i-Bandar, which appears to have been formed out of pargana Chandradwip as a site for the bazár. The English church and the principal public offices are situ-

[1] I believe the proper name of the river is the Kirttankhola, though I never heard it called so.

ated in Barisál proper. These offices consist of the civil and criminal courts, the Collectorate, the registration office, &c.

The present dimensions of the town are of recent origin, it having been enlarged with the view of making it a more suitable basis for the registration of vital statistics, and also in order to increase the collections from the taxes. Formerly only portions of some of the five villages I have named were included in the town, but now they have been entirely incorporated. This has given a survey boundary for an arbitrary one, and has enabled us to know the area of the town with some exactitude. From the survey papers it appears that the area is nearly six square miles (5 square miles, 588 acres). The population within these limits appears to be 13,332, including 1124 of a boat population. The population therefore is very sparse for a town, being only about 2000 to the square mile, or about four times the prevalent rate (482 to the square mile) in the district. The fact is that great part of the so-called town consists of scattered villages, interspersed with trees and gardens, and even rice-fields. In truth it may be said that, with the exception of the bazár, every house in Barisál is more or less a *rus in urbe*. I believe that the towns in other Bengal districts are similarly constituted. When, therefore, it is justly stated in the Bengal Administration Report for 1872-73 that "the absence of large towns is one of the most remarkable statistical features in Bengal," and reference is made to "Rangpúr, the capital of the great district of Rangpúr, containing only 6100 souls, and to Jessore 8152, each of these districts having a population of over two millions," these facts, extraordinary as they are, do not bring out the whole singularity of the case. For even these petty

towns have their populations distributed over wide areas, and are "half town and half country."

More than half of the inhabitants of Barisál are Mahomedans, and the other half are Hindus, with the exception of about 150 Christians. The place has no manufactures and no trade, except that it is to some extent an entrepôt for cloth from Calcutta, which is distributed from Barisál over the district. There are one bazár and two markets, one for fish and one for general produce. The latter is held on Tuesdays and Saturdays. Barisál is a calling-place for steamers, and its river is navigable by them all the year round. It contains an English church (built in 1845), a Baptist chapel, a Brahma Samaj meeting-house, three *akras* — namely, two of Madan Mohan and one of Jagannath—five *kalibaris*, and five *manashas*, though only one of the latter is in a separate building. The Mahomedans have one mosque and three or four places of prayer. There are a charitable dispensary, established in 1847; a public library, founded by Mr Kemp (now a Judge of the High Court) in 1855; a large civil and criminal jail, &c. There are a very good English school,[1] a vernacular school, a normal school, a girls' school, and one or two *pátsálas*. There are two printing-presses—viz., the Purna Chandrodai and the Satya Prakásh. Four newspapers are published at it—viz., the "Barisál Bártabaha," the "Hitsadini," the "Bala Ranjika," and the "Satya Prakásh." There are a burial-ground for Christians, one for Mahomedans, and a burning ghât for Hindus.

The town is largely occupied by the professional classes, such as pleaders and attorneys, and their servants.

[1] The present schoolhouse is, I believe, an escheat to Government. It was formerly inhabited by Dr Spencer, who committed suicide in it on 20th July 1836.

They are only temporary residents, and hence at times, when the courts are closed—such, for example, as the Durga puja holidays—the town is almost deserted. As the pleaders and shopkeepers do not make the town their home, there are comparatively very few women in it, and even of these a large proportion are professional prostitutes. This puts the climax to the facts above mentioned about the paucity of towns in Bengal, and shows how the genius of the people is opposed to agglomeration in great centres; for not only are the towns few in number and small in point of population, and that too not closely packed together, but there is hardly any home-life in those parts of the towns, such as the bazár, &c., where houses are contiguous enough to form streets.

The affairs of the town are managed by a town committee appointed under Act 6 of 1868 (Bengal Code). There are 3042 holdings, and these, for taxation and other purposes, are arranged in ten wards. The income of the committee is about Rs.7000 a year, Rs.6000 of which are derived from the tax on houses (at the rate of three anas a month), Rs.600 from the town ferry, and the remainder from the cattle-pounds, proceeds of fishing licences in the tanks, &c. The committee also generally receive a grant from the road fund. In 1814, 522 houses were assessed to the chaukidari tax, the monthly collections were Rs.65, and there were 17 chaukidars. In 1819 there were only 378 houses assessed, and the monthly collections were only Rs.46 (M. 28, 5, 19). There were then 13 chaukidars at Rs.3 a month, and a dafadar at Rs.6. In 1820 there were 1316 houses in the town (M. 4, 7, 20). In 1826, 564 houses were assessed. The Magistrate's cutchery was not finished till 1830, and previous

to that time the Magistrate held his court in his own house, and got an allowance of Rs.40 a month on this account (M. letter, 1826). In 1827, Rs.1500 were given by Government and Rs.925 subscribed for improvements in the town, and some tanks were dug in consequence, &c. I do not know when the present Barisál band was made, but it is mentioned incidentally by Mr Chapman, in a letter dated 22d May 1819, that he had left court at about 5 P.M., and that on returning from his ride he was walking on the bank of the river with three other gentlemen. The letter I have quoted describes a mutiny which had arisen among the sepoys of the Provincial Battalion owing to one of their number having been put in irons.

On 25th February 1833 the Magistrate refers to the bad repute of Barisál for unhealthiness, and says that a fire which occurred in the town showed by removing the houses the bad state of the sanatation. The town now has tolerably wide and straight streets, and clearly it owes them to English influences, for natives, when left to themselves, have no idea of keeping highways clear of houses.

Barisál has for a considerable time been diluviating, and it appears that within the last twenty years about a third of the bazár portion has been washed away. There is a report of 6th December 1854 on the subject, and there is a map, made in 1857, and now in the possession of the town committee, which shows, by comparison with the present state of the town, the amount of land which has been carried away.

CHAPTER XIX.

GENERAL REMARKS.

On reviewing the history of Bákarganj for the last eighty years, it seems impossible to deny that some improvements have been effected. Gang-robbery has been in a great measure suppressed, and the cases which still occur seldom exhibit the circumstances of atrocious cruelty which used to characterise the crime. Widow-burnings have ceased, affrays have become less frequent and less bloody, and the wrongful confinement of the peasantry and other acts of high-handed oppression have become comparatively rare. The rights of landlords and tenants have been defined, extensive tracts of country have been brought into cultivation, and trade and population have largely increased. School education has been introduced, and has made some progress; and there has been, I think, some change even in the character of the people, who no longer deserve the sweeping terms of reprobation employed by Mr Wintle in 1802.

As regards the cause of these improvements, I think that every unprejudiced person must acknowledge that they are mainly due to the introduction of the English Government. That this has been the chief cause seems evident from the fact that it is the only important change which has taken place in the country during the last two hundred years. If, then, the English Government has not been the cause of the improvements which

we see, why did they not occur at an earlier period? If other things were the same then, and the form of government was not worse, why was it that much of the country was a jungle, that the rivers and creeks were full of piratical boats, and that life and property were everywhere insecure?

It is natural that enthusiastic Bengalis should regret the days of their native kings, when Bákarganj was ruled by a Rajah of Chandradwip, and Jessore had a prince who was powerful or audacious enough to dispute the supremacy of the Emperor of Delhi. But, in sober truth, there seems little reason to regret the extinction of any of the Hindu dynasties. Taken at their best, they seem to have been chiefly beneficial to idle Bráhmans, and other unproductive classes. There is no evidence that any one of the Chandradwip Rajahs was a man of superior ability or virtue; and we know that one of them was insane, and that the last lineal representative of the family was an ignorant voluptuary. Pratápáditya, the King of Chandecan or Jessore, and the most famous and powerful of the so-called "twelve suns of Bengal," seems, from his biography, to have been a brutal tyrant who fell into his proper place when his conquerors shut him up in an iron cage.

We may also remind our Hindu friends that nine out of the twelve above-mentioned luminaries are described by the Jesuit priests as being Mahomedans. Until lately we had a good illustration of the working of a petty Hindu kingdom in the native state of Kuch Behar. The Rajah of this little country was not, it is true, independent after the treaty with the British Government in 1773, but he enjoyed considerable freedom of action, and we may judge from the way in which he used it how he would have acted if he had

been totally uncontrolled. Now it was my fortune some years ago to be stationed at Kuch Behar for many months, so that I had an opportunity of studying its history in the old records, &c., and I can confidently state that the condition of the worst-administered district in Bengal is better than that of Kuch Behar under its native Rajahs. The most famous of the ancestors (Harendra Narain) of the present Rajah, and the one who, I am sorry to say, seemed to be most highly thought of by the native amlah, was a debauchee and a murderer, who only escaped punishment from the unwillingness of the Governor-General of the day to interfere in the internal affairs of the country. Not many years ago there was a native Rajah of Jyntia in Sylhet, and he lost his territories (in 1835) partly from long misgovernment, and partly because he was believed to have connived at the kidnapping of four British subjects for the purposes of a human sacrifice. Another Rajah with whom I was acquainted, and who, though not really independent, claimed certain privileges and the possession of a quasi-sovereignty over the neighbouring hill-tribes—I refer to the Rajah of Susang in Mymensing—made use of the latter in his quarrels with other zamindars, and tried to screen them when they had committed a diabolical outrage on a Bengali household, and had murdered a whole family—man, woman, and child—of fifteen or sixteen persons.

One of the best-known instances of a modern Hindu kingdom in Bengal is the territory which used to be known as Independent Tipperah, but which is now officially designated Hill Tipperah. There is now a political agent at Agartolla, the capital of the state, and things have perhaps improved, but some years ago Tipperah was the resort of all the fugitives from justice

belonging to the neighbouring districts. I remember also that when, some fifteen or sixteen years ago, a boundary dispute was decided against the Rajah, and a tract of country which he claimed was declared to belong to the district of Sylhet, he revenged himself by burning the villages in question, and by carrying off the inhabitants into his own dominions. Another instance of a Hindu, or at least a semi-Hindu state, is to be found in the country of Manipúr, and I can testify from personal observation that things are not in a very flourishing or progressive state in that territory.

With more reason the Mahomedan part of the population, and even the inhabitants generally of Eastern Bengal, may regret the days of the Nawabs and their deputies, for there was a vigour and a power of organisation among the Mahomedan rulers which were wanting among the Hindu princelings. We see the difference between them in the way in which they treated the Arracanese invasion. The Hindus were unequal to the contest, and fled under the pretext of avoiding contamination; the Mohamedans, on the other hand, took the more manly course of grasping their nettle, established themselves at Dacca, where the danger was greatest, raised and maintained a fleet, and swept the rivers and their estuaries clear of the Arracanese and the Portuguese pirates. Bengalis, indeed, and especially those of Eastern Bengal, have much reason to be thankful to the Mahomedans, for it is to them that they owe in great measure their preservation from the Burmese. But for the conquest by the Mahomedans of Sandwip and Chittagong, it is probable that much of what is now known as Eastern Bengal would have been a portion, and a deserted and despised portion, of the kingdom of Arracan or Burmah.

It must be admitted, also, that Eastern Bengal (though not that part of it which forms the district of Bákarganj) has declined in importance, if not in prosperity, since the English conquest. Dacca is no longer the seat of a great trade, and presents the melancholy appearance of a decayed city. Various reasons may be assigned for this, but the principal one of course is the destruction of the weaving interests by the importation of Manchester goods. English power also was not always as beneficent as it now is, and there was a time when our English laws, and still more our English desire to make rapid fortunes, wrought sad havoc in Eastern Bengal. This was the time of the outrages and tyrannies at the Bákarganj bazár referred to in a former chapter, and which exhibited what Lord Macaulay has called "that most frightful of all spectacles, the strength of civilisation without its mercy." This probably was the most unhappy period in the modern history of Bengal. There were abuses under the Hindu rulers, and also under the Mahomedan governors, but we suspect that the thirty years before the Permanent Settlement were more acute in their misery than any which had gone before. It says much for the vigour of our Government that we have been able not only to heal the wounds inflicted in that terrible time, but also to raise the body politic to a higher stage of health and wellbeing.[1] Perhaps some

[1] "It must give pain to an Englishman to have reason to think that since the accession of the Company to the Dewanny, the condition of the people of this country has been worse than it was before; and yet I am afraid that the fact is undoubted, and I believe has proceeded from the following causes: The mode of providing the Company's investment; the exportation of specie, instead of importing a large sum annually; the strictness that has been observed in the collections; the endeavours of all concerned to gain credit by an increase of revenue during the time of their being in situations, without sufficiently attending to what future consequences might be expected from such a measure; the errors that subsist in the manner

will say that I am attributing too much importance to administrative action, and they may be disposed to remind me of the dictum of Mr Buckle, that governments can do but little towards the advancement of a country. But, in the first place, if the fact really be that Bengal owes much of its progress to the English administration, it cannot be set aside in favour of the notion of any individual writer, however eminent; and secondly, I think I can show that there is no contradiction in the matter. Mr Buckle, in saying that governments have not done much for civilisation, is not referring to governments composed of foreigners. He begins his arguments by the following remark: "In the first place, we have the obvious consideration, that the rulers of a country have, under ordinary circumstances, always been the inhabitants of that country, nurtured by its literature, bred to its traditions, and imbibing its prejudices. Such men are at best only the creatures of the age, never its creators. Their measures are the result of social progress, not the cause of it" (vol. i. p. 250).

It is plain, therefore, that his argument does not apply to the case of our Indian Government. He would not, I think, have denied that it might exercise great influence over the civilisation of Bengal, any more than he would have denied that the Roman or the Norman government of England had powerfully affected the condition of that country.

of making the collections, particularly by the employment of *amils*. These appear to me the principal causes why this fine country, which flourished under the most despotic and arbitrary government, is verging towards its ruin, while the English have really so large a share in the administration." (Extract of letter of Mr Becher to the President, dated 24th May 1769, quoted by Sir Philip Francis in a paper printed at p. 931 of the Ninth Report of the House of Commons. See note about famine of 1770 in Appendix for a notice of Mr Becher.)

Two circumstances in the progress which Bákarganj has made under English rule appear to me to be deserving of attention. The first is that the non-official Englishman, or interloper, as he used to be called, has had very little to do with it. I do not mean to say that the district has not been largely influenced by Calcutta merchants, nor that English literature has not produced a perceptible effect on its educated classes. I only wish to point out that hardly any non-official Englishmen have resided in the district as indigo-planters or traders, as has been the case in the neighbouring districts of Farídpúr and Jessore. Opinions will differ about the effect of the absence of these classes, and some will think it has been a great loss to the district. Still it cannot be denied that the peasantry of Bákarganj, or, in other words, four-fifths of the population, are at least as comfortable as those of Jessore or Nadiya, and that they have therefore done very well without indigo. For my own part, I consider that Bákarganj is to be congratulated on its escape from a class of residents who were not subject to the same laws as the rest of the community.[1] Almost the only non-official English residents whom the district has had have been the Baptist missionaries, and they did not enter it till 1830. Their influence has been almost entirely confined to its north-west corner, but there it has, I think, been very beneficial. At least I am sure that the presence in the district for many years of a man so simple and gentle-hearted as the late Mr Sale must have done good, and I know that he was esteemed by all the natives who knew

[1] At the time of the Indigo Commission (1860) Morrellganj was included in Bákarganj, and Mr Morrell's evidence (answer 2390, p. 234) gives a curious picture of the abhorrence which his ryots had for the cultivation of indigo. The same evidence gives some interesting details about the cultivation of the Sundarbans.

him. His predecessor, Mr Page, was a man of much vigour and energy, and exercised great influence over his flock.

The second circumstance is that few if any of the Bákarganj officials appear to have been men of great ability, and that none of them has left any deep impression of himself on the district. Mr Douglas, who made the Permanent Settlement, was a man of exceptional breadth of view and humanity, and Mr Massie seems to have been energetic and able; but they lived at Dacca, and were thus too far away to exercise much influence. None of the other early Magistrates or Collectors appears to have risen much above mediocrity, and there is at least no one who stands out in the manner in which Mr Westland has made Messrs Henckell and Rocke to stand out in the early history of Jessore; though, indeed, even with regard to Mr Henckell, one has a suspicion that he was more energetic than prudent, and that his schemes for the reformation of the salt administration, &c., ended in failure. Certainly his plan for cultivating the Sundarbans appears to have brought loss to Government, and to have embroiled him with the zamindars.

The names of the older officers have quite gone out of the memories of the Bákarganj people. The name of Mr Battye, who was Magistrate in 1811, survives officially from his having built a bridge, and from an outbreak in the jail having occurred in his time. It appears also from a letter of the Court of Directors that he was very successful in putting down dacoity. Mr Chapman, who was Magistrate in 1819, is remembered from his connection with the burial-ground, which appears to have been formed by him, and from his name having been given to a tank which is said to yield the best drinking-water in Barisál. Mr Garrett was

an active and public-spirited officer, and is remembered for the improvements he made in the town, and for his having assisted in the formation of the first English school. The name of Mr Shawe, who was Magistrate in 1845, and who at a later period became Judge of Sylhet, is remembered on account of his activity in road-making, and of his having built the English church; while his contemporary, Mr Sturt, is remembered for the extravagance of his entertainments, the defalcations which occurred in his treasury, and above all, perhaps, for the great *éclat* with which on one occasion he had the Kali puja celebrated in the bazár as a means of averting the cholera.

Another officer (Mr Morris Beaufort) is remembered on account of his having sentenced a notoriously oppressive zamindar to a term of imprisonment, and then compelled him to work at the road leading from the Magistrate's house to the cutchery. The path is to this day known by the name of Nil Kanth Rai's road.

Perhaps the names which linger longest in the memories of the people are those of the Settlement officers, for they are intertwined with their dearest interests. I have referred in another chapter to the great fame in the eastern districts of Sir Henry Ricketts. Similarly Mr Dampier's name will long remain in the island of Sandwip on account of his settlement of it, while that of his assistant, Sir Frederick Halliday, is remembered in Noakháli for his settlement of the island of Hattia, &c.

In Bákarganj one of the most noted names among those of Settlement officers is that of Mr James Reilly, who settled the large Government estate of Tushkháli, and who was in fact Collector of the district during the incumbency of Mr Reid.

Of late years I do not know that any name has been more widely known among the people than that of one who was never anything higher than an uncovenanted Deputy-Collector and Deputy-Magistrate. I refer to the late Babu Dinu Bandhu Maulik, who held office in the district for several years, and acquired a great influence over the people. He left the impress of himself on nearly every department of the administration, but was especially famed as a good police-magistrate. So useful was he that he never could get leave of absence, and I think it is not too much to say that his premature death, when only about thirty-four years of age, was in a great measure owing to overwork. Curiously enough this man, who was so popular with the natives, and who also did so much good service, was far from being esteemed by some of the higher authorities, and more than once narrowly escaped dismissal.

In the above review I am, of course, only speaking of officials. If I were to mention non-officials, there are at least two who have exercised more influence than any judge or magistrate. I refer to the Mahomedan preachers named Keramat Ali and Dudhu Mia. The name of the latter is widely known, and he and his father, Shariyat-oolah, may be called the founders of the sect of Ferazis. Dudhu Mia's character, however, was stained with vices, and I am not prepared to say that his influence has been beneficial. On the other hand, from all that I have heard, Keramat Ali, who was a native of Juanpúr, was a man of a very pure and disinterested character, and did much good by preaching sound morality. He has certainly exercised much more influence over the common people than Keshab Chandra Sein, and I should think that he was the truer and more modest man of the two.

Religion.—The mention of these two men brings me to the consideration of religion, and of the possibility of the country's ever becoming Christianised. At present, as we have seen, two-thirds of the population are Mahomedans, and I cannot say that there seems any likelihood of their soon throwing off the shackles of their faith. Some might even say that there is an appearance of their wishing to draw them tighter, for Feraziism is undoubtedly a puritanical movement, and an endeavour to return to the supposed greater strictness of the primitive Church. But such movements may indicate fear rather than strength, and may testify to a dying out of Mahomedan faith, just as the spread of Ultramontanism is significant of the vogue of infidelity. However, the great body of the peasantry seem to be still sincerely attached to their religion, which after all does not interfere much with their life, nor call upon them for any important sacrifices, except in the month of fasting. Singularly enough, the educated Mahomedans do not exhibit any signs of scepticism, and appear to reverence their Koran almost as much as their more ignorant brethren. If the fact be so, it is not a little strange, for the Koran is, at least in Sale's translation, such an unintelligible and wearisome book, that it is difficult to imagine how any intellectual person can believe it to contain a divine message. The number of educated Mahomedans, however, is very small, and I have had little opportunity of judging of their real sentiments. It may be, therefore, that free-thought has made more progress among them than I am aware of.

Among the Hindus the prevailing worships are those of Kali, or Durga, and Vishnu. The worship of Siva is comparatively rare. The common people are considerably addicted to idolatry, and are fond, especially the

womankind of them, of worshipping sacred trees, &c. I have seen a tree near Sarupkátti almost covered with hair, which had been hung up by parents in fulfilment of vows that if their child recovered they would cut off his hair, and make a votive offering of it to the tree, or rather, I suppose, to the goddess who was believed to reside there. The educated Hindus have for the most part lost all faith in their religion, and are deists or atheists. Many of them reject the doctrine of a future life. The organisation of the Brahma Samaj, however, is not making much progress, and many Hindus seem inclined now to draw back and to return to the customs of their country, even where they are tinged with idolatrous associations. Christianity is not making any progress in the district, and I do not see the least likelihood of its ever becoming the prevalent religion. Although there is an English church at Barisál, there is no resident clergyman, and the spiritual wants of the members of the church are attended to by the Dacca chaplain, who visits the place once a quarter. It is to be hoped that in time the principle of disestablishment will be at least partially carried out in Bengal, and that people who are so very "churchy" that they cannot enter a Baptist chapel will not be indulged at the public expense in their exclusivism.

Considerable as has been the progress of the Bengal districts under English rule, it would doubtless have been much greater under more favourable circumstances. Probably the frequent changes of officers have been the greatest obstacle to improvement. A gentleman who has resided in Barisál for about five-and-twenty years tells me that during that time he successively served under twenty-four Collectors of the district and nine Commissioners of the division. Bákarganj has been

worse off in this respect than other districts, for it has generally been disliked as a residence, and therefore most officers who have been appointed to it have tried to get away as soon as possible. Other districts, however, have not been much more fortunate. Dr Taylor, in his "Topography of Dacca," tells us that "from the year 1781 to 1839 fifty-nine civil servants have filled the office of magistrate, but of this number thirty have only been in temporary charge; the average duration, therefore, of each Magistrate's appointment has been two years, the longest period four years and twenty-seven days. The number of Collectors for the same time was thirty-seven; twenty of this number have been acting Collectors: the longest period for which a permanent Collector has held office is six years and forty-five days." Nor is it only the Collectors and Magistrates who have been frequently changed. Transfers have been quite as rife among the subdivisional officers, the deputy-magistrates and deputy-collectors, the police officers, &c. At one time the Board of Revenue went so far as to pass an order that no native ministerial officer should remain in the same district more than three years. The result of this notable order (which was passed with the idea of diminishing corruption) was that poorly-paid natives were driven from their homes, and subjected to much expense and inconvenience, and that hardly any one remained in a district office who had local experience, or who could help his newly-arrived Collector out of a difficulty. At length, after much heart-burning and distress had been occasioned, and after the efficiency of many offices had been crippled, the Board were pleased to place the order in abeyance, though I am not aware that it has been formally cancelled. Attempts have been made of late years to diminish the frequency of transfers,

but they have not been very successful, and in fact the inherent difficulties of the matter are too great to admit of the hope that they will ever be overcome so long as the administration is in the hands of foreigners.

In the report on the administration of Bengal for 1872–73, Sir George Campbell writes as follows: "It must be admitted that in the inferior grades of the service, covenanted and uncovenanted, permanency has not yet been attained. The present leave and service rules are so favourable to change, the varieties of climate and of amenities or disamenities in Bengal stations afford such temptations to seek change, the habit of going frequently to Europe has so much grown among the European servants of Government, and so many of the native servants so persistently strive by every device to avoid and get rid of out-of-the-way and disagreeable stations, that it is very hard indeed for those who administer so great a government with such a mass of Government servants to hold its own against so many who, for one reason or other, seek change. So many interests are set in motion, that it is a matter of extreme difficulty to avoid the necessity of making several changes when a vacancy occurs before things settle down. It is, in fact, a sort of game of chess, as it were, in which the Government is very unequally pitted against a great many players, and it is hardly possible to give to each move the attention and the calculation of contingencies which is necessary to avoid being taken at a disadvantage by one or other of them. The Lieutenant-Governor has been, he may say, shocked to find how many changes have occurred during the year among the subdivisional and other subordinate officials of some districts, in spite of all his struggles to avoid change."

In the above extract the Lieutenant-Governor deals

only with changes among the subordinate officers. But the changes among the heads of great departments are nearly quite as frequent, and are more injurious to the public service. The Governors-General, the Lieutenant-Governors, the Judges of the High Court and of the District Courts, and the Commissioners follow one another in rapid succession, and hence there is great want of stability in our administration.

One effect of such frequent changes is to give an air of grandeur and solidity to everything in the country which is permanent. Victor Hugo somewhere remarks, that whatever was the real character of Louis XIV., he acquired a semblance of greatness from the mere length of his reign, and from his thus presenting an appearance of immobility amidst the revolutions and changes of the kingdoms around him. In like manner, amidst the incessant flux of our administration, the inert Bengali landowner, living from youth to age in his ancestral home, and distributing a rude and unequal justice among his tenantry, or the village watchman going the rounds of his native hamlet year after year, forms a not unimposing picture of steadiness and uniformity.

The moral which these facts teach seems to be, that we should endeavour to place the internal administration of the country as much as possible in the hands of natives. And in doing so, we should, I think, not only appoint Bengalis to appointments in Bengal, but should, other things being equal, give the preference to inhabitants of the district, and even of the subdivision, in which the vacancy occurs. Bengal cannot afford to be administered by foreigners, and the inhabitants of one part of India are often almost as much foreigners in

another part of it as Europeans are. A Bengali of Nadiya or Hughli will not serve in Eastern Bengal for less than Rs.200 a month, but the same man would gladly take office near his home for one-half of this amount. Already we have made a commencement towards localising the administration by choosing our rural registrars from among the inhabitants of the registration circle, and it only remains to give them magisterial powers. Of course this can only be done gradually, and on proof of the fitness of each officer to discharge judicial duties. The system of appointing honorary magistrates, and of thus making zamindars and others discharge the duties of country justices of the peace, has been lately revived in Bengal, and has had some good effect. I think, however, that it will not become really successful until more confidence is placed in the gentlemen selected for the duties, and they be not absolutely debarred from trying cases occurring in their own estates. At present the more property a zamindar has, the less useful is he as an honorary magistrate, because the fewer are the cases in his neighbourhood which he is supposed competent to try.

Interesting attempts have of late been made to develop municipal institutions, and to form what have been called village communes. And there is no doubt that this is eventually the direction which reform in Bengal will assume. The days of individualism and personal government seem to be over in that country. We have got beyond the days of the strong man of Carlyle and the Panjáb, who is to put everything to rights by a glance of his eye. Personal government of this kind may do very well among the hill tribes and in some other parts of India, but it is quite out of date in

Bengal.[1] A late Lieutenant-Governor, who was endowed with rare energy and quickness, but who came to Bengal with notions derived from less-advanced parts of India, made a vigorous attempt to establish personal government; but though his intensity, and still more the strength of his position, enabled him to make himself felt in the remotest villages of his government, yet no permanent effect was produced. Many of his measures have been silently abandoned or changed by his successor; and it seems to me that, great as Sir George Campbell's abilities undoubtedly were, the chief good effected by his administration was the demonstration it afforded of the hopelessness of any merely individual attempt to counteract a national will.

No doubt it seems melancholy to some that the days of hero-worship are over. They have trusted that some great man would deliver them and their country from the evils under which they laboured, and have been disappointed that he has not come. Tennyson has expressed this sentiment of sadness at the growing greatness of the world in the passage where he speaks of the

[1] "While I admit that the abridgment of discretion by written laws is to some extent an evil—though, under the actual circumstances of India, an inevitable evil—I do not admit the proposition which is sometimes advanced, that the natives of India dislike the abridgment of official discretion. This assertion seems to me not only unsupported by any evidence, but to be contrary to all the probabilities. It may be allowed that in some cases discretionary government is absolutely necessary; but why should a people, which measures religious zeal and personal rank and respectability by rigid adherence to usage and custom, have a fancy for rapid changes in the actions of its governors, and prefer a regimen of discretion, sometimes close upon caprice, to a regimen of law? I do not profess to know the natives of this country as well as others, but if they are to be judged by their writings, they have no such preference. The educated youth of India certainly affect a dislike of many things which they do not care about, and pretend to many tastes which they do not really share; but the repugnance which they invariably profess for discretionary government has always seemed to me genuinely hearty and sincere."—*Maine's Village Communities*, Appendix I. p. 215.

individual withering and of the world becoming more and more.[1] But, in fact, the complaint is a somewhat idle and querulous one, and need not seriously disturb us. True it is, that as the world advances, its dependence upon any individual man becomes less and less; but when we consider the shortness and uncertainty of human life, this is a motive for rejoicing rather than for sorrow. It is better that nowadays, if a great man die, he leaves five hundred as good as he, than that, as when Charlemagne or Akbar died, there should be no one to fill the void. Nor need we fear that the individual must *wither*, for the world is made up of units; and no assemblage of withered individuals, however great, will ever make a prosperous world. If, then, the world is to wax greater and greater, as apparently it will, individuals must rise higher and higher, though at the same time the absolute importance of any one of them must diminish.

Although we feel assured that some reform in which the whole country takes a share must be the ultimate remedy for Bengal, and that comparatively little can be done by individuals, yet it is not easy to predict the form which the change will take. Some have thought of reviving the village system; but, in fact, this is a system which never had a vigorous existence in Lower Bengal, and is now altogether decayed. The village system, of which we hear so much, may work well in Madras and the North-Western Provinces, but in Bengal it seems to be an anachronism. Besides, it is a Hindu institution, and therefore we cannot expect it to flourish

1 "Knowledge comes, but wisdom lingers, and I linger by the shore,
And the individual withers, and the world is more and more.
Knowledge comes, but wisdom lingers, and he bears a laden breast
Full of sad experience, moving toward the stillness of his rest."

The words are those of a man who has been soured by disappointment and treachery, and are quite appropriate in his mouth. We need not take them to be expressive of the poet's own sentiments.

in Mahomedan districts such as Bákarganj and the other districts of Eastern Bengal. Villages in Bákarganj are very different from villages in the North-West, or even in Western Bengal. The houses in them are not grouped together, and there is little feeling of companionship among the different householders. The old village boundaries have also been obliterated in many cases by the formation of chars or by diluviation. There is certainly nothing in them which corresponds to the organisation which we read of in Elphinstone. There is no village accountant or village barber, nor even was there originally any village watchman, for the last is the introduction of the English Government, and was unknown till the last fifty or sixty years. And the village watchman, or chaukidar, as he is called, bears traces of his being a new institution; for we often find that he does not even live in the village he is supposed to guard, and it is with great difficulty that he ever gets his pay from the villagers.

"In Backergunge the villages are more scattered and less defined than in Jessore and Faridpúr; indeed in many parts are not defined at all, each villager having ordinarily selected as the site for his house the spot which appeared to him to be most eligible in relation to his agricultural pursuits, and wholly without reference to any future village community. This want of definition became a source of great difficulty when compiling the map of the district in the Surveyor-General's office. It was often impossible to say whereabouts to fix the dot or other conventional mark to designate the village." —*Gastrell's Report.*

Nor is there any feeling of local patriotism or of fellowship among the inhabitants of the same village. The village is in most instances of too recent origin, the

houses are too scattered, and ryots migrate too readily from one village to another to admit of the growth of such feelings. Bráhmans and other non-agricultural classes live for generations on the same homesteads; but, as a general rule, the tenancy of cultivators is of short duration, and I think that if the ryots of a village were interrogated, it would be found that most of them had been settled in it for less than twelve years. Some villages are chiefly inhabited by one caste or profession. Thus Kalasgram is full of Bráhmans, Banaripara is full of Kayasts, and Baukátti has for generations been celebrated for the number of its thieves. But, as a general rule, the inhabitants of a village are a heterogeneous assemblage, and have few ties with one another. At least one-half of them are generally Mahomedans, and the remainder is composed of Hindus, who again are subdivided into castes and *dals* which do not intermingle. The land of a village does not belong to the village community, nor are there any waste or pasturage lands in which all the villagers and *no others* can share. The occupancy right in each plot generally belongs to a ryot, but the rights of receiving rent, &c., are generally held by some taluqdar or zamindar who often lives a great way off.

These last rights are not always or even generally vested in one man, so that the inhabitants of a village have frequently different landlords and different rates of rent. In fact it may be said that they have often nothing in common except contiguity of residence, and even this does not always exist, for the houses in a village are often an hour's journey apart from one another.

Within certain limits the people of Bákarganj are great travellers, and at all events they cannot be

described as never losing sight of their native village. The absence of railways or steamboats prevents them from undertaking distant journeys, but they frequently visit the headquarters of their district to look after their lawsuits, to consult their landlord's agent, &c.

Their relatives and friends are widely scattered, and the facilities for locomotion afforded by the numerous rivers and the general possession of boats are so great, especially during the rains, that they spend much time in paying visits either with or without their wives and families. Thus a man will have his home in one pargana, his father-in-law's in a second, his son-in-law's in a third, and almost innumerable uncles and cousins—*dharam-pitas* and *dharam-putras*—scattered over the country. Every now and then one of his friends or relatives gives a feast, and as the Bengali ryot is generally only accountable to himself for the employment of his time, and is not a labourer paid by the day, there is nothing to hinder him from accepting the invitation, or from spending two or three days in a jaunt with his wife and children. Owing to the scarcity of land in the more populous parts of the district, and to the possession of herds of buffaloes, &c., it is no uncommon thing for a ryot to have two homesteads. In one he lives with his wife and family, and the other, called his *do-alia bári*, he visits during the cultivating season, and often inhabits for two or three months at a time.

For all these reasons I think it will be impossible to make the village the unit of administration, and that it will be necessary to take something wider, such as the thana or the registration circle.

Destruction of Wild Animals.—There is one improvement which I think might be accomplished without

great difficulty, and which would be of great benefit to the people. I refer to the destruction of tigers, leopards, crocodiles, and other wild animals. I have often wondered that the British India Association, or the People's Association, or some other of the societies which Young Bengal delights to form, has not taken in hand a work so simple and so clearly useful. A very moderate amount of organisation and of expense might suffice to stamp out the plague of noxious animals in most districts of Bengal. In Bákarganj the greatest number of deaths by carnivorous animals is caused by crocodiles, and yet, strange to say, no reward is ordinarily allowed by Government for their destruction. There is said to be a tribe of men in the Dacca Division whose peculiar business it is to harpoon crocodiles, and as Government has not thought fit to undertake the task of extirpation, I think that the wealthy zamindars of the division could not do better than employ this tribe to do so.[1] Tigers and leopards are numerous in Bákarganj, but it is somewhat surprising to find how few human beings are killed by them. They are principally destructive to cattle and goats. Yet it would be a great mistake to suppose that because tigers and leopards only kill a few men in the year, their ravages are not very injurious to the community. We cannot measure the harm they do by the number of human beings whom they kill or wound. The distress and panic which they cause, and the obstruction which they offer to the performance of

[1] The chief sufferers from alligators are women and children, who are struck down by them (the alligator is said to knock them down with his tail) when bathing or when fetching water, and who have not the strength or the presence of mind to recover themselves. It is very rarely that Europeans are carried off by them. Colonel Wilford, however, mentions ("Asiatic Researches," vol. xiv.) that Mr B. Plaisted, one of our early surveyors, was carried off in the Sundarbans by an alligator, which he mistook for the rotten trunk of a tree.

work, are evils of much more general consequence. Thus a tiger may perhaps kill only one man in a village, but the terror which he produces will spread over a whole pargana, and prevent people from travelling at night, delay postal communications, &c. So the fact of a crocodile's being seen in a reach of the river, or of his having carried off, or attempted to carry off, any one from a ghât, will produce uneasiness among thousands of bathers, and of women who have to come daily to the river to draw water. In matters of this kind it is the indirect effects which are most serious. The direct injury inflicted by a dacoity may not be very great, but the indirect effect may be to paralyse the trade of a large bazár.

We may apply this consideration when reflecting on the benefit which the British Government conferred on the country by the abolition of satí. When we look at the returns of widow-burnings from the various districts, the surprising thing, perhaps, is not that there were so many cases, but that there were so few. In Bákarganj, in the year of the cholera (1825), when upwards of 25,000 persons died in a few months, the total amount of satís was only sixty-three. It is evident, therefore, that the great majority of the Hindu widows abstained from the rite. But this must not make us conclude that its abolition was of small consequence. The real evil of it, perhaps, was the sickening dread which every Hindu wife, and all who loved her, must have felt whenever her husband was ill, or even when she was given in marriage. And, perhaps, worse than even this must have been the loss of self-respect felt by every Hindu widow who could not bring herself to submit to being burnt.

Wild pigs are extremely destructive to the crops, and

I am sorry to say that some Englishmen have been selfish enough to try to prevent the peasantry from killing them. Of late years the sport of pig-sticking has been revived in the district of Dacca, and I have been creditably informed that the Commissioner and the Magistrate deprived many of the native shikaris or sportsmen of their guns, on the pretext, indeed, that there was danger of their being used in affrays, but really lest the pigs should be killed, and the sport of the gentlemen thereby interfered with.[1]

Much loss of life is caused by snake-bite, and as no remedy against the poison has yet been discovered, it is probable that the only thing to be done is to endeavour to extirpate snakes. This, however, is obviously a more difficult and expensive work than the extirpation of tigers and crocodiles. Government already has moved in the matter, and a small reward is given in certain places for the killing of the cobra de capello.

Note to General Remarks.

As I have said that Bengal cannot afford to be administered by foreigners, it may perhaps be supposed that I am one of those who advocate the immediate abandonment of India by Great Britain. Such, however, is not the case. I have a great respect for Dr Congreve, and I

[1] A correspondent of the "Times" gravely objected a year or two ago to the destruction of tigers, on the ground that it interfered with sport! This reminds us of Gibbon's note about Commodus and the African lions: "The African lions, when pressed by hunger, infested the open villages and cultivated country; and they infested them with impunity. The royal beast was reserved for the pleasures of the emperor and the capital; and the unfortunate peasant who killed one of them, though in his own defence, incurred a very heavy penalty. This extraordinary *game law* was mitigated by Honorius, and finally repealed by Justinian." Bad as this was, it was less exclusive in its selfishness than the behaviour of some of our modern sportsmen, for the lion-fights gave pleasure to a whole capital.

presume every one must admire a man who has made such sacrifices as he for his convictions, but I think that the time has not yet come for the step he recommends. Granted that we wrongfully got possession of India, still to abandon her now would be to act like a man-stealer who should kidnap a child, and then in a fit of repentance abandon him in a tiger-jungle. I think that we should look forward to the time when India can be left to herself, and that we should hasten its coming by putting the internal administration more and more into the hands of natives. For example, probably nearly all the judicial offices in Bengal might be held by natives. They will work for less pay than Europeans, and their knowledge of the language and customs of the people, and their not requiring long furloughs to Europe in order to recruit their strength, give them an immense advantage over foreigners. I do not overlook the advantages possessed by Europeans, but I think that none of them counterbalances the superiority of the Bengalis in the above-mentioned points.[1]

I would suggest also that no more appointments should be made to the India Civil Service as at present constituted, or at least that the number should be greatly restricted. Those who are already in the service must be provided for in some way or other, but I think that the Government is only making additional embarrassments for itself by bringing more young men into the service. Already some of those admitted complain that they have been enticed by false pretences.

[1] Another advantage which is perhaps of even greater moment, is that by employing natives, Government can get the services of men of mature age. It does not seem fitting that extensive judicial powers should be exercised by persons under twenty-five or thirty years of age.

APPENDIX.

(A.)

I.—Four Settlement Reports from the Collector of the Dacca District, dated 6th April, 5th and 26th May 1790, and 31st July 1792.

To the Honourable Charles Stuart, President,
and Members of the Board of Revenue,
Fort William.

Gentlemen,—I have the honour of your letter of the 18th ultimo, transmitting for my information and guidance a copy of the Resolution of his Lordship in Council respecting the future settlement for Bengal for the period of ten years, and directing that I proceed with all practicable despatch to make the settlement of the district under my charge in the manner and agreeable to the principles therein laid down.

You also enclose for my information extract from your letter to his Lordship in Council, alluded to in the 7th article of the Resolutions, and containing your opinion relative to the amount of the jamma realisable from my district, founded on the information with which you were supplied by my predecessor, Mr Day, in answer to your circular letter of the 10th August 1787, directing me to refer thereto in the formation of the ensuing settlement as far as the suggestion therein contained conform with the Resolution of his Lordship in Council now communicated to me.

You further enclose me copies of your Resolutions, and those of his Lordship in Council, to the Collectors of Bazhai regarding the ganjes, bazárs, and hauts held within them, to which you desire my particular attention, as well as my answer to the several queries therein stated.

You also desire I will notify to the landholders, by publishing the same at the several cutcherries of my district, that the ensuing settlement for ten years, if approved by the Court of Directors, will

become permanent, and no alteration take place at the expiration of that period.

I shall, in obedience to your orders, commence on the Ten Years' Settlement with the least possible delay.

As Government's motives for concluding a Makarrar jumma dus salah is to secure to the Honourable Company a certain fixed revenue on fair and equitable rates, and to afford ease and give confidence to the landholders, their under-renters, and ryots, I think it a duty I owe my employers, myself, and the proprietors of the lands, and those under themselves, early to lay before the Board my sentiments on the orders transmitted me.

By the extract of your letter to his Lordship in Council, dated the 14th October 1788, to which the seven articles of his Lordship's Resolution alluded, it should seem that in forming the ensuing settlement I am to be guided in fixing the jumma of each mahal by Mr Day's plan of settlement of 1195, which accompanied his letter of the 17th January 1788.

However unwilling I am to animadvert on Mr Day's proposed plan of a Ten Years' Settlement, yet a regard for my own character, and from a perfect conviction that I cannot conclude the settlement with many of the mahals at the jumma recommended by him, impels me to deliver my sentiments freely on the subject, relying on the Board's candour for putting a favourable construction on the motives by which I am actuated.

It is necessary to observe that Mr Day did not send down his proposed plan of settlement for upwards of six months after this district had been visited by the most dreadful calamity ever remembered by the oldest inhabitant of the district, and which deprived it (by Mr Day's calculation) of upwards of 60,000 of its inhabitants, who either miserably perished, or were reduced to the painful necessity of forsaking their habitations in search of a precarious subsistence. Mr Day visited some of the pargannahs where the famine raged with the greatest violence, and had ocular proofs of the extreme misery to which the wretched inhabitants were reduced. He saw the pargannahs inundated, whole crops destroyed, and cultivation totally neglected. He had the mortification of beholding hundreds of the poor wretched inhabitants daily dying without the means of affording them the smallest relief. After a local investigation of the cruel effects of the inundation, after a full conviction of the very heavy loss many of the principal pargannahs sustained both in its inhabitants and crops, and the consequent decline of cultivation, it is a matter of great surprise that Mr Day should, in many of the pargannahs which had suffered so materially by the inundation and loss of tenants, recommend an increase to be taken in the ensuing year's settlement. That gentleman observes that his plan was founded on the idea of a Ten Years' Bandobast; admitting of this, can it be supposed that districts which had been deprived of one-half of their natural resources, could in the short period of one year so far recover as to yield the customary revenue, much less bear an

increase, which would have added to the miseries they had already suffered, and in all probability have obliged the remaining ryots to desert their habitations and seek refuge in more favourable districts?

I shall now proceed to point out to the Board those pargannahs which I am well satisfied cannot bear the jumma of 1194, but where even an abatement on the present year's assessment will be absolutely necessary in some of them.

1194. *Pargannah Rajnagar.—Jumma, Rs.*97,194-15-17-3.

This pargannah Mr Day visited in person, and in his letter to your Board under date the 20th December 1787, reporting on the state of the district and the effects of the inundation, observes that this pargannah presented such a scene of distress as he never before beheld, the land being then totally inundated, the country not showing the least appearance of cultivation, and the inhabitants in general being on raised stages. He at the same time expresses his apprehension that Government was likely to experience a very heavy loss at the close of the year in consequence of the late calamity.

Notwithstanding the wretched state in which Mr Day found this pargannah, yet he recommends in his proposed plan that the settlement be concluded for 1195 on the jumma of 1194.

The Board acquiesce in Mr Day's proposal, and direct him to conclude the settlement accordingly.

The Collector in consequence called upon the proprietors to enter into engagements on the proposed terms, but they positively declined, saying, "to engage at the rate of 1194 for the pargannah of Rajnagar and Kartikpoor would be subjecting themselves to a very considerable loss, from the absolute inability of the lands after the calamity which attended them during the last year."

In consequence of the zemindars declining to lease their lands on the terms of 1194, the Board direct the pargannah to be advertised for farm, and the settlement of 1195 to be tendered to the proprietors at the amount of the highest offer.

The pargannah was accordingly advertised for farm, but no offers being tendered, the Collector on the 4th of September 1788 transmitted the proposals of the zemindars for leasing it on an abatement from the jumma of 1194 of Rs.36,404.

The Board observe in their reply, under date the 23d of September, that "the offer of the proprietors of this mahal being extremely disadvantageous—being a deduction from the jumma of last year of no less a sum than Rs.36,404—we cannot accede to it. We authorise you, however, to make an offer of it to the proprietors at the remission Rs.8934 from the jumma of 1194, that in the event of their not accepting of it, the mahal be held khass."

The proprietors having refused to enter into engagements on the proffered terms, the mahal was held khass; and to show that it was little capable of yielding the jumma of 1194, I must observe

that Government sustained a loss of Rs.47,272. This balance even exceeded that incurred in 1194, which amounted to sicca Rs.45,179.

It will probably be remarked that the settlement has not been concluded this year on the jumma of 1194. This I acknowledge, but I must beg leave to observe that an abatement of Rs.8934 was allowed in Bozergomedpore, and a further sum of Rs.13,791 in Kartikpore, both mahals dependent on Rajnagar; but the latter sum cannot be considered as an abatement on the jumma of Rajnagar, for supposing Kartikpore to have been the property of another person, a similar deduction must have been granted in consideration of the dreadful calamity it experienced in 1194. So that, in fact, the abatement allowed last year on account of Rajnagar was the remission of the increase laid on Bozergomedpore in 1194, being, as before stated, Rs.8934; and the late Commissioner's report will show that this abatement was very inadequate to the heavy losses sustained in the pargannah in the two preceding years both in its crops and inhabitants, and nothing but the apprehension which four of the proprietors entertained lest the proposals made to your Board by Kebal Ram, the remaining proprietor, would have been accepted, could have induced them to have entered into engagements on such high terms. They were fearful, in the event of Kebal Ram getting possession of the land, that he would have continued in the entire management and control of the zemindari in the same manner as his brother Gopal Krishna had done, by which means they would have been totally excluded from all participation or concern in the lands.

I have every reason to apprehend that a balance will be incurred at the close of this year of at least Rs.25,000. That the zemindars have collected more than they have paid into the Government treasury is beyond all doubt, but the amount appropriated by them for their maintenance does not amount to 5 per cent. on the jumma of the zemindari. The profits of their private lands, from the best information I have received, do not exceed Rs.15,000, and this profit enjoyed by two of the proprietors only to whom they appertain.

By his Lordship's instructions the zemindars are to enjoy a profit of 10 per cent. from their lands. The proprietors of Rajnagar will cheerfully relinquish their lands on these terms rather than engage on the jumma of 1194. They are men of rank and family, and have long been in the habit of living splendidly; and should they engage on the jumma of last year, the whole of the profits arising from the niz taluks will not be sufficient to answer the dues of Government; and as the proprietors have no other resources than their lands, they must, if deprived of a moderate profit from such land, be reduced to extreme indigence, and would be under the disgraceful necessity of disposing of their lands for a subsistence. For these reasons, and in order to secure a certain revenue to Government, I would recommend that an abatement of Rs.20,000 be allowed in the jumma of Rajnagar for three years, and at the expiration of which the same be resumed on a rusud jumma of three years.

1194. *Pargannah Kartikpúr.—Jumma, Rs.*25,791.

This pargannah forms a part of the zemindari of Rajnagar. Mr Day, in his proposed plans of settlement, recommends that an increase of Rs.4000 be laid on this pargannah, observing that he had no doubt of the ability of the lands to this addition without subjecting the renters to any additional tax above what they have paid for some years back to the zemindars.

Had my predecessor adverted to his letter under date the 20th December 1787, written about a month prior to the transmission of his proposed plan of settlement for 1195, I humbly conceive he would not have recommended the above increase, for in describing the state of the pargannah he makes the following remarks: "This mahal, I am sorry to inform the Board, has suffered in an equal degree with that of Rajnagar, to which it is contiguous, and is under charge of the same sazawal. The balance due from it to the end of Kartik is Rs.11,200, in part of which I much fear very little will be realised, as the only sources left in the pargannah for the liquidation of this, as well as the remaining kists, are the boro crops and the produce of betel-nut, which, from the proportion I am informed they bear of the pargannah resources, will scarcely suffice to pay either one or the other, and a considerable balance is of course to be expected from this mahal at the end of the year."

What Mr Day foretold actually happened, for at the close of the year 1194 a balance of Rs.12,238 was incurred.

Again, Mr Day, in explanation of the balance exhibited in his touzi account for Aghan, transmitted a few days previous to his proposed plan, speaking of the arrears due from Kartikpúr and Rajnagar, expresses his apprehension of realising the same, owing to the unfavourable state of the lands; and that the general failure of the crops, together with the loss the proprietors have experienced by the death and desertion of many of their under-tenants, he much fears will put it totally out of their power to make good their engagements with Government for the current year, a circumstance which nothing but the late unfortunate calamity would have prevented.

Surely after the deplorable state to which this pargannah was reduced by a total loss of its crops, and the depreciation of many of its under-tenants by death and desertion, it could ill bear the increase recommended by Mr Day. A loss of the harvest may be only considered as a temporary evil, but that of the tillers of the ground must be ever looked on as a most serious loss, and nothing can recover a district labouring under such misfortunes but great indulgence and much time.

The Board, in their answer to Mr Day's recommendation, seem to think that the pargannah is not equal to the increase, for they say, "You will call upon the proprietors for the increase you have proposed, or for such as may appear reasonable and can be levied with-

out distressing them, the ryots and under-renters, due consideration having also been had to the late calamities of the season."

The proprietors being called upon to enter into engagements in 1195, so far from consenting to give an increase, they demand a deduction on the jumma of 1194 of Rs.9791, alleging that it was altogether out of their power to subscribe to any other engagement without risking the loss of their lands, a failure on their part being inevitable from the positive want of resources.

Mr Day, in his letter of the 11th July 1788, appears to be convinced that this mahal was not equal to the increase proposed, for, remarking on the balance of 1194 due from Rajnagar and Kartikpúr, he expresses his opinion as follows: "I was an eyewitness of the death of many when in the lands in the month of November last; and further, that many of the poor distressed wretches now daily perishing in the streets of Dacca were in the beginning of the year inhabitants of those mahals, but from the failure of their crops, having no means of support in the country, came to the capital to seek sustenance. Such, therefore, being the state of these lands, nearly depopulated, and the cultivation decreased of course in proportion, I cannot but consider the present heavy balance due from them irrecoverable, but further apprehend a considerable deficiency in the ensuing year's revenue to be unavoidable if an abatement be not made on their respective jummas on renewing the settlement."

Mr Day with great propriety might have added, considering the wretched state of the pargannah and the miserable situation to which the few remaining ryots were reduced, that unless an abatement was allowed for a period of years he saw no prospect of this mahal's recovering the heavy losses it had sustained by the inundation.

Mr Day, on the 15th of the same month, transmits to the Board the proposals of the zemindars of Rajnagar, Kartikpúr, and Bozergomedpúr for farming their mahals in 1195. The former they offered to take on a deduction on the jumma of 1194 of 36,404. On Kartikpúr they demand a deduction of Rs.9991, and on the latter they agree to an increase of 8934. Mr Day, in his letter which accompanied these proposals, begs to call the Board's attention to them, and observes "that the immediate loss arising in the two former is heavy, but, from the present state of the pargannahs, does not think that more with certainty, or without endangering a greater loss hereafter to Government, can be obtained from them than what has been offered."

Time has shown that Government has experienced a greater balance than the abatement required by the zemindars.

The Board in their orders to the Collector, under date 12th September 1788, speaking of Kartikpúr, made the following remark: "Considering the opinion expressed by you in your report of the 17th January, of ability of the lands to bear an increase of Rs.4000 on the jumma of last year, and also your recommendation that this

increase should be levied at the ensuing settlement, we are altogether at a loss to account for your having submitted to us without comment proposals from the proprietors at an abatement from the jumma of 1194 of no less a sum than Rs.9991, making in all a difference in the jumma originally recommended by you of 13,791. Whilst we regret so disadvantageous a proposal, we deem it highly necessary, on your part, that you should furnish us with the fullest explanation of a result so widely different from what might have been expected from your own opinion and recommendation."

Mr Day, in answer to the Board's letter, says, "My letter of the 17th July has already pointed out that these lands have suffered afresh in the loss of the boro crop, which misfortune having befallen them subsequent to my report of the 17th January, must have added to the distress of the pargannah and its inhabitants. This, together with the year being so far advanced, no doubt influenced the proprietors in making so low a tender from the original jumma."

I have taken the liberty of submitting the above extracts to the Board to show the impracticability of making the settlement of this mahal upon the terms proposed by Mr Day, and the Commissioner's report, under date 28th October last, will show that Government sustained a loss in 1194 of Rs.12,238, and in 1195 the enormous sum of 16,205-2-12-2.

The Board being satisfied of the inability of this mahal, sanctioned the conclusion of the settlement with the proprietors of the present year on an abatement of the jumma of 1194 of Rs.13,791, and even this exceeded the assets of the pargannah in 1195; and from what I have said I cannot but recommend that the present jumma of 1196 be continued for three years, so that the lands may recover themselves, and that after that period an increase of 5000 be put on this pargannah on a rusud jumma of three years.

1194. *Jalálpúr.—Jumma, Rs.*103,902-12-7-3.

On adverting to Mr Day's proposed plan of settlement for 1195, he recommends that the jumma of this pargannah for 1194 be continued for two years, and that the deduction granted in 1192, amounting to 16,358, be resumed the two following years, half in each, by which the mahals at the expiration of four years will stand rated and yield to Government the jumma of 1188. He further recommends that "the mode of talukdari settlement be continued, or that the mahal be let to farm." Mr Day seems to have forgotten the loss and sufferings this pargannah and its dependencies experienced, and the misery to which the under-tenants were reduced, by the dreadful calamity of 1194, or he would not, I humbly conceive, have recommended the above mode of assessment. His letter of the 20th December 1787 evinces that many of the principal pargannahs dependent on this zemindari were nearly ruined by the inundation. In speaking of the pargannah of Moha-

butpúr, Naroollapúr, and two or three others, he observes, "This year the owsh crop in these pargannahs appears to have been nearly wholly destroyed, and that of the aman in a considerable degree prevented. The loss, therefore, which those lands have sustained by the late inundation may be estimated at nearly seven anas proportion of its grain revenue. Notwithstanding this heavy loss, the Arzamin has paid up his revenue in full to the end of Assin; but in doing this there is every reason to believe he is become much in advance for the renters to liquidate his advances, if any such are due, as well as the remainder of the revenue to the end of the year. There is now only left the boro crops and the produce of the betel-nut plantations. From the latter, for the reason assigned in my report for Rajnagar, I fear little is expected."

The Board, relying on the accuracy of Mr Day's statement, authorise the continuation of the assessment of 1194, and direct that the same mode of settlement be adopted. A sazawal was in consequence intrusted with the management for 1195; and the balance incurred that year being 25,999-14-17-3, will show how far Mr Day was warranted in recommending a continuation of the jumma of 1194. The causes of this arrear are fully stated in the late Commissioner's report, transmitted under date the 28th October, to which I must beg leave to refer the Board.

The settlement concluded this year with the proprietors is an abatement of 16,901-12-17-3 on the jumma of 1194, which has been sanctioned by his Lordship in Council. By Mr Day's proposed plan, this abatement must not only be resumed at the ensuing settlement, but an increase of 8175 be added to the jumma.

The settlement of 1197 must therefore stand at 112,081-12-7-3, being an increase upon this year's jumma of Rs.25,080-12-17-3.

To satisfy the Board of the total impracticability of this increase being levied, I must beg to make the following remarks in addition to what I have stated in my report of the balance of 1194 and the assets of 1195.

From 1191 to 1195 this pargannah was held khass, and suffered very considerably in its resources by the loss of the crops and in inhabitants in 1194. Notwithstanding every extortion and oppression of the sazawal, Government sees a balance at the close of the year of 22,638-12-17-3, although it appeared on examining the sazawal's account that this arrear had been realised by him, and which has since been recovered; yet my report will also show that this collection did not arise from the produce of the lands solely, but from a sale of the talukdar's houses, cattle, implements of husbandry, and their private lands. Notwithstanding these violent measures adopted by the sazawal realising the revenue, there still appeared a deficiency at the close of the year of Rs.9956-6-10.

The zemindars, in order to encourage cultivation, and to recover the lands which had become waste by the death and desertion of many of their under-tenants in 1194, were induced to let them out

to other talukdars at a reduced rate. Yet notwithstanding the efforts of the zemindars, and the abatement allowed this year by Government, there is every reason to believe that the assets of this district are not equal to the present dues of Government. The Security is greatly in advance to the proprietors, and finding on a scrutiny of the Moffossil resources that they fall short of the saddar jumma, withholds any further assistance, and solicits an examination of the Moffossil receipts; but as he became responsible of his own accord for Government dues, I shall use every exertion to compel him to fulfil his engagements, though I apprehend there will be a balance at the close of the year of Rs.4000 or Rs.5000.

Sensible of the declining state of Jalálpúr proper, Bangrolah, and Mohabutpúr, and confident that this zemindari is not equal to the present jumma, I am induced to recommend that a deduction of Rs.7000 be granted on it at the concluding the settlement for the ensuing year. That this abatement be resumed at the expiration of three years, when the jumma of Rs.1200 will stand at the present year's rate of assessment. This indulgence will not only prove beneficial to Government in securing to them a certain and regular payment of their dues, but will give confidence and encouragement to the talukdars and ryots to exert themselves in the improvement and cultivation of their lands; but, on the other hand, should Government be disinclined to allow of the above abatement, I apprehend a further loss will be experienced, for the under-tenants finding that the demands of Government are heavier than the earnings of their labour will produce, will be compelled to forsake their habitation and retire to some district where they may peaceably enjoy the fruits of their industry.

1194. *Edeelpúr.—Jumma, S. Rs.*95,115.

In Mr Day's proposed plan of settlement for 1195 he observes "that no cause can be traced why the different deductions have been granted, and as Manek Bose has had it in farm and always paid his revenues punctually, I should suppose he would have no objection to enter into engagements as heretofore on an increased jumma. I would therefore recommend that at the ensuing settlement an increase of 4885 be laid on, fixing the jumma at one lac of rupees."

The Board approve of the above-proposed increase, and on account of the notorious bad characters of the zemindars, direct it to be continued in farm. I humbly conceive that the increase proposed by Mr Day was made without due consideration of the loss this pargannah sustained in its crops and inhabitants by the dreadful calamity of 1194. This conjecture is confirmed by Manek Bose's refusing to renew engagements in 1195, unless a considerable abatement was allowed him on the jumma of 1194. In consequence of this refusal the mahal was advertised for farm, but no one offering for the same, it was held khass.

The Board, in their letter of 23d of September 1788, make the

following remark: "Your holding this mahal khass being in conformity to our orders, we necessarily approve of it, but cannot help remarking on it as a circumstance somewhat extraordinary, that no proposals should have been tendered for the farm of a pargannah at the jumma of 1194, which you, in your report of the 17th January, deemed capable of paying an increase on that jumma of Rs.4885."

At the close of the Bengal year 1194 a balance was incurred in this pargannah of 25,128-11-15. The farmer pleaded total inability to discharge this, alleging that he sustained a loss equal to that sum. However, on his houses and effects being attached, and himself put under restraint, he, to avoid the disgrace of having his property sold at public auction, discharged the balance by borrowing, and mortgaging his houses; and well knowing the loss the pargannah sustained in its resources in 1194, he prudently refused to renew engagements for 1195 on the terms of the preceding year. The late Commissioner's report on the assets of 1195 will show that the causes of his refusal were but too well founded. It will further show that Government sustained a loss that year of Rs.30,541-7-8.

The zemindars having for a period of years been deprived of the management of their lands, and anxious once more to get possession of them, entered into engagements this year at a jumma exceeding the resources of the Moffossil; security being taken from them for the regular discharge of their dues is the reason that the revenues have to this period been paid up with tolerable punctuality, though the Security has declared to me that he is in advance to the zemindars upwards of Rs.10,000. The proprietors being sensible of their inability to discharge the debt contracted with the Security, and with a view to encourage him to a continuance of his assistance, have given a writing purporting that, in the event of their not being able to liquidate the amount advanced by him on their account, they will sell a portion of their lands to pay the same.

By Mr Day's proposed plan of settlement the jumma of this pargannah must stand rated at the commencement of 1197 at sicca Rs.100,000, which is an increase of the present year's jumma of Rs.19,999, and an excess on the amount paid into Government treasury last year of Rs.35,426-7-4.

The late Commissioner's report will fully show that the pargannah now stands overrated, and consequently altogether unable to bear the excess recommended. Government wish to secure a fair and equitable jumma, and his Lordship in Council's instructions evince equal anxiety to afford the landholders a reasonable profit from the produce of their lands.

Although confident that the assets of the pargannah are not equal to its present jumma, yet from a conviction that the lands are capable of great improvement, I would recommend the present assessment to be continued for the space of three years.

With whom to conclude the settlement is a matter that merits the consideration of Government.

With the proprietors—I fear they will not engage on the jumma of last year; but, in the event of their agreeing, security must be taken from them, or the regular discharge of their dues will be precarious. They are many in number, and in needy circumstances. They are reputed men of very bad character, and have long been under the stigma of entertaining dacoits in their pay. One of them, Ram Kanth, was confined for near six years in the Phouzdari jail of Backergunge, Dacca, and Moorshedábád, for abetting and participating in the robbery and plunder of the Company's factory at Soonargunge.

Should it be farmed, no person, I apprehend, will agree to the terms of last year, and at the same time allow 10 per cent. for a provision to the zemindars.

The present Security, who is well acquainted with the pargannah, a man of responsibility and fair character, having for a series of years had the management of it, has offered to farm it for the term of ten years on the jumma of last year for the first three years, and then offers an increase of Rs.4000 for the remaining seven years, provided he be not obliged to pay the 10 per cent. to the proprietors; that on the event of his being necessitated to pay the 10 per cent., he requests an abatement on the jumma of the current year equal to the sum to be allowed the zemindars; that at the expiration of three years he will give an increase of 4000. Considering the very ruinous state of the pargannah, and the noted bad characters of the proprietors, I cannot but give the preference to farming the mahal; but should his Lordship in Council not approve of this mode, I beg to suggest the expediency of holding the pargannah khass, but in doing this Government must not expect to realise the jumma of the present year, as I have before remarked that the resources of the mahal are not equal to that assessment.

I have been told from respectable authority that the northern parts of the zemindari lost three-fourths of its inhabitants in the dreadful calamity of 1194. Much time, great attention and indulgence, and regular advances of takávi are absolute requisites to restore this pargannah to any degree of cultivation. The loss of inhabitants must almost be considered as irretrievable, and the only mode left of increasing cultivation is by granting pecuniary assistance and giving every encouragement to the remaining husbandmen.

I trust what I have said on the subject of the state and capacity of this mahal will enable your Board to determine on a mode for its future management.

1194. *Chandradeep.—Jumma, Rs.*85,725.

My predecessor, in his proposed plan of settlement for 1195, recommends an increase of sicca Rs.15,000 be laid on this mahal, on the plea that the zemindar enjoys a net profit equal to that sum from the hissajat lands, besides avowed advantages on the gross realisation from the lands on which the present jumma is assessed.

The Board, at the same time they approve of the increase, express

their hope that it will not be productive of distress to the zemindar or his family, or to the under-renters or ryots, and in that confidence they direct the Collector to call upon the zemindar to enter to engagements accordingly.

Of the increase recommended, 3000 was secured in 1195, and the additional sum of Rs.1000 laid on at the concluding of the settlement for the current year.

The proprietor of this pargannah is a youth of seventeen years of age, but as no attention has been paid to his education, he remains in total ignorance of the minutiæ of the Moffossil collections. His time is wholly spent in the luxuries of a zenanah, and his mother, wishing to continue in the management of the pargannah, supplies him with the means of gratifying his pleasures. The mother entrusts the executive part of the business to her brother, who is in every respect unfit for and unworthy of the office.

With care and good management an increase might be obtained from this pargannah, and to effect this I would recommend that the present jumma be continued for one year, that the gomastas report its state to me, and that according to such information the settlement be concluded with the zemindar on a fair and equitable jumma for the remaining nine years.

1194. *Narullapúr.—Jumma, Rs.*126,569.

Mr Day in his plan, speaking of this mahal, says, "The opportunity I have lately had of ascertaining with some degree of accuracy the gross amount of the sum annually realised from a part of this pargannah (Hosseenpúr and Hosseenshy) leads me to conclude that the jumma of which the pargannah at large is now rated is by no means equal to its ability, and that the balance remaining of the deduction of 1187 should be resumed at the next settlement. This, however, must depend on the truth and falsity of the pleas urged by the zemindar's agents, who allege that the impoverished state of Pautpossar and other parts of his district renders the excess of jumma, which appears to have been and is now collected from the other two above mentioned, absolutely necessary to enable them to perform their engagements with Government. I would, therefore, recommend that this plea of the bad state of Pautpossar be inquired into previous to concluding any settlement with the zemindars, when, should it appear to be false, the increase before proposed should, in my opinion, be levied, and the pargannah will then stand rated at the jumma of 1179, being Rs.136,687-9-3."

To the above proposal the Board make the following reply: "We direct that you will call upon the zemindars to enter into engagements for Hosseenpúr and Hosseenshy, with the increase proposed by you, and which you inform us you have ascertained their ability to pay; and that you conclude the settlement of these pargannahs accordingly. In respect to the assessment of Pautpossar, we await your report on the result of the investigation now making into the

alleged losses in that pargannah, and in other parts of Narullapúr, which we require you will transmit to us with the least possible delay."

The zemindar's naibs being called upon to renew engagements for the pargannahs Hosseenpúr, Hosseenshy, with the increase proposed, observe that they can have no objection to an increase on the above pargannahs; at the same time they hope that equal justice will be done them on the assessment of Pautpossar, &c. &c., in which case they are satisfied and ready to engage, under the consideration that Government shall not insist on the liquidation of the present balance, in which case a renewal of engagements on their part is altogether impossible without the consent of their principal, to whom they shall immediately communicate the orders now received.

The agents' answer being communicated to the Board, they approve of the settlement of Hosseenpúr and Hosseenshy at the increase agreed on, and direct that Pautpossar and the remaining lands be published for farm, and that should the zemindar decline to engage for the highest amount offered, the Collector conclude the settlement with the farmer offering the same, subject, however, in either case to the approbation of the Governor-General in Council, should any remission be necessary from the jumma of last year.

Pautpossar, &c., pargannahs were in consequence advertised for farm; that no tender being made, and the proprietors requiring the enormous abatement on the jumma of 1194 of Rs.41,393-14-15-1, the Board directed, under date the 23d September 1788, these mahals to be held khass.

The balance due to Government from the zemindari at the close of the year 1194 stood at Rs.28,020-10-12. Of this arrear the Board recommend to his Lordship in Council a remission of 20,000, from a conviction of the losses sustained in the pargannah. His Lordship consents to a remission of half the balance, provided the zemindar would agree to discharge the remainder in the course of 1195. This offer the proprietor declined. However, the amount has since been recovered from him, as the Board remark in their letter of the 15th May last that they shall stop the same from his mosharah.

In 1195 Pautpossar, &c., being held khass, Government sustained a balance of 35,782-15-7-2.

The late Commissioner's report will show that these pargannahs suffered very considerably in their funds during the dreadful calamity of 1194, and that the settlement concluded with the proprietor for the current year exceeded the resources of the pargannah in 1195. I cannot, therefore, but earnestly recommend that the present jumma, being 113,001, be continued, and the settlement be concluded with the proprietor for the term of three years, after the expiration of which an increase of Rs.5000 be paid on a rusud jumma of three years.

1194. *Russoolpúr.—Jumma, Rs.*26,749-6-5.

Mr Day, sensible of the inability of the mahal, recommended in his proposed plan of settlement for 1195 that the jumma be fixed at Rs.22,000; but the Board disapproving of the abatement proposed, and the zemindars refusing to renew engagements on the term of 1194, the Collector was directed to advertise the mahal to farm, but no tenders being made, the pargannah was held khass. The balance sustained in 1195 amounted to the enormous sum of 15,817-9-17-2, and in 1194 the proprietors fell in arrears 16,365-5-13-2, the particulars and causes of which are fully stated in the Commissioner's report.

The settlement for the current year was concluded with the proprietors at the jumma of Rs.18,766, and the sole management given to one of the partners with the sanction of the Board; and I have the pleasure to observe that, by the mode adopted, the revenues have been paid with great punctuality. And if I might presume to recommend, I should propose the management be continued with Zey Odeen; and I am urged to this recommendation from the incapacity of one of the partners, and from the known refractory conduct of the other, who is the proprietor of the five and three anas share of Edrokpúr. The Board will see by my touzi account for Phangoon the heavy balance due from these divisions, and the steps I was obliged to adopt in consequence of the contumacious conduct of the zemindar. Zey Odeen is a mild capable man, and I have no doubt if the sole management of this mahal be left with him for ten years, that cultivation will be considerably extended, and Government revenues increased in proportion. If the Board should approve of this mode, I beg to recommend the present assessment be continued for three years, at the expiration of which period an increase of 5000 be taken on a rusud of two years, by which means Government jumma will stand in 1201 at 23,766, which is an excess on Mr Day's assessment of Rs.1766. I think it my duty to observe that the other two proprietors will strenuously oppose Zey Odeen's being vested with the sole management, but whether their objections are to be admitted and Government dues thereby endangered, must be determined by the Board. I shall only add, that in the event of the sole management devolving on Zey Odeen, he should enter into an obligation to divide the profits equally between the other partners, or to allow them their share of the 10 per cent. adjudged to the zemindars as their proportion of the Moffossil funds.

I have now, gentlemen, as my duty required, laid before you the state and ability of the principal mahals under my superintendence. If for the reasons adduced you deem it necessary to conclude the settlements on the terms proposed by me, I request to be furnished with your speedy orders.

I shall do myself the honour of transmitting you my remarks in the course of a few days on such of the petty mahals which in my

judgment are not capable of bearing the assessment recommended by Mr Day.

In respect to your queries regarding the hauts and gunges, I shall reply to them with the least possible delay.—I have, &c.,

(Signed) W. DOUGLAS, *Collector.*

DACCA, *6th April* 1790.

To the Honourable CHARLES STUART, President,
and Members of the Board of Revenue,
Fort William.

GENTLEMEN,—I am now to reply to that part of your letter of 18th February which respects the hauts, bazaar, and gunges, and their attachment and separation from the mahal revenue.

As the immediate attachment of the bazaars, &c., would have greatly interrupted the collections of the land revenue, which must have taken place by deputing persons into the Moffossil for that purpose, and from the confusion which such a step would have occasioned, I judged it a matter of expediency to postpone the attachment till the close of the collections, lest the Honourable Company should have sustained a loss in the collections thereby, more especially as the zemindars and renters of every denomination considered themselves as entitled to the profits arising from them, and a depreciation of them would have been held forth as a plea for withholding balances probably to a considerable amount.

I did not fail, however, to institute an inquiry into the several articles of sayer collection, as directed by your Board, and from inquiry I perceive that the sayer collections general are constituted in this district under the name of mahals; for instance, the tax collected from the washerman is called the Gazzer-mahal, that from dried fish the Mehai-mahal; and so of others, the mahal deriving its name generally from the country name of the profession or article each should happen to bear.

Here it is necessary to observe that most of the mahals comprising the sayer are either included in the Shire Chundanah or Shawbunder.

In respect to the advantages or disadvantages to be expected from the continuance or discontinuance of them, I can only give my opinion, and leave the result to you for determination.

As these taxes are all, exclusive of the bazaars, hauts, and gunges, wholly separated and unconnected with the land revenue, the continuance or abolition of them cannot affect any other persons than those immediately employed in their collection or from whom they are levied; and it will rest with Government to give up the profits derived from them by their discontinuance; but in order to form a judgment of the expediency of such measure, a particular account of the mode of collecting and the rate of taxation is necessary.

As far as I have been able to learn, they are in general of the same nature as taxes on the same articles in other countries, and I

am inclined to think they are not considered as oppressive even by the natives themselves, excepting a few in this district, which I shall have the pleasure of recommending to the Board to be abolished in the course of making the present year's settlement.

I shall not therefore take on me to recommend their discontinuance, whereby the Honourable Company must sustain considerable loss; while at the same time the benefits arising to individuals would scarcely be a compensation for giving up so much revenue which is necessarily appropriated to the general defence of the State, and of the benefits of which every individual participates. I therefore see no reason why professional men, tradesmen, and artificers of every kind should not contribute their quota to such a useful and necessary purpose, as well as the ryot or husbandman, more specially in times of pressing exigencies.

The mode of collection and rate of taxation is, I perceive, not very well defined, and is in some measure even arbitrary. I should therefore recommend that a moderate and fixed rate of taxation be determined on by the Honourable Board, to become a general and permanent rate, to be adhered to strictly in all instances, and every deviation punished exemplarily; that this rate should be published throughout the pargannahs, and the Collector directed to see it properly executed, which, with a proper situation of the persons employed in the detailed parts, might have a very salutary effect, overrule every objection to the nature of the taxes, and secure ease to the subject, while at the same time it would afford a source of revenue to Government.

In respect to the bazaars, hauts, and gunges, I conceive them to be on a very different footing from the sayer; and here I beg leave to acknowledge the receipt of the Board's letters of the 19th and 26th ultimo. On this subject I have carried the Board's orders into execution in attaching all bazaars, gunges, and hauts, whether situated on rent-free lands of different descriptions or otherwise, and as soon as I receive the Moffossil accounts, I hope to be able to propose from these lights a plan for the future management of them; at present I cannot venture to hazard a conjecture. I beg leave to submit my answers to the several queries put to the Behar Collections:—

Question 1.—Whether in admitting the rights of the zemindars to a property in the soil, they do not consider the gunges and bazaars as much a part of that property as any part of the lands in their possession?

Answer 1.—Admitting the right of the zemindars to a property in the soil, I certainly consider the gunges and bazaars as much a part of that property as any part of the lands in their possession.

Q. 2.—If they do not, to point out the ground of the distinction.

A. 2.—The former being admitted, all argument respecting the second falls to the ground.

Q. 3.—To report whether the zemindars claim the gunges and bazaars as their property, and whether they make any, and what objection to the separation of them.

A. 3.—The zemindars certainly claim the gunges and bazaars as their property, unanimously object to the separation of them, and have delivered in a petition to that effect, which goes enclosed, No. 1, with a translation stating their objections.

Q. 4.—To report if there are not gunges, bazaars, hauts, and sayer in the lands held by the proprietors of altamghas and the tenants of jageers, and whether persons of this description would object to the separation of gunges, &c. &c., and the grounds of such objection.

A. 4.—No doubt but there are many gunges, bazaars, and hauts in the rent-free lands, and the proprietors have the same objection as the zemindars to their separation; they claim them as their right held under certain grants. To show how extremely averse the proprietors of charity lands are to the separation, I must beg to state the remonstrance of a respectable old man who holds Narraingunge.

"I hold Narraingunge in virtue of a sanad granted by the Company for the purpose of defraying the expenses of the takoor, for feeding the poor, and for my own support. To this day the gentlemen have not resumed Debouter, Bormouter, Lackarage, Aymah, Piraun, and Fakiraun lands of ancient establishment, and the proprietors have been suffered to enjoy them unmolested. I have been an old and faithful servant of the Company, and have held Narraingunge these thirty years; and now that I am worn down with years and infirmities, and have no other means of support, I learn that a darogah is appointed to Narraingunge to attach the same. This news have overwhelmed me with grief, and as I am too ill and too weak to wait on you, I have sent my son to you to represent my miserable situation. He will show you my sanad. Let me beseech you to give a favourable ear to his representation; but if you do not, it were better that you take away my life, or expel me from a district where I can no longer remain without incurring shame, trouble, and infinite distress. Hundreds of beggars who are daily fed by me are clamorous for food, and you have not only deprived me of the means of supplying their wants, but shut the door against my performing my religious rites by taking possession of the gunge."

If any partial deviation from a general rule could be departed from, it ought to be done in the instance of this man.

He served the Company from eleven years of age, and held the office of Dewan to the Dacca Commercial Resident for eleven years, the duties of which, I am told, he executed with zeal, integrity, and credit until age and infirmities compelled him to relinquish the station.

There are several petty bazaars in this district, the sole profits of which are employed in defraying the expenses of different musjeds and takoors, and for the performance of religious ceremonies. The proprietors of these have resorted to me in crowds, and are become very clamorous in consequence of the late orders, and declare that attaching their bazaars is not only an infringement of their established rights, but strikes at the fundamental principles of their reli-

gion, as they are now deprived of the sole resource by which they were enabled to defray the necessary establishment of officers kept up for the performance of their religious ceremonies; that their houses of worship must now be shut up, and their priests dismissed. They freely say that Government had better deprive them of their existence than prevent the performance of their religious rites.

Your Board must decide how far these representations can be [not legible], they are well founded. I am also satisfied that the revenues to be derived from them will be absorbed in defraying the establishment necessary to be entertained for collecting the same.

His Lordship must determine how far bazaars which come under the above description can in justice or policy be resumed. It is only for me humbly to observe, that by suffering them to continue in the hands of the present proprietors, Government will afford ease, comfort, and relief to many hundreds of the poor inhabitants who are daily supported from the produce of them.

Q. 5.—As far as right of property is concerned, to discriminate between the rights of zemindars and those of jageerdars and altamgadars, in case objections on this ground should arise to the separation of the gunges, &c., from the jurisdiction of the latter.

A. 5.—I conceive there is a wide distinction between the property of the zemindars and altamgadars.

The former is liable to be deprived of his lands in the event of his declining to renew engagements on the terms proposed by Government, and for each deprivation he receives a certain stipend. Whereas the altamgadars hold their lands rent-free, and in perpetuity. The jageerdars, again, hold theirs on a different tenure, for on the death of the proprietor the jageer escheats to Government. Zemindars can have no claim to it, he having received an abatement from his jumma at the time such jageer was granted.

Q. 6.—Whether the abuses now prevailing in the gunges are of such a nature as not to be corrected by rules and limitations without taking them under their own charge?

A. 6.—I apprehend the abuses are of such a nature as cannot be corrected but by taking them immediately in charge for Government. It may then be practicable, by proper rules and limitations, with diligent and active officers.

In recommending for adoption a new system, which is likely to affect every renter in the country, I am aware that much caution, diligent inquiry, and a thorough knowledge of existing evils are necessary, and that great changes should not be hastily adopted; yet, from the nature of the abuses committed, the almost impossibility of detection, particularly in the [not legible] of the country, and the difficulty of obtaining redress and retribution, and from a persuasion the intended change will be attended with very salutary effects, every exertion shall be used on my part to carry his Lordship's orders into immediate and effectual execution, and I shall endeavour to fulfil the wishes of Government with unremitted zeal, activity, and integrity.

I beg to be favoured with your early orders respecting abatement to be granted the zemindars in consideration of their being deprived of the gunge, haut, bazaar collections, as you will perceive by the petition No. 1 that they have refused to renew engagement unless some compensation be made them. I apprehend that any farther delay in concluding settlement will be attended with a serious loss in the present year's revenue, for although I have taken every precaution to prevent anticipation of the revenues, yet the zemindars will endeavour to exceed the same, and clandestinely collect.—I have, &c.

(Signed) W. DOUGLAS, *Collector.*

DACCA, *5th May* 1790.

To the Honourable CHARLES STUART, President,
and Members of the Board of Revenue,
Fort William.

GENTLEMEN,—I have the honour to acknowledge the receipt of your secretary's letter of the 14th instant, enclosing copy of the Resolutions of the Governor-General in Council in the Revenue Department, under date 12th May 1790, revoking the 16th article of the General Regulations for the Bengal Settlement passed in Council on the 10th February last, as far as it regards who are actual proprietors of the lands composing their talooks, with the exception of that part of it which prescribes rules for fixing the amount of the assessment to be imposed upon their talooks, and directing that all talookdars who are proprietors of the soil and who now pay their rents through the mediation of a zemindar be immediately separated from the jurisdiction and authority of such zemindar, and the rents of the latter be adjusted, exclusive of the talooks so separated, and ordering that the settlement be concluded with the talookdars themselves.

As the measure involves a question of considerable magnitude, as far as it applies to the district in my charge, and the persons who are the immediate objects of it, I conceive it becomes a point of duty in me to take this early opportunity of stating to your Board the advantages or disadvantages which are likely to arise from an adoption of it in this district, as far as my local knowledge and the inquiries I have hitherto been able to make extend; and in doing this I rely on the candour of the Board to exempt me from any intentional inclination of opposing measures which may be established for the general benefit of the country. I trust the unremitting zeal and attention I have shown in endeavouring to carry into execution the late orders of Government will secure me from any suspicion, while at the same time a simple statement of facts, though they may operate in some measure against the intended Regulation, becomes in me an indispensable piece of duty, as the ensuing year's revenue may be affected thereby.

The first question that occurs is, What is a talookdar, and what the essentials that constitute him an actual proprietor of the soil?

As I was not satisfactorily informed on this subject, I recurred to the most authentic evidence, written or verbal, within my reach, and I find they are in this district of four kinds, besides a similar description of renter called a howladar, as follows :—

1. *Jungleboory.*—Previous to the division of the country into pargannahs and tappahs, and fixed what is called the tuxeembandy, many persons undertook to cultivate jungle and waste lands, and when the tuxeembandy was made, these new-cultivated lands were constituted talooks, and included in the zummabandy of the nearest zemindar by the Government of that time; and if any increase or remission was granted the zemindar, a proportional part fell to the talookdar. If the zemindar withheld from the talookdar any part of this, he was at liberty to complain to the Government, who compelled the zemindar to allow the talookdar his proportion of the remission. If the talookdar died leaving heirs, they got possession of this land in the same manner as their predecessor, and the zemindar had nothing to do with them, but receive his malgujari agreeably to kistibandi; but if there happened to be no heirs, the zemindar was the manager for the behalf of Government.

2. *Zur Khorid.*—The talookdars under this denomination were at liberty to sell their talooks by bill of sale, with or without the permission of the zemindar; and on failure of heirs the zemindar could take possession, and sell the lands, or keep them, as he might be inclined. These talookdars were subject to increase or entitled to remissions proportionately with the zemindar, agreeably to their respective jumma.

3. *Pattah Talookdar.*—The zemindars and chowdries could grant hereditary talookdary pattahs to any person for lands belonging to themselves, called their neez, whether cultivated or uncultivated, in which pattah it was stipulated that the talookdar should have possession of the whole lands agreed upon, and that the management should descend to his heirs for ever; but this talookdar could neither sell nor make over by deed of gift the lands of his talook, neither could the zemindar dispose of it, but on failure of issue it reverted to the zemindar. Pattah talookdars were subject to increase and remission along with the zemindar.

4. *Ausat Talookdar*, or talookdar within talookdar, is the same in respect to a talookdar that a jer khareed talookdar is to a zemindar.

5. *Howladar.*—In the pargannah of Bickrampore a custom prevails that if any talookdar sell any part of talook to another person, upon receiving the purchase price he calls him a howladar of so much land, who pays his rents to the talookdar; but if any dispute arises between the talookdar and howladar, he can get his howallah separated from this talookdar and included in some other talookdary lands; is subject to increase and decrease of revenue along with the other renters, and the property is hereditary and transferable.

The above is as accurate a definition of the different talookdars of this district as I have been able to procure, and it remains with the Board to decide what description of them, or whether the whole are

to be considered as having an actual property in the soil, and to be separated from the zemindars.

The number of talookdars in this district is computed to be upwards of 20,000. Many pargannahs have already a talookdary settlement, the zemindars standing between them and Government in the light of tahsildars.

I am authorised by the Resolutions of the Governor-General in Council to appoint tahsildars in those pargannahs where the talooks are too numerous to receive the revenues immediately from the talookdars. This mode I must consequently adopt in many pargannahs, but in doing this the zemindars will murmur, as long custom and possession have given them a sort of hereditary claim to the management, from which they derive pecuniary advantages, as well as influence and consequence. The new tahsildars, it is true, can for some time to come have no hereditary claim, though there is no doubt but possession may at some future period give them a handle to set up pleas of the same kind. Thus, then, a new set of men will be set up who may claim property to which they have no title, at the expense of those who are already admitted to possess or supposed to have a right in the soil.

In the mahal Katarabu the zemindars have not a foot of ground—all talookdary—yet they claim a right to the lands, and are allowed the usual *russoom*. May we not suppose them to have been originally only talookdars, and from long possession have set up hereditary claim? And may we not also from thence infer that our talookdars may have a sense of their own interests sufficient at least to attempt a similar claim?

I beg to subjoin a list of some of the principal zemindaries of this district, showing the talookdary jumma, the neez jumma of the zemindars, and the number of talookdars in each zemindary:—

	Crown Lands.	Talookdars' Jumma.	Total Jumma.	No. of Talookdars.
Pargannah Jalalpore .	11,000	76,001	87,001	2148
Pargannah Chandradeep	17,000	72,725	89,725	400
Pargannah Bickrampore	2,010	25,642	27,652	268
Pargannah Rajnagar, &c.	92,555	20,118	293,673	400
Tappeh Mysurdee . .	4,000	14,004	18,004	561
Pargannah Essakabad .	1,700	2,000	3,700	200
Tappeh Hydrabad . .	1,237	750	1,985	200

From the above comparative view of the property of the talookdars and zemindars, it appears that the latter possess but little real property of their own, and that a separation of the talookdars would reduce many of them from affluent circumstances to a state of indigence, and the titles of Rajah and Zemindars, which they are allowed to enjoy, will become a mere empty name.

To ascertain the rights and tenures of such a number of talookdars as 20,000 must take up a great deal of time, and cannot be accom-

plished in less than two or three years; and sensible that the revenues of the current year must sustain considerable loss by any further delay in concluding the settlement, and anxious to prevent anticipation of collections which unavoidably must happen by any longer procrastination, notwithstanding every precaution has been taken on my part to prevent it, I cannot but earnestly recommend that engagements be entered into immediately with the zemindars as heretofore, with a notification of their agreeing to the separation of the talookdars whenever Government shall think proper to do so, and that the separation from their authority be gradually effected.

There can be no inconvenience in adopting this mode, as the zemindars are obliged to state the sudder jumma levied from every talook, mouza, and village under their authority, and grant pattahs to the talookdars, by which means illegal exactions will be prevented, and the talóokdar will have it in his option to continue under the authority of the zemindars, or pay his revenues directly to the Collector. It is a matter of doubt with me whether, by emancipating the talookdars from the present authority and jurisdiction of the zemindars, it will free them from the exactions they have hitherto been subjected to, as, considering the number of them, the agency of tahsildars will be necessary, it being impossible for a Collector to treat directly with 20,000 or 30,000 different renters, more especially when his time is fully occupied in new and other important regulations, and I am not sure the management of a tahsildar is preferable to that of a zemindar; for my own part I should give the latter the preference, because a zemindar may entertain hopes of the management being continued to him from good behaviour, but a tahsildar has no right to entertain any such idea, and he will, looking to the present moment only, endeavour to enrich himself at the expense of those who are placed under his authority, unless indeed Government choose to confirm him in his office, for a space of time. There is another inconvenience attending the collection of a tahsildar in this district, which I believe does not exist in any other to so great a degree—namely, the dispersed situation of the lands. The lands of a talook are not one continued spot of ground, but extend through many pargannahs and detached in small and separate parts, and nothing but an actual measurement of the whole district can ascertain to whom the property belongs.

The zemindars, feeling their interests affected by the new regulations, will endeavour to conceal, combine with, and connive at the concealment of others; hence a defalcation of revenues, endless disputes, and consequent investigations attended with expense, will be the consequence, and I am convinced nothing but an actual measurement of the whole district can render the regulation of Government so effective as they could wish. Experience proved the collections of a native collector to be defective, and this induced the sovereigns of this country in former times to grant lands upon lease to the inferior renters under the most respectable of that class of people now denominated zemindars, for management and collection,

finding the inferior landholders too numerous and too distant for receiving their collections at the sudder, and the collections of a tahsildar too defective to adopt the system universally. The zemindars also had the privilege of administering justice in their respective jurisdictions, acting something like justices of the peace in our own country, settling trifling disputes, and rendering easy and speedy redress to the injured party, which would have been rendered very difficult indeed if a poor man has a travel to the Huzzoor and prefer his complaint through a regiment of corrupt mutsuddees, every one of whom must have been bribed before he could obtain what a respectable zemindar could have granted him on the spot in a day's attendance.

The powers with which the zemindar was invested, I believe to have given rise to the present claims of the zemindars to the right of having the talookdars under their authority, and they are certainly not entitled to complain, if upon proof of ill-treatment or exactions, they should be separated from them; but it is, I think, doubtful whether the appointment of tahsildars is calculated to remedy the evil, while at the same time it affords, as I mentioned before, a handle to the zemindars to combine with one another, and with talookdars, to conceal lands and defraud Government of its just dues.

I shall conclude with observing that the talookdars whose distance from the sudder cutchery is considerable, and whose revenues do not exceed two, four, or six rupees per annum (and there are many such in this district), will find much inconvenience and loss of time in travelling to Dacca with their monthly instalments of two, four, and six anas, and the possibility of entertaining vakeels is out of the question from the amount. The jurisdiction of a tahsildar must extend through several pargannahs, and include these distant petty talookdars, and his authority over them must be very inefficient from their separate and dispersed situation, and hence an opportunity will be afforded for collusion.

W. Douglas.

Dacca, *the 26th May* 1790.

To William Cowper, Esq., President, and
Members of the Board of Revenue,
Fort William.

Gentlemen,—I have now the honour to transmit to you the proposed Novennial Settlement of this district, commencing with the Bengali year 1198 and ending with 1206, for your information and orders.

As in my letter of the 8th August last I expressed my hopes that the increase to be obtained by separating the talukdars would equal the expense of the tahsildari establishment required for this district, but as my expectations have not been realised it becomes necessary to explain to you the causes which have occurred to frustrate my hopes at the time I addressed your Board, trans-

mitting for approval my tahsildari establishment. I conceived that the talukdars of the following mahals would be entitled to separation—viz., Selímábád, Chandradeep, &c., Nazirpore, Sultanábád, and Aurangpore—but upon investigating into their right to that indulgence, I find but few who are entitled to separation, the major part of them holding their lands on similar tenures with the jungleboory talukdars of Bozergomedpúr, who are considered as leaseholders, and therefore continue subject to the authority of the zemindars. Had the talukdars of the pargannahs above mentioned been separated, I am confident that my expectations for increase would have been secured.

Your Board will perceive in my account settlement that the lands of sundry talukdars who have been separated from different pargannahs remain khas. This has arisen either from the non-attendance of some, the death of others, or because their jama has not been finally adjusted, owing to the difference between the jama stated in the accounts delivered in by the zemindars and the account declared by the talukdars to have been annually paid by them. However, in my detailed account settlement, which I shall hereafter have the honour of laying before you, I hope to show that all taluks now held khas are either intrusted with their respective proprietors or farmed out, and in settling their jama I trust to secure some additional increase to Government.

The zemindary mahals which still continue khas I shall have the honour to report upon in the course of a few days.

Your Board may probably observe that a small increase has been obtained from the lands of the zemindars. To this I reply, that could any excess have been obtained from them without endangering the future prosperity of the district it should have been effected; but many of the pargannahs have not yet recovered the losses they suffered in the direful era of 1194 by a deprivation of many thousands of ryots, who either died or emigrated in that year. The Rajnagar zemindary is a melancholy instance of the truth of this assertion. This mahal was under the immediate superintendence of Mr Thompson for two years, and notwithstanding every attention was bestowed, and every encouragement given, yet he found it impracticable to secure the former jama. In 1196 it was found necessary to allow a deduction of 22,725. In 1198 a further abatement of Rs.20,000 was granted, and in concluding the eight years' settlement the further sum of Rs.6447-7-2-2 has been allowed, notwithstanding the sum of Rs.15,860 was added to the zemindary by a resumption of the profits of Pitambar Sen's neez taluks. Consequently if that sum had not been annexed to the jama of the zemindary, a deduction equal to its amount must have been allowed. It should therefore appear that in the short space of four years this pargannah has declined in its assets in the enormous sum of Rs.65,032-7-2-2.

Great difficulty was experienced by the tahsildars in realising the revenues from the talukdars, owing to the scattered situation of the

lands composing the pargannahs under my superintendence. To remove this inconvenience, and to afford ease and relief to the separated talukdars, I propose, with your sanction, to divide the district into eight compact zillahs, and to place the same under eight tahsildars. Should your Board approve of this measure, I will do myself the pleasure of submitting to you the establishment necessary for carrying this plan into execution, the adopting of which will be affording great relief to petty talukdars, many of whom have to travel two days' journey to pay monthly the trifling sum of Rs.2 or 3, and Government revenues will be realised with greater ease and punctuality.—I have, &c.

(Signed) W. Douglas, *Collector.*

Dacca, *the* 31*st July* 1792.

II.—Letter of Mr Massie to the Board of Revenue about the Permanent Settlement, dated 24th March 1801.

Gentlemen,—It appearing to me, that in consequence of the *Malguzari* lands having been declared by the existing regulations responsible for such arrears as might become due to Government therefrom, sufficient regard was not paid in this district at the conclusion of the Decennial Settlement to the ascertaining and recording the names of the actual proprietors of such lands for the time being; in consequence of which the Government not unfrequently suffers losses in its revenues in cases where the proceeds of sales of certain lands are not sufficient to answer the balances due from such lands, as it cannot be ascertained what other lands the defaulting proprietors are possessed of; and individuals are often unable to recover the amount of their just demands by a sale of lands after decisions have been passed in their favour by the courts of justice; and it also appearing to me that if some easy and effectual mode of ascertaining and recording the names of the actual proprietors of lands could be adopted, it would be attended with the most beneficial effects as well to Government as to individuals, I therefore beg leave to trouble your Board with a few remarks on this subject for your consideration.

2d. Your Board will be pleased to observe that a practice has prevailed in this district from time immemorial, and still prevails, of conducting all the affairs of an estate from generation to generation in the name of the original proprietor of such estate or some fictitious name formed by him, under which cloak the actual proprietors for the time being are kept concealed, and what the consequences of such concealment are I have stated above. But before I proceed further, I deem it necessary to lay before your Board the following extract from the proceedings held in this office at the time of the conclusion of the Novennial Settlement, my remarks on which will, I trust, satisfy your Board that what I have already advanced is not incorrect, nor the evil complained of imaginary.

Dacca Jalálpúr, Revenue Cutchery, *the 20th May* 1791.

This being the day fixed on for commencing the settlement for nine years, in obedience to the orders of the Board under date the 29th of December 1790, and several taluqdars and zamindars being in attendance in consequence of the advertisement published in

. The Collector commences the settlement accordingly.

*Taluq Hujuri, Mirza Jehan.—J. Rs.*630-8.

Ram Sankar, gomasta, being in attendance, gives in proposals for the ensuing settlement. He is informed that as the settlement is to be made for nine years, he must give an increase so as to make the jama equal to Rs.701. He acquiesces. Resolved the terms be accepted.

*Taluq Hujuri, Sib Ram Mullick.—J. Rs.*23.

Dip Chand, proprietor, enters into engagements for this mahal upon an increase of Rs.2, making the aggregate Rs.25. Accepted.

*Taluq Hujuri, Sib Ram Kalsi.—J. Rs.*6.

The proprietor delivers in proposals with an increase of Rs.1, making the jama 7. Accepted.

*Taluq do. (i.e., Hujuri), Ram Sankar Sein.—J. Rs.*98.

Kowala Kanth, gomasta, being in attendance, delivers in proposals with an increase of Rs.2, making the jama Rs.100. Accepted.

*Taluq Putchkowl.—J. Rs.*107-6.

Ram Nar Singh, gomasta, being in attendance. This man declines entering into engagements on the terms of last year. The Board to be addressed. Ordered the settlement be postponed for the present. The zamindar having acceded to the terms of last year, it becomes unnecessary to address the Board.

*Taluq Hujuri, Birju Sundar.—J. Rs.*294-9-4-3.

Ram Sankar, gomasta, being in attendance, gives in proposals with an increase of Rs.3-6-15-1, making the jama Rs.298. The vakil represents that his constituent holds a taluq under taluq Baidinath, which he requests may be separated and annexed to his own.

Accepted for this taluq, and that the Board be addressed on the subject of the latter requisition.

The proprietor of Baidinath being in attendance, is asked whether he has any valid objections to make to the separation thereof. He replies that he has none; but he observes, that as some of the taluqs under him are ruined, that the profitable taluqs, among which is this one, belonging to the taluqdar who wishes to be separated, used formerly to make good the loss he sustained upon the others, consequently if he is separated, an adequate abatement must be allowed him.

*Taluq Hajari, Abul Moolah.—J. Rs.*125.

Kishen Mohan, gomasta, declines entering into engagements on the terms of last year, though a deduction has been allowed them last year, alleging that his taluq is overrun with jungle and the lands unfit for cultivation.

Ordered. The Board be advised. Unnecessary, the zamindar having agreed to the terms of last year.

*Taluq Sha Khalil.—J. Rs.*178.

This taluq stands rated in 1194 at Rs.138. An increase was obtained in 1195 of Rs.40. On a reference to Mr Day's plan, the jama of 1169 is recommended as the standard for the conclusion of the settlement, which the Board approve of. It appears, therefore, that the present jama is deficient in Rs.102-1-17-2. The vakil therefore is desired to enter into engagements with that increase. He declines, there not being assets. (The zamindar's terms were afterwards acceded to.)

*Taluq Chand Ram Pabaz.—J. Rs.*45-7-10.

Byjunnath, gomasta, delivers in proposals, with an increase of Rs.4-8-10, making the jama Rs.50. Accepted.

3d. The foregoing extract, your Board will be pleased to observe, contains one day's proceedings, in which only the name of one proprietor is mentioned as being in attendance, and even he in the previous counterpart proceedings is stated to be a gomasta.

Mr Massie then gives specimens of some of the *tahuts*, thus: "Mirza Jehan, signed by Mirza Jan, by the pen of Ramraman Naib, gomasta. Taluq Ram Sankar Sein, by the pen of Kamla Kanth Sarma," &c. &c., and adds, "From these signatures, any person unacquainted with the practice that has hitherto prevailed in this district, would of course suppose that all the persons named as the proprietors thereby, were in existence at the time of the conclusion of the Novennial Settlement, and that the several gomastas named were appointed by them to enter into engagements on their parts, but I must observe that it would appear there were then no such persons as Mirza Jan, Ram Sankar Sein, Abul Moolah, Sha Khalil."

He adds, "With regard to the settlement of the separated taluqs, from the immensity of their number, the proceedings appear to have been still more summary, and the difficulty of finding out the proprietors consequently increased, as your Board will perceive from the following extract."

He then gives an extract in which fifteen taluqs are put down without any proprietor being named, the note appended being merely that Ram Kanth, gomasta, enters into engagement on the Mofussil jama.

III.—Bákarganj in 1801, being a Letter from Mr Wintle, dated 7th January 1802.

In obedience to the orders of Government of the 29th October last, I have now the honour to forward my reply to the interrogatories therewith transmitted. I fear it may not be thought so full and particular in some points as perhaps is expected, and I am sensible that it does not contain all that might be said on several questions; but as an apology for its defects, I take the liberty to state that I have had but little time since I was nominated to this district to turn my mind to the framing of Regulations, as my attention has been fully occupied by official (and in some measure extra) business ever since my first arrival in the zillah. When I took charge of the office, I found an immense accumulation of *fouzdarry* business, occasioned by my predecessor's sending out a *girdwar* who apprehended upwards of 350 persons, whose examinations occupied both the acting register's and my own time most fully for several months. Before this was finished, an order was passed for the removal of the sudder station to Burrishol, the carrying which into effect, by clearing away jungles, erecting jails, buildings, &c., and laying out a new town, has taken up all the time and attention I could spare from official avocations to this moment, so that though I have had every inclination to take minutes and propose amendments where I found the Regulations deficient, I really have been unable to find time. . . . I however hope that the reply, though deficient in some points from being written amongst sundry busy employments of surveyor, architect, &c., in addition to my judicial avocations, may not be deemed totally useless; and that your Lordship will believe my greatest wish is to give satisfaction to, and obtain the approbation of Government, by a faithful and diligent discharge of my public duty.

(Signed) J. Wintle, *Judge and Magistrate.*

Zillah Backergunge, *7th January* 1802.

Question 1.

The number of causes depending on the 31st December 1801 was as follows, viz.:—

Before the Judge	117
Before the Register	315
Before the Native Commissioners	1274
Total	1706

Question 2.

The Civil Courts of this zillah were not established until April 1797. The number of causes depending at the end of each year

is inserted underneath, which will show the proportion those now depending bear to former years, viz. :—

	1797. On the 31st December.	1798. On the 31st December.	1799. On the 31st December.	1800. On the 31st December.	1801. On the 31st December.
Before the Judge . .	276	269	220	384	117
Before the Register . .	260	290	121	40	315
Before the Native Commissioners . .	133	160	759	2461	1274
Total of each year . .	669	719	1100	2885	1706

Question 3.

The number of causes decided in the past year (1801) is inserted below, but they fall short of what may be decided when the Judge holds regular courts. The Judge's Court was not opened till my arrival on the 25th February, as I was not allowed to leave my former station for some months after my appointment to this zillah. From May to September inclusive four court days also in each month were lost by my being obliged to come once a week to Burrishol to look after the works carrying on at the new station. The Judge's Court was, besides, shut during the months of November and December, on account of the removal of the station, to enable the omlahs, vakeels, and pleaders to erect habitations at the new Residence, and to give time for removing the prisoners, cutcheries, &c. The number of causes decided was as follows ; in which statement I have thought it proper, for the information of Government, to insert causes disposed of by nonsuit, &c., and other business that is not brought on the regular file, viz. :—

Tried by the Judge.

In appeals from the decision of the Register .	49	
In appeals from the decision of the Native Commissioners	3	
	—	52
Decreed on trial	46	
Dismissed on nonsuit	80	
Adjusted by Razeenomah . . .	10	
	—	136
Total . . .		188

By the Register.

Decreed on trial	187	
Dismissed on nonsuit	146	
Adjusted by Razeenomah . . .	38	
Total . . .		371

By the Native Commissioners.

Decreed on trial	63
Dismissed on nonsuit	2467
Adjusted by Razeenomah . . .	1204
Total . . .	3734

Remarks.—Besides the above, 338 summary causes, according to the 7th Regulation of 1799, 49th Regulation of 1795, and 6th Regulation of 1800, were decided by the Judge. *N.B.*—The number of Commissioners were not complete previous to my taking charge.

Question 4.

The number of causes that must necessarily be depending cannot be stated with any certainty, because, though a pretty exact calculation may be made of the number that ought to be decided, the question must in a great measure rest on the number of suits instituted annually, which may vary exceedingly. This court having been established but a few years, the number of causes filed has annually increased, particularly in the past year, and may still increase. But as it is necessary to have some criterion to form an opinion upon, I think the past year's file (or 1801) the properest to go by. Agreeable to that, I conceive that, supposing the three tribunals to be regular and attentive in the discharge of their duty, there must yet necessarily be about the under-mentioned number of causes always in arrear, or nearly six months' business—that is to say, that a suitor may obtain a decision in six months from the period of instituting his suit, viz. :—

Before the Judge	60
Before the Register	310
Before the Native Commissioners . . .	900

The various official business the Judge has to perform prevents his giving his attention solely to the decision of regular suits. The reason of the number of causes now depending not being reduced so low as they might have been is principally to be ascribed to the causes mentioned in the answer to the 3d question, which, however, were temporary, and not likely to operate hereafter.

Question 7.

Litigation has certainly been checked by the establishment of the fees and stamp duties mentioned in this question, as far as respects frivolous and unfounded suits, but not in regard to real causes of action, which are as much sued for as ever. I do not think the several charges attending the institution of lawsuits too considerable, as far as relates to suits for large demands; but they appear in many instances to be too heavy on suits for small demands, as will appear by the following statement on a demand for two rupees, which would be much more were the suit for landed property. This the plaintiff has to pay to Government alone, exclusive of the expense of serving the processes before his cause comes to be tried, though,

it is true, that eventually the defendant will have to pay it in addition to his own expenses, viz. :—

Stamp paper for plaint	0	4
Fees for filing ditto	0	2
Stamp paper for security for vakeel's fees	0	4
Fees for filing ditto	0	8
Stamp paper for security to make good expenses of suit	0	4
Fees for filing ditto	0	8
Fees for issuing a summons	0	8
Stamp paper for a copy of defendant's answers	0	4
Stamp paper for a copy of rejoinder	0	4
Stamp paper for vakalant namah	0	4
Fees for filing ditto	0	8
Stamp paper for petition for issuing subpœnas	0	4
Fees for filing ditto	0	8
Fees for three witnesses	1	8
Issuing subpœna	0	8
Two vouchers (only)	1	0
Total	Sicca Rs.7	6

To suggest the means by which the expense might be lessened to the individual, without subjecting Government to much loss of revenue, requires some consideration and more time to arrange than the various duties I have at present on my hands will allow. Hereafter, when I have more leisure, I shall offer such suggestions on this point to Government as may appear to me deserving of its notice.

Question 10.

The vakeels in general, I believe, discharge their duty to their clients with as much honour and fidelity as a native usually possesses. I have never met with a native, high or low, who possessed much of the first quality, and their portion of the latter is but small, as far as seventeen years' intercourse with them enables me to judge.

Question 14.

There are several private schools in this zillah, where the Hindu law is taught, but no Mahomedan. The Brahmins, who are at the head of them, either have rent-free lands, or subsist by the bounty of their students. Some of them also receive presents for performing marriage and religious ceremonies.

Question 15.

The general moral character of the inhabitants of this district (if I may be allowed to use the expression) is at the lowest pitch of infamy; and very few exceptions, indeed, to this character are to be found. There is no species of fraud or villany the higher classes will not be guilty of, and to these crimes in the lower classes may be added murder, robbery, theft, wounding, &c., on the slightest occasion. In fact it is hardly going too far in asserting that the whole of the inhabitants of this district are dacoits; for the lower classes in general must in a great measure support themselves in that manner, as few of them really work at trades, or cultivate sufficient lands for their maintenance; and the zemindars and talookdars, with very

few exceptions, undoubtedly entertain and protect dacoits secretly, who are the principal actors in all affrays between the former respecting disputed lands, boundaries, &c. I fear the system of law established by the British Government has not had much effect in improving their moral character. Fear is the only passion that can operate to any purpose with the natives of this part of the country; they may be restrained from committing crimes from the dread of punishment, but I apprehend that no precept or example will ever induce them to be in love with virtue or honesty, from their purity only. Strict justice and rigorous laws can alone keep them in order.

Question 16.

The inhabitants undoubtedly consider their private rights and property to be far better secured by the present constitution of the country than ever they were under the Mogul Government, and that they are not liable to infringement by the executive authority itself, by the executive officers of Government, or by individuals.

Question 17.

The cultivation and population of this district are in a state of improvement; but from all I can learn from the natives, commerce has declined, the principal articles of which formerly consisted of salt and cloth; but since the Honourable Company has monopolised the first, and made advances for the second, many individuals have given over their dealings. Religious buildings are less frequently erected; and for domestic purposes, little or no improvement seems to have been made in those constructions. The natives are enemies to innovation, even in the form of their houses, and are too indolent to imitate neatness or taste. The grand cause of the decline of commerce and religious buildings seems, however, to arise from what in other countries forms not only the strength, but tends to the riches and prosperity of the State—increase of population. In this, it only operates to its impoverishment, if the opinions of the natives themselves have any force; for they say that when the population was less, their ancestors were rich, and had a capital which could be spared for the purposes of commerce and the erection of religious edifices; but as their descendants have multiplied so much of late years, such sums, divided and subdivided amongst them, gives to each but a small pittance, and has destroyed all the great fortunes. From my own observation and intercourse with the natives, I believe there is some truth in this reasoning; and unless a spirit of enterprise and honest activity can be infused into the natives at large, I see no means of their becoming either richer or happier. The lower classes of natives in this district are too indolent to try to better their situations by labour and exertion, though there is no doubt that the lot of the ryot, labourer, and mechanic has considerably improved under the English Government. My opinion respecting the population and cultivation of the district is founded upon inquiries from the natives and my own observation.

Question 18.

I believe the inhabitants of this district are perfectly satisfied with

the British Government, and that they are fully aware of the great freedom they enjoy under it, beyond what they could ever taste under either the Mogul or Hindu administrations.

Question 19.

The present system of police is in general well calculated to ensure the apprehension of offenders, and only requires some additional rules, which are proposed in the answer to question 33.

Question 20.

The police establishments of this district are not adequate to the duties required of them, there not being a sufficient number of thannahs at present to admit of their being placed at ten *coss* from each other, agreeable to the 4th section, 2d Regulation of 1793, some of them being a much greater distance asunder. They appear also to have been in the first instance injudiciously placed, and not so disposed as to afford security to the district, equal to what the actual number of stations should do. Three or four more thannahs will be necessary, which I shall propose to Government as soon as I have leisure to prepare a new arrangement of the stations.

Question 21.

I am of opinion that the number of crimes committed annually has diminished in the past year, in comparison to what I understand were formerly committed; but as there does not appear to have been any regular account kept previous to my appointment to this zillah of the crimes committed within the jurisdiction of each darogah, it is not an easy matter to assert positively whether they have annually diminished since the year 1793 or not, the Adawlut Calendar not being a sufficient criterion to judge by (particularly the past years, which includes many crimes committed in former years), for many crimes were formerly, and are still sometimes committed, where the perpetrators escape being apprehended or discovered. I however keep a regular account of all crimes that come to my knowledge of the darogah's, whether the parties are taken or not. An account of the number of trials in each year since 1797, agreeable to the Calendar, is inserted below. No calendars prior to that year are to be found in the office. The second sessions of the last year not being concluded, the first sessions only is inserted, viz. :—

Crimes.	1797.	1798.	1799.	1800.	1801. 1st Sessions.
Murder	2	19	22	22	21
Dacoity	11	15	17	19	39
Dacoity and murder	1	7	9	8	5
Theft	2	13	8	5	4
Receiving stolen goods	...	1	1	1	...
Bribery	1	1	...	1	3
Perjury	2	1	8	...	12
Forgery	...	1	...	...	1
Wounding	1	1	2	1	6
Resistance to Court's authority	...	...	...	...	4
Total	20	59	67	57	95

Question 22.

The crimes of enormity most prevalent in this district are murder; dacoity, with murder; dacoity, with wounding with spears, &c.; dacoity simple; dacoity, and burning with lighted *masáls;* dacoity, with putting bamboos to the back and chest of a person, and drawing them close with twisted strings, in the manner of a vice, until he is breathless, and sometimes the breastbone or ribs are broken; dacoity, with putting chilli powder (cayenne pepper) into the eyes, mouth, nose, and ears,—all these for the purpose of extorting confessions where the sufferers' effects are kept or hid, and which are usually inflicted by dacoits at the time of committing robberies; violent wounding with *daos*, &c.; affrays and assaults.

The cause of the prevalence of the first is that the inhabitants of this zillah in general are of the lowest class, and both the men and women are extremely passionate in their dispositions, and loose and profligate in their manners. Infidelity on the part of the women, and jealousy on the side of the men, most frequently are the occasion of murders, but sometimes a dispute about a kid or a *hooka* is sufficient for that purpose. Passion also often leads to the commission of self-murder, which is more frequent in this zillah than in any part of the country I have resided.

Dacoity (which often includes many crimes) arises from two causes—viz., 1st, That dacoits consider themselves as much a distinct caste or profession as any other caste; and it is very common for several generations to be dacoits. I have heard of an instance of a dacoit recommending to his son at the foot of the gallows to continue the profession, notwithstanding his own ill-fate. 2d, That the idle and ill-disposed begin first with pilfering, &c., and gradually advance from one enormity to another. . . .

Question 23.

The generality of the inhabitants of this district do not keep arms in their houses. Such respectable persons as keep arms have these for defence against dacoits. The latter have the largest quantity of arms. They consist of *talwars*, spears, bows and arrows, *raibánses* (a long iron, somewhat like a spit, fixed at the end of a bamboo), *khangauns* (a long talwar), bludgeons.

Question 24.

There are the ruins of three old mud forts—two at Sujábád, pargana Chandradwip, and one at Sangrám, pargana Uttar Shahbázpúr—which were formerly built as a defence against the incursions of the Mugs. Some old cannon, it is said, are there remaining, but I have not had time to visit these places.

[Question 25 was about the population. Mr Wintle was not able to answer it, but thought that the proportion of the Hindus to the Mahomedans was 10 to 6.]

Question 26.

There is no person of rank except Rajah Jai Narain, *alias* Durga Koer Narain Rai, late zamindar of Chandradwip. The names of the most respectable persons are inserted underneath, but none of these

have more than twenty-five or thirty followers. They never appear to go abroad with more than three or four barkandazes, armed with talwars and shields, and four or five peons.

1. Mir Hoosein Uddin Chaudhari, zamindar of tappa Nazirpúr.
2. Sib Narain Rai Chaudhari, zamindar of Selímábád.
3. Mir Asad Ali Chaudhari, zamindar of Shaistábád.

Ram Dulab Chakrabarti, Bhowani Prasad Chakrabarti, } taluqdars, Chandradwip.

Kirti Chandra Rai, taluqdar, Ratandi Kalikapúr.

Sib Chandra Rai and Kirti Chandra Rai, taluqdars, pargana Arangpúr.

Khaja Mahomed Dyom and Khaja Chand, taluqdars, taluq Salkneenah.

Bhowani Prasad Rai, merchant at Sutaluri.

Question 29.

There are few or no roads besides those I am now making at Barisál, except an indifferent one at Bákarganj, about four miles long.

Question 30.

The convicts are employed from sunrise to sunset (two hours at noon for eating excepted) in making roads, clearing jungle, digging tanks, and raising the ground about the new station.

[In reply to question 32, Mr Wintle says that he does not think commissions should be issued to zamindars and others to act as justices of the peace, &c.; and in reply to question 33 he makes many suggestions about the appointment, &c., of village chaukidars.]

Question 34.

The tax on spirituous liquors has certainly rendered drunkenness less prevalent. [Still Mr Wintle thinks drinking has become more general within the last few years.]

Question 38.

[Mr Wintle thinks that dacoits and thieves have increased since the abolition of the Mahomedan punishment of amputation.[1]]

[1] This report is in a printed volume in the India Office Library. Mr Wintle was probably a better magistrate than he was a writer. His report is full of tautology; but if he had anything to do with the choosing of Barisál as a site, and if, as appears, he laid out the town, he must have been a shrewd executive officer.

The same volume contains reports from the Collectors, but Mr Massie's does not contain anything of special interest. He states that in 1792 Mr Douglas made an estimate of the population of the Dacca District (which then included Bákarganj and Faridpúr), and that it came to 938,712.

Mr Wintle does not state the population, but it appears from Mr Adam's Report on Education in Bengal that it was afterwards furnished, for he states the population of Bákarganj in 1801 to have been 926,723, and that Hindus were to Mahomedans in the proportion of 5 to 3.

The fort of Sangrám referred to in answer 24 has now disappeared, but the name is still known in the Mendiganj thana (see note, p. 43). From answer No. 2 it appears that Mr Wintle did not know of the Civil Court's having existed in 1782 (see p. 311).

(B.)

Extract from Mr Pellew's Article on the Physical Characteristics of Bákarganj.

The district of Backergunge is situated wholly within the lower Delta of the Ganges—that is to say, in that part of the Delta where the beds of the watercourses are all below the level of the sea at high tide. All of these are in consequence subject to tidal influence, and although during the height of the rains the water does not turn in the principal channels, but flows constantly towards the sea, it rises and falls as considerably as in the dry season. Owing to the incessant motion of the water at a considerable velocity, all the channels (which are innumerable) are kept open and navigable for boats proportioned to their size, and there is probably no part of India where such perfect access by water to every part of the district can be obtained. The district is, in fact, covered with a network of kháls most intricate in their windings and intercommunications, and apparently without any order or regularity. But although in a district so essentially flat, an organised system of natural drainage would scarcely be looked for, we find that in fact the whole district, except where the great Megna and Aryal Khan river have obliterated the old features of the country by recent deposits over its northern and eastern portions, may be divided into distinct drainage districts, each of them containing corresponding features.

In undulating tracts of country the drainage ordinarily radiates from elevated centres towards the circumjacent coast-line. In alluvial formations, on the contrary, owing to the excess of deposit on the edges, the water flows inwards from an elevated surrounding and enclosing ridge to a central basin, from whence it is conducted to the exterior along watercourses, piercing through this surrounding ridge. And this order is followed not merely in tidal districts like Backergunge, but in all alluvial formations, however elevated—as, for example, in Sylhet [or in Behar.]

Each of the drainage circles or districts of Backergunge, then, possesses its central basin or reservoir of swamp towards which the surface slopes in every direction from the exterior. On the exterior edge of the area, where it abuts on the large tidal rivers (which everywhere divide one drainage circle from another), the land is well raised and covered with villages. The intermediate space is covered with rice cultivation, and the centre is a lake or *beel*, varying in size and depth with the season of the year.

From points not very far from the centre of this beel, and quite submerged in the rains, numerous little watercourses proceed in every direction towards the edge. These can only be recognised by the fact that a current flows along them, and by the narrow submerged rims of deposited earth which enclose them on either side

and partially separate them from the beel proper. Beginning almost in nothing, many combine to form others, which, though still within the beel and with banks submerged by its waters, present more defined features. At last, by the coalescence of many, a watercourse is formed, with banks which, though but a few feet wide and sloping rapidly towards the beel-water, are yet in the dry season above the water. After further convergence of such channels, we find ourselves (supposing we are attempting to find our way out of the beel by water) in a khál of moderate dimensions, with banks which are not submerged except in the height of the rains; we are still probably many stages from the great rivers, whose banks are permanently above the water, and which are some hundreds of yards in width. But it is useless to particularise further. The numerous kháls which originate in the depths of the central reservoir terminate in some two or three considerable channels which open into the circumposed main watercourse. Between this latter and the beel there is no water communication except through these two or three channels and their ramifications. Even if a short cut were artificially made direct into the beel, it would in a few rainy seasons, by sucking in at the ebb tide the water from all directions, create for itself a branched system of terminations under water, which in the dry weather would be exposed to view.

The whole system depends on the principle that inundating waters, if in a condition to lay down deposit, do so chiefly upon their actual banks, and thus tend to shut themselves off from the tract of submergeable country beyond. As the banks rise, the rush of water over them at ebb and flood is intensified, and at length bursts open channels of communication. These throw up enclosing banks in their turn, which process gives birth to new connecting channels piercing these new banks, and the process is repeated till the communicating channels become so small as scarcely to be noticed.

It is obvious that in this manner the drainage of flat surfaces is performed in the most effectual manner. In undulating or mountainous countries the drainage derives sufficient force from gravity to maintain the channels open, but in alluvial flats the slow passage of the water would scarcely suffice. If in a tidal district the drainage channels merely flowed from the interior of each patch of land towards the circumference, they would soon fill with sediment brought in by the tide, which would ebb and flow in them with but slight velocity; but where these channels are the only means of communication between two considerable bodies of water constantly differing from each other in level, a high rate of speed is easily maintained.

In the rainy season the drainage reservoirs are connected much more directly with the exterior than during the remainder of the year. The water, from various causes, stands at an average at least six feet higher than in the dry season, and completely submerges all the interior articulations of the system of relieving channels. Only the larger and more external have their banks above the water;

the smaller feeders are supplied both from their extremities and over their own banks. The greater volume of water which then requires passage is thus amply provided for; whilst in the dry weather, when the drainage volume is weak, the water is unable on account of the fall in its level to leave the reservoir except through the extreme ends of very small channels. The banks of the different classes or grades of channels, each in turn, begin to fulfil their proper functions, as the level decreases, and in this manner the waterway is always exactly proportioned to the volume to which it is required to give passage.

In districts of alluvium raised above tidal influence the rise and fall of the rivers during the rainy season produce similar effects. The water on the swamps being only connected with these by narrow channels piercing the banks of the rivers, is always, unless the river remains very long at exactly the same level, either above or below that level, and the channels are incessantly occupied in restoring the balance.

The swamps or drainage reservoirs are themselves an interesting feature in the physical geography of Backergunge. They vary greatly in size, in accordance with the area of the tract they drain, and the amount of *filling up* which they have undergone. In the eastern portion of the district, the alluvium from the Megna has completely obliterated the whole drainage organisation, which has become enveloped in one uniform mound sloping towards the west, and forming the right bank of this immense watercourse. In the western portion of the district where the system of drainage prevails which we have endeavoured to describe, the swamps during the rainy season fill up the whole of each drainage tract, except its extreme margin and the banks of the primary channels which penetrate that margin. In the dry weather they become reduced to the extent of the nucleus or central portion from which the relieving channels take their rise. This nucleus is often of considerable depth, and is generally covered by a floating surface of matted grass and earth on which Nul, Hoogla, and Koonda reed sometimes grow; at other places it is covered with a short, coarse, but very green grass, abounding in snipe. In parts where the covering is thick enough to support the cultivators, rice is sown in the dry season. It is dangerous to tread on this shaking surface except where the straw *hiras*, or small retaining embankments which mark the fields, show that people have been before. Even through the midst of this quaking bog the small ramifying watercourses are to be found, and on their margins, though two or three feet deep under water, a firm footing is generally obtainable. Their beds also are ordinarily composed of a hard mixture of sand and clay, and it is only in the interspaces that the floating surface exists. The smaller beels are very useful as village boundaries. The inhabitants on either side cultivate as far as they prudently can, and abandon the centre to jungle and water-fowl.

From the beel on every side the country rises with considerable

slope, the first footing being generally found in the watercourses. The drainage towards the beel is along successive terraces of rice-fields, each a few inches lower than the next above it. The water is retained in the higher ground for cultivation by means of the little hiras or banks (here constructed of straw as well as earth) common throughout Bengal. It may be repeated here that all the surface drainage of the tract surrounding each beel flows towards it, and never into the penetrating channels, whose banks are always higher than the ground outside, and always slope away from the channel.

The level of the sea at the head of the Bay of Bengal, and on the tidal watercourses of the Delta, is subject to a considerable annual alteration. It is a doubtful point whether this alteration is to be attributed to the influx of fresh water in such immense quantities, or to the banking up of the sea by the south-west monsoon. As the increased elevation occurs during the rainy season, when both these influences are at work, it is extremely difficult to decide the question, and both are probably concerned in the result. The change of level is not confined to the head of the bay, but is found some distance down the east coast of India. In Backergunge the difference in mean level must be at least four feet. This is an important point, for, as the whole district of Backergunge is nearly horizontal, the water at high tide in the rainy season floods nearly the whole of it, and the inhabitants are obliged to raise their houses on mounds. It is owing to this alteration in the level of the tides, rather than to the mere local rainfall, that the change in the level of the beels takes place.

(C.)

I.—Prices.

The following interesting facts regarding prices are extracted from a manuscript volume in the India Office:—

"Rice, which forty years ago was two and a half maunds per arcot[1] rupee, is now [November 1800] one and a half maunds per arcot rupee. Salt, which at the same period was one arcot rupee per maund, is now four sicca rupees per maund. Oil, which was

[1] The arcot rupee seems to have been worth about one per cent. more than the Government rupee. As regards the price of salt in old times, see Sir Philip Francis' letter of 22d January 1776, where he says that the Company had declared in their letter of 20th November 1767 that they had rather that even the duties should be reduced than that the price of salt to the consumer should ever exceed Rs.140 sicca per 100 maunds.

two and a half arcot rupees per maund, is now four arcot rupees per maund. Other articles were also enhanced in price. *Cappas* [cotton], which used to be at the rate of from four to five puns per sír, was last year at six, and is this year at nine puns. Thread of all kinds, excepting the finest, is much dearer now than formerly. In 1787 and 1788 a great number of spinners died of famine; this and the increased price of necessaries of life are considered as the principal cause of the present dearness of thread. Labour is likewise raised; the pay of a weaver forty years ago was from one to one and a half arcot rupee, and of a journeyman from eight anas to twelve anas per month. The pay of the former is now from two and a half arcot rupees to three and a half arcot rupees, and of the latter from one arcot rupee to two arcot rupees. Rent also is said to be raised, and what formerly was eight anas per *pakhi* [a little less than a bigha] is now twelve anas."

In the same letter reference is made to "the great diminution in the demand for the fabrics of this province, which has prevailed since the commencement of the present war in Europe" (Letter of Mr John Taylor, Commercial Resident at Dacca, dated 30th November 1800, and forwarded to the Court of Directors by Commercial Letter from Bengal dated 1st December 1801). Mr Taylor gives interesting particulars of the cultivation of cotton and of the weaving processes. In a postscript, dated November 1801, he states that the population of the city of Dacca had been estimated by the Magistrate to be 200,000.

Some interesting statistics about prices will be found in appendix to a report of Board of Customs, Salt and Opium, 26th January 1832 (Calcutta, 1833). See especially p. 120.

II.—India Office Records.

The India Office in Westminster contains Revenue Consultations of the Dacca Factory from 1736. Many papers appear to be wanting, and those which remain do not possess much interest, as they are chiefly taken up with details of the weaving business and of the Company's investment. Those were days when, as Lord Macaulay has remarked, "the ablest servants of the Company were busied only about invoices and bills of lading." How unprepared we were for a larger conception of our duties is shown by the following extract from a Dacca minute of 20th July 1763, which was written by Messrs Leycester and Senior on their return to Dacca after they had quitted it on the outbreak of the war with Mir Kassim: "Having recovered our factory, &c., with the assistance of the Meckly detachment, and also taken possession of the city, the collections and the revenue of so large a district is an important business which we are not much acquainted with, and having no

man belonging to the factory equal to so great a charge, it is agreed to call on the officers of the Government to resume the management of their several offices in the name of our honourable masters till we are informed from the President and Council through what channel these matters are in future to pass."

The records extend from 1736 to 1763, then there appears to be a blank up to 1772, when we have the report of the Committee of Circuit. Then come the reports of the proceedings of the Provincial Council, which commence in 1774 and go down to 1779. The following notes are arranged chronologically, and contain such passages as appeared to me of interest, especially with reference to Bákarganj:—

August 1737.—Aga Bákar, foujdar, is said to have taken Rs.3000 as hush-money from the chaudhari of a pargana in connection with a theft of cloth from the Jagdea Factory.

October 1737.—On the 30th ult. and 1st inst. there happened a storm here and in the adjacent countries, the most violent that has been known in the memory of man. It began at eleven o'clock of the night, and blew very violent from north-east till seven in the morning, when it returned from the south-west with double violence. This storm destroyed almost every boat and vessel that was on the river, and ashore blew down vast numbers of buildings, and among the rest the honourable Company's bungalows that were for the use of the washermen and their workmen at Tezgong and on the wharf. A consultation of the 17th idem refers to information having been received from the President of the loss of several of the Company's ships in the hurricane.

N.B.—This is the storm which did so much damage in Calcutta and the Sundarbans, and which is referred to in the "Gentleman's Magazine" for 1738–39. See "Calcutta Review" for March 1859, article "Gangetic Delta."

24*th November* 1737.—Letter from Mr Pomfret of Jagdea, dated 18th idem, stating that they have advice that the Mugs are come out in great numbers, and the country around them being full of dacoits, who have already done considerable mischief, &c.

Another storm took place on 31st May 1739, and the three following days.

December 1744.—Sergeant Cooper being sent with 30,000 arcot rupees to Jagdea, reports that there were a great many Mugs in the way. Resolved to send him all the European soldiers in the factory.

4*th June* 1745.—A sloop returning from Dacca to Calcutta had been attacked by dacoits near Serampore, who had plundered the crew of what they had and murdered five of them, after having cut the rigging, sails, cables, &c. Having information also of several sloops and boats being on the way from Calcutta to Dacca, and that as the ways between this and Bawkergange (*sic*) are greatly infested with dacoits, it was agreed that a party of ten men, with a sergeant, corporal, and ten Baxeries, (?) be sent down as far as Bawkergange, and convey hither all vessels belonging to the English.

30*th December* 1745.—Apprehensions about the Mahrattas.

January 1746.—Resolve to put a parapet wall round the factory as a protection against the Mahrattas.

1749.—Mr Nicholas Clerembault became chief. He had joined on 9th March 1744, when he took his seat as the youngest of Council.

30*th December* 1754.—Raj Ballab Duan intimates that on the change of the head Nabobship of Dacca, which is now in the name of Muradda Doulla, he expects a large present, and even hinted the sum of Rs.10,000. Resolved to give him Rs.3000, if the payment is absolutely necessary.

15*th November* 1755.—Nicholas Clerembault, Esq., chief of this factory, departed this life of a violent fever. Doubtless this is the Columbo Saheb whose tomb Bishop Heber mentions.

23*d October* 1757.—Nabob communicated his apprehensions of his safety.

July 1763.—Council had fled from Dacca, and taken up their quarters at Luckypúr.

22*d July* 1763.—Mir Jaffar Ali Khan proclaimed Souba.

We now come to the report of the Dacca Committee of Circuit, 1772, which is in a separate volume. It does not, however, contain much which is interesting. There is a long report in it, dated 25th September 1772, from William Makepeace Thackeray, about the lime quarries in Sylhet. He was appointed Collector of that district on 10th October 1772. The volume also contains long reports of the disputes between Gokal Ghosal and the zamindars of Sandwip, and would doubtless be very interesting to any one writing the history of Chittagong or Noakháli. The following is the advertisement, dated 3d October 1772, which the Committee of Circuit published when they proceeded to settle the land revenue :—

"Notice is hereby given that the lands of the Dacca District, as also those of Sylhet, will be let in farm for the term of five years, agreeable to the conditions that have been already advertised; all persons therefore who are willing to farm, and can produce respectable securities, are directed to deliver in sealed proposals specifying the amount rent they offer to give for each pargana separately." It will be seen from this that the claims of zamindars and taluqdars, or the rights of the tenantry, were not much considered in those days.

17*th February* 1774.—Regulations about the post office.

5*th April* 1774.—Petition from Mani Ram Dabee, son of Dyal Chaudhari, claiming Buzurgumedpúr. States that his father reclaimed it from jungle, and that during the administration of Murshid Kuli Khan, Aga Bákar infamously sent people to seize on the daughter of Dyal Chaudhari, whereon he, being driven to the greatest pitch of desperation, relinquished his estate and effects, and destroyed all the female portion of his family. Petitioner afterwards tried to recover the property, but was thwarted by the intrigues of Raj Ballab's sons. The latter replied, saying that they bought the property in 1167 from Mirza Mendi, the brother, and Mahomed Salé, the son

of Mahomed Sadok, who was son of Aga Bákar. They added that in 1737 the property belonged to Udai Rajah and Mahomed Reza, after which Aga Bákar got it, and recorded the estate in his son Sadok's name. (This is the name in the old Collectorate papers.)

3*d May* 1774.—The Calcutta Council rejected the claim on the ground, first, that Dyal Chaudhari had been regularly dispossessed by the government of the Nazim for rebellion; and secondly, because Aga Bákar was regularly appointed to the zamindari by the same reigning government about thirty-three years ago, in the light of a reward for his services in reducing the rebellious Dyal Chaudhari. There is also a petition, dated 6th May 1774, from Mirza Mendi and Katissa Khanam, setting forth that on Aga Bákar's death in 1160, Mahomed Sadok absconded, upon which Raj Ballab confiscated his effects. In 1164 Mahomed Sadok returned, and obtained the wadadari of the pargana for his son, Mahomed Salé, under the seal of Nawab Jaffar Ali Khan, and was himself reinstated in his zamindari. In 1166 Mahomed Sadok died, and in 1167 Raj Ballab dispossessed petitioners. Apparently this petition was dismissed.

20*th June* 1774.—Much correspondence about char Bhuta, and reference to a trial about it in Luckypúr Civil Court 10th June 1773.

Idem.—Reference to Calcutta about an order, dated 17th May 1774, directing that from 1st July 1774 no person shall be allowed to buy or sell a slave who is not such already by former legal purchase, and any kazi who shall grant any kawala after that date for the sale of any slave whatever shall be dismissed.

The Dacca Council writes, "As it is an established custom throughout the Dacca districts to keep in bondage the offspring of slaves who have once become so, agreed that we address the honourable President and Council of Revenue, requesting to be informed whether the benefit of the Regulation is to be extended to the future offspring of such persons who may at present be in slavery." The Calcutta Council replied on 12th July as follows: "In those districts where slavery is a general usage, or in any way connected with, or is likely to have an influence on the revenue, which we are informed is the case in Sylhet, and may be so in the other, especially the frontier parts of your division, we must desire you particularly to advise us what is the usage, and every circumstance connected with it, and we shall then give you such direction as we may judge necessary; but considering your question in the meantime in the light of a general proposition, we are of opinion that the right of masters to the children of the slaves already their property cannot legally be taken from them in the first generation, but we think that this right cannot and ought not to extend farther, and direct that you do make publication accordingly."

5*th July* 1774.—Severe orders from Calcutta against the impressment of ryots as coolies by travellers.

11*th July* 1774. — Appointment of foujdars. Boundaries of Bákarganj thana—south, Aurungábád pargana; north, Sundarkul; east, Jalálpúr; west, Syedpúr in Dacca.

30*th July* 1774.—French letter from M. des Granges, reporting that the French have abandoned their Dacca factory.

13*th August* 1774.—The President and Council of Calcutta send a price-current of grain, which has been made the standard for collecting the Government duties upon throughout the provinces, from which, the Collectors have been informed, they are not on any account to deviate. The standard is fixed so very low that it must remove every just ground of complaint from the rice merchants.

The Government duty of 2½ per cent. was to be levied according to this standard, which was to be current over Bengal, Behar, and Orissa. I give the more important items:—

	Mans.	Sírs.		Mans.	Sírs.
Horse grain, per rupee	1	26	Rice, 1st sort, per rupee	1	10
Green grain (*sona möog*), per rupee	1	10	Rice, 2d sort, „ „	1	20
Barley, per rupee	2	30	Rice, 3d sort „ „	1	30
Ashar „ „	1	20	Paddy „ „	2	20
Wheat „ „	1	10	Mustard „ „	1	0
			Til „ „	0	30

21*st August* 1775.—Petition from Gopal Kissen, zamindar of Buzurgumedpúr, asking for remission of the *phanri malwa* (called here *phannaly malwa*, and also *panny malwa*), on the ground that it had been abolished when taxes on grain were removed. In these proceedings we at last meet with an explanation of the term, a witness stating that the tax was a duty levied on grain, timber, and all kinds of goods under transportation. The Calcutta Council relieved Gopal Kissen from the obligation of paying it (see p. 100).

1775.—Frequent notices of a Mr Wood, who was salt agent at Jainagar—*i.e.*, Jhalukátti.

18*th January* 1776.—Report on French factories states that the French carry on a trade in rice and cotton thread at Bákarganj, where a gomasta resides continually, with two or three sepoys.

29*th July* 1777.—Extract from Court of Directors' letter stating that they had revoked their orders to let the lands to the highest bidders, and signifying their pleasure to have them occupied by hereditary zamindars. Strict orders are given for insisting on every zamindar and farmer giving leases to their tenants.

21*st July* 1777.—Report on the arcot rupee, which has been "the only specie of general currency in this country time out of mind, and yet they never were coined at the Dacca mint." Also send proposals for the settlement of the Dacca Province.

11*th July* 1778.—Notice of declaration of war between France and England. Flight of M. Chevalier. List of all the Europeans in the Dacca Province. The total is about fifty.

8*th September* 1778.—Mr Hatch claims to be put in charge of Sylhet. Mr Holland dissents, and supports Lindsay.

Complaint of Chandradwip zamindar against Baksh Ali, foujdar of thana Barisál (10 September 1779).

19*th November* 1778, *Arangpúr*.—Case between taluqdars and

zamindars. Vakil of zamindars states a division took place in 1158, after death of Janaki Ballab, into four equal shares, and again in 1172. This was found correct, and Board ordered taluqdars to pay the shareholders.

2d September 1779.—Remarks of Calcutta Council on settlement of Dacca districts for 1186—*i.e.*, 1779: "We particularly enjoin you never, in any instance whatever, to propose any abatement of any nature whatever unless you can at the same time clearly point out how such deficiency may be supplied. In short, it is our determination that the Dacca Division shall yield to the Government an annual revenue of Rs.2,985,549."

There is also a separate volume giving in detail the settlement for 1184—*i.e.*, 1777.

N.B.—The Dacca papers contain many interesting reports about the Jyntia Rajah, Sylhet, Sandwip, &c. There is much correspondence about Sandwip in a volume for 1774, but by far the fullest report on Sandwip is to be found in the Bengal Revenue Council Reports for 1780, vol. vi. This voluminous report extends over 491 paragraphs, exclusive of appendices, and contains a genealogical table of the Sandwip zamindars, and a statement of its revenue from as far back as 1069 A.H.—*i.e.*, 1662—when the Moghals first got possession of it. The report is written by Mr Jonathan Duncan (I presume the famous Jonathan Duncan of Benares and Bombay). He was sent to Sandwip to report on the murder of one Mahomed Kain, and lived on the island for a considerable time.

III.—Famines of 1770 and 1787.

Dr Hunter observes, in his "Annals of Rural Bengal" (p. 28), that the only non-official description of the famine of 1770 by an eye-witness is a metrical one; but, in fact, there is a tolerably full description of it in a letter in the "Gentleman's Magazine" for September 1771, vol. xli. p. 402. The letter was forwarded to the editor by one J. C., who describes himself as having just received it from a very worthy friend of his in the Company's service in Calcutta.[1] The same letter appears in the "Scots Magazine" for September 1771, vol. xxxiii. p. 454; and there are also references to the subject at pages 160 and 216 of the same volume. See also the "Gentleman's Magazine" for February 1772, p. 69. It is probably to the above letter that Warren Hastings refers to when he speaks of the effects of the famine having been made known "to the public by laboured descriptions, in which every circumstance of fact and every art of languages have been accumulated to raise compassion, and to excite

[1] Though the letter is from a Company's servant, it is non-official in the sense in which Dr Hunter uses the word, or otherwise Lord Teignmouth's verses could not be called non-official.

indignation against your [the Company's] servants" (Warren Hastings' letter, Appendix G of Dr Hunter's Annals, p. 380). It would appear, however, from Charles Grant's "Observations on the State of Society in Asia" (General Appendix, No. I., to House of Commons Report of 1833), that the French of Chandarnagore were the first to accuse the English of being the authors of the famine, and probably therefore detailed descriptions of it are to be found in the French papers of that period. Mr Grant himself gives some particulars of the famine. His paper was written in 1792, and he tells us that he derived his information partly from his own observations and partly from a manuscript account by Mr Becher. Mr Becher was then resident at the Durbar (Murshídábád), and was, I presume, the person quoted by Sir Philip Francis (*vide* note, p. 376). Mr Grant says Mr Becher saved the country in 1770 by laying in 60,000 mans of rice for the use of the army, and that he was a man noted for his honesty and humanity. "His anxiety and exertions for alleviating the miseries of that whole period ended in an illness which almost cost him his life. Yet on his return to England he found himself traduced as the author of the famine." Unfortunately the charge of turning the public distress into a source of private profit was true as regards some servants of the Company, and Mr Becher had only himself to thank for the odium he incurred, inasmuch as he neglected to restrain or even give up the names of those who had through their native servants not only "monopolised the grain, but compelled the poor ryots to sell the seed requisite for the next harvest." (See Court of Directors' letter, Appendix B, p. 420, Hunter's Annals.)

Notices of the 1787 famine will be found in "Calcutta Gazettes" of 20th September 1787 and 27th March 1788. The last shows that Bákarganj rice was sent to Dacca.

IV.—Establishment of Civil Courts at Bákarganj.

At p. 889 of the Sixth Report of the House of Commons there is printed a Revenue Department Consultation, dated 6th April 1781, which gives us the details of the first establishment of a court of civil justice at Bákarganj. The following is an extract from the preamble: "The Board, taking into consideration the present state of the administration of civil and criminal justice throughout the provinces, pass the following resolution: That to remedy the inconveniences occasioned by the too extensive jurisdiction of the Mofussil Dewanny Adâlats established by the Resolutions of 28th March 1780, and thereby promote the more rapid and effectual administration of justice, the following Courts of Civil Justice, including those now existing, be established throughout the provinces." Then follow the names of eighteen courts, among which Jessore appears under the

name of Moorly. The boundaries given of Bákarganj are as follows: "The jurisdiction of Buckergunge (*sic*), consisting of that portion of the Dacca Province lying on the south-west of the Ganges or Padma and the Cally Ganges, and to the west of the Meghna from Chandpúr to the sea; having as its western limits the eastern frontier of Boosna and Jessore, down to the mouth of the river of Raj Mongal, including also all the islands belonging to and situated on the coast of the Dacca Province, except the pargana of Sandwip and its dependencies."

The Resolution farther directs that the Civil Judges shall have the power of apprehending dacoits, &c., though not of trying them, and that the Nawab be requested to withdraw all his phousdars except the phousdar of Hughli.

The above orders are also published in Colebrooke's Digest, vol. iii.

V.—Character of the People.

The following interesting remarks on the character of the Bákarganj population, &c., are taken from a letter by Mr Meredith (?) Parker, printed in the appendix to Mr Plowden's salt report. Mr Parker's letter is dated 15th September 1832, and the object of it is to rebut the assertion that the molunghies or salt-makers were not free agents:—

"I believe I am well warranted in asserting that no portion of Lower Bengal, with the exception perhaps of the Nuddea district, has ever been considered so difficult to manage. I speak with reference to matters of police, as the Twenty-four Parganas, the Jessore and Bákarganj zillahs, the chars and islands at the mouth of the Meghna and Chittagong, but more especially the belt of cultivated land which accompanies or invades the line of the Sundarbans in the three first-mentioned districts. It need scarcely be observed that everywhere people dwelling on the frontiers of great forests, the pioneers before whose hatchets these forests recede, people who dwell in islands surrounded by broad and dangerous rivers, or on the sea-shore, are noted, as compared with their fellow-countrymen in other parts of the same land, for hardihood and roughness of character, nor am I inclined to believe that Bengal offers any exception to this nearly general rule. Now, four-fifths of the molunghies belong to the above class, and certainly no more unfavourable selection could be made for trying the experiment of coerced labour if all Bengal had been searched for the purpose. Attempts at coercion which might bewilder and intimidate the quiet weavers of Dacca or Murshídábád, would, I apprehend, meet with a very different reception from the borderers in the Sundarbans; the woodcutters and fishermen of the Twenty-four Parganas, Jessore, and Bákarganj; the ryots of Bhulloah

[Noakháli], ever braining each other in boundary disputes; and the litigious, unmanageable people of Chittagong. For my own part, had I a public measure of an unpopular nature, or which would be considered oppressive by the ryots, to carry into effect, I confess I should prefer being appointed to make the experiment in any portion of Bengal rather than in the districts I have adverted to, and I believe the Magistrates and other public officers who have had experience of them would agree with me in this preference."

In the same letter Mr Parker asserts that cultivation is essential to the salt manufacture, as the rice straw is used for boiling the water. This seems too strongly put, but still it is satisfactory to know that there is not necessarily any opposition between cultivation and salt-making. We may therefore hope that the reclamation of the Sundarbans and the chars will not prevent the revival of the salt trade.

VI.—Dacoits.

There is a curious passage in Mill's "Logic," where he speaks of the English bringing with them into Bengal the phrase "landed proprietor," and of the confusion which it led them into. "They gave an absolute right to one who had only a limited right, from another, because he had not an absolute right, they took away all right, drove whole classes of men to ruin and despair, *filled the country with banditti*, created a feeling that nothing was secure, and produced, with the best intentions, a disorganisation of society which had not been produced in the country by the most ruthless of its barbarous invaders" (book iv. chap. v. Natural History of the Variations in the Meaning of Terms).

This passage apparently refers to the formation of the Permanent Settlement, and makes it answerable for the filling of the country with banditti. But as regards the eastern districts, at all events, the quotations given in my book show that dacoity flourished there long before 1790. I suspect that Mill borrowed the illustration from his father, who was prejudiced against the Permanent Settlement.

VII.—Early Travellers in Bengal.

An interesting article might be written on this subject, but as I am only dealing with the history of one district, it would be out of place for me to go into much detail. With the help of my friend Dr Wise I have searched a great many books in the hope of finding some particulars about early Bákarganj, but the result has been

disappointing. In conducting an inquiry of this kind, one is, I think, most struck with the tremendous amount of waste with which the carrying on of the world's work is accompanied. The same facts are repeated in scores of books in the same or in different languages, so that about nine-tenths of them are superfluous; and hardly any book can be found which goes farther than its neighbours, or gives any information which is novel and valuable. The earliest European traveller in Bengal appears to have been Varthema (Vertomannus) of Bologna, who was in Bengal about 1507. His travels have been translated for the Hakluyt Society (1863), and the editor discusses in the introduction the question of the site of the town of Bengala or Banghella, which Varthema describes himself as having visited. The editor supposes that it was situated between Hattia and Sandwip, and it has occurred to me that perhaps it is after all identical with Fitch's Bacola. Le Blanc of Marseilles, who was in Bengal some ten years before Fitch, speaks of Bengala as being the principal town of Bengal, but adds the important observation that the native name of it was Batacouta. Faria y Sousa, and perhaps some other writers, seem to call Bacola sometimes Baticala,[1] which is very near to Le Blanc's word, especially when we consider how easily *t* may be mistaken for an *l* in printing from a manuscript.

Le Blanc must have been in Bengal shortly after Cæsar Frederick, and, curiously enough, he too was forced by stress of weather to land at Sandwip. Unfortunately Le Blanc's travels were not published till after his death, and perhaps they were not written down till long after his return. At all events, they contain allusions to things—*e.g.*, the reception of the Jesuit priests by the King of Chandecan, which did not take place till some twenty years after his return home.

Another early traveller in Bengal is Sebastian Manrique (referred to in a paper by Dr Wise). He was in India and Arracan from 1628 to 1641, in the capacity of an Augustinian missionary. He describes Shahbázpúr, and also an island which he calls Sagaldiva—*i.e.*, he says, all-rich. He says that these islands had become depopulated on account of the continual wars between the Portuguese, the Arracanese, and the Moghals. He also describes Sandwip, and gives some particulars about Gonzales, whom he calls the Portuguese "King of Sundiva." He describes the Sundarbans and his shipwreck in the neighbourhood, but unfortunately I am not sufficiently acquainted with Spanish fully to understand him.

I may here note that the most complete list of early works on India appears to be that given in Don Antonio de Leon Pinelo's work entitled "Epitome de la Bibliotheca Oriental," &c., Madrid, 1737.

The earliest map of Bengal appears to be Gastaldi's (1561). A facsimile of it is given in the Hakluyt Society's translation of Varthema's Travels (Dr Badger's introduction).

[1] There was also a Baticala in Canara and another in Ceylon.

VIII.—Francis Fernandez.

Francis Fernandez and his companion Dominic da Sosa were the first Jesuits who visited Bengal, and they probably deserve the honour of being reckoned the first missionaries to the Bengalis. They were not, however, the first priests in the country, for they found a curate in Gullo on their arrival in May 1598. This Gullo appears to me to be identical with Bandel, which last was a name given to all Portuguese stations in Bengal. Fernandez describes it as being 210 miles from the mouth of the Ganges, and says that it took them eight days to ascend the river to it. Gullo was evidently one of the earliest, if not the very earliest station of the Portuguese in Bengal, and so we know was Bandel, the church bell of which bears the date 1599. When the Jesuits speak of their church at Chandecan as being the first erected by their order, they do not thereby deny the priority of that of Bandel. Fernandez and his companion stayed at Gullo till October, and they employed themselves there in the laudable work of establishing a hospital, which I suppose must have been the first in Bengal. From Gullo they went to Chandecan, and stayed there till December, when they went on to Sripúr. Fernandez describes Chandecan as lying half way between Porto Grande (Chittagong) and Porto Piccolo (Gullo?), and says that the king's dominions were so extensive that it would take fifteen or twenty days to traverse them. He adds, that it has a great trade in bees'-wax, which is produced in the jungles, so that there were Sundarbans then also. There were dacoits also, and Fernandez says they encountered great dangers from them and from tigers on the way from Gullo to Chandecan.

Fernandez' first letter was written from Sripúr, and was dated either 14th or 19th January 1599 (both dates are given). It will be found at length in the edition of Pimenta's letter published at Venice in 1602, but the note of Aquaviva prefixed to this edition states that the letter was originally printed in Latin. It would seem, therefore, that the statement in my text (p. 29) is a mistake, and that the missionaries originally wrote in Latin. The edition states on the titlepage that Pimenta's letter was written from Goa on 25th December 1598, but the date given at the conclusion of the book shows that 98 is a mistake for 99. A Portuguese edition of the letter was published at Lisbon in 1602. There is a short biography of Fernandez in Bartholomé Alcazar's "Chronicle of the Jesuit Worthies of the Province of Toledo," Madrid, 1710. From it we learn that Fernandez was born at a place called La Villa de Huerta, near Toledo, and that he entered the University of Alcala in 1570, when he was twenty years old. He arrived in Goa in 1575, and died in 1602, when he was only about fifty-two, though Du Jarric and Alcazar speak of him as being weighed down by years.

(D.)

Two Bákarganj Cases.

1. *Story of Karimuddin.*

I only mention this story to show to what desperate lengths Bengalis will occasionally go in the prosecution of their revenge. Karimuddin was an idle, dissolute fellow, and a thief. One night he was seen by some of his fellow-villagers stealing fish from their nets, and they gave him chase but could not catch him, and so had to content themselves with giving him a volley of abuse. Karimuddin resolved to be revenged, and the method he took was this. He had an old father who had been bedridden for two or three years, and whom he felt to be a burden to him, so he actually took up a bludgeon and fractured his father's skull, and then hurried in with the body to the police station and laid a charge of murder against the people who had abused him. The case was investigated, and I am glad to say that the truth came out, and that Karimuddin was transported for life.

2. *Story of Jabar Ula.*

Some three years ago there was a Mahomedan peasant, named Jabar Ula, who lived with his wife and family on the banks of the river Meghna. The homestead was a joint one—that is to say, he and his family lived in one part of it, and another family, distantly related to his, occupied the remainder. The lands attached to the homestead were cultivated in common by the two families, an arrangement which led to occasional disputes about the produce. One day Jabar Ula had a quarrel with a woman of the neighbouring family about the division of a quantity of sesame or oil seeds which had been spread out to dry in the courtyard. Jabar Ula wanted to carry off his share, and the woman said he was taking more than he was entitled to. I suppose she used her tongue pretty freely, for at last Jabar Ula got so angry that he tried to strike her, and in doing so he happened to twitch off her upper garment. She rushed off to her brothers, who had just come in from the field, and complained of the affront. Her two brothers at once came into the courtyard, seized Jabar Ula, and gave him such a beating that he at last fell down insensible. Terrified at this, the two lifted him up, gave him water, and finally carried him into his house and laid him down on his bed. Some days after this Jabar Ula's wife sent word by the village watchman to the police station that her husband had died of his beating, and that the murderers had broken into her house and carried off the dead body. The police went out to the village, which was a good way off, and commenced an investigation. No

trace of Jabar Ula's body could be found, and his widow gave a circumstantial account to the police of how her husband had lain insensible for two or three days after his beating, how he had got worse and worse, and how she and his mother had watched by his side night after night until he died. When they saw that all was over, and that they were widowed and childless, the two women gave way to their grief, and broke out into the lamentable cries which Bengali women use on such occasions. The accused heard them, and knowing what the cries meant, and that there was no safety for them if Jabar Ula's body remained where it was, and if the marks of violence on it were seen by the authorities, they broke into the room, which had only mat walls, and carried off the corpse. The widow could tell no more, but the accused were now arrested, and they told the rest of the story. They acknowledged to the police that all that the widow had said was true, and added that they had put the body on board of a small boat, rowed out to the middle of the stream, which was there two or three miles wide, and then flung the body into the river. On this they were sent into Barisál to appear before the Magistrate, and I well recollect that their confessions were recorded in my presence, that they were full and particular, and that each prisoner told the same story. The case was made over to another Magistrate, who examined the witnesses and then committed the accused to the Court of Session on charges of murder, &c. Before the trial came on the prisoners said to their attorney that they were innocent of the murder, and that Jabar Ula was not really dead. They, however, admitted that they had beaten him, and that they could not produce him. On this their attorney advised them to plead guilty, and to throw themselves on the mercy of the Court. "It is of no use," he said, "for you to deny the crime; you can't produce Jabar Ula, and you have no witnesses who can say where he is. On the other hand, his widow and his mother are prepared to swear that they saw him die, and that they saw you carry off his dead body. Your best plan is to plead guilty, and to plead the provocation Jabar Ula had given by insulting your sister." They took his advice, and acknowledged the genuineness of their confessions before the Magistrate. The witnesses for the prosecution were examined, and repeated the evidence they had given before the Magistrate, and the Judge convicted the prisoners, but passed a comparatively light sentence. As the body had not been found he acquitted them of the charge of murder, and sentenced them to six months' imprisonment for causing grievous hurt, and six months for concealment of evidence, in that they had thrown the body into the river. Altogether they got a year apiece. The prisoners went to jail, and made no appeal; but some seven or eight months afterwards, and while the prisoners were serving out their time in Barisál jail, we were all startled by a rumour that Jabar Ula had turned up, alive and in good health. It was true. A man had come to a country market to make some purchases, and a fellow-villager had recognised him as Jabar Ula. He had changed his

name, and did not want to come forward, but the village watchman insisted on taking him to the police station. There he acknowledged that he was indeed Jabar Ula, and told a marvellous story to account for his reappearance. He had become insensible after he was beaten, he said, and remembered nothing farther until he felt a gnawing sensation in his back, as if some animal were biting him. This awoke him, and he found that he was lying in shallow water on the edge of a sandbank, and that a jackal had been biting him. The animal had come down to drink, and had seen Jabar Ula and thought he was dead. After this Jabar Ula saw a boat passing and hailed it, and was taken by it into the district of Noakháli. After that he lived in various places, but always in hiding, lest he should be discovered by his assailants and murdered by them. We tested his story by sending an officer with him to make inquiries in the various places he had visited. The result did not corroborate his story, and he now began to shuffle about the names of the places he had visited, and to tell conflicting stories. Among other things he dropped the story of the jackal, and said he had been saved by clutching at a plantain-tree which was floating down the river. He also gave up the story of his having been taken to Noakháli. And now, when the evidence of the witnesses in the Court of Session was more closely examined, it was found that the women of Jabar Ula's family had materially altered the statements they made to the Magistrate. Before the Magistrate they had sworn that they had seen the prisoners carry off the dead body of Jabar Ula. Before the Judge they said that they had fallen asleep, worn out with watching and fatigue, and that when they awoke again they found that the body was gone. Moreover, it was clear that the confessions of the prisoners must have been false, at least in part, for they had said that they had flung the body of Jabar Ula into the middle of the Meghna, and it is utterly impossible that he could ever have been saved if he had been flung in there, especially when reduced by illness. By this time the prisoners had heard of the reappearance of Jabar Ula, and had forwarded petitions declaratory of their innocence, and accusing Jabar Ula and his family of getting up a false case against them, and the police of having tortured them into confessing. The prisoners were now sent for, and they made similar statements in person, and no doubt these were the real circumstances. Of course the police denied that they had used any violence to the prisoners, and it was impossible to get proof of this so long after the occurrence; but at the same time they could not get out of the difficulty that Jabar Ula was alive, and that if the confessions were true he must have been dead. The affair was never wholly cleared up, but no doubt remained in the minds of the great body of the public that the case was altogether false except as regards the beating, and that Jabar Ula had, in revenge for his thrashing, slipped away in the night-time and hidden himself for months, having previously arranged with his wife and friends that

they should say he was dead, and accuse the prisoners of having murdered him.

The case thus remains as a memorable instance of the lengths to which a man will go in order to satisfy his revenge, and of the danger of relying too much on confessions of guilt.

Note.—It seems proper to add that I was so convinced of the innocence of the prisoners in this case that I took upon myself to release them in anticipation of the orders of Government. For this irregularity I was deservedly censured, and three Judges of the High Court afterwards decided that there was no ground to interfere with the original conviction. However, the prisoners were not re-presented before the High Court, and there is no doubt that the general opinion in the district is that Jabar Ula never was flung into the river.

(E.)

The Language of the District.

Bengali is the vernacular of Bákarganj, and there are few provincial peculiarities except in pronunciation. I doubt if there be a single word whose use is exclusively confined to Bákarganj; and when we reflect how modern the district is, and what violent changes of boundaries it has undergone during its short life, we can hardly expect to find many peculiarities of language in it. In all the districts of Eastern Bengal we find a good many Arabic and Persian words, due no doubt to the influence of the Mahomedans. These words chiefly relate to administration and jurisdiction, but some of them relate to the arts and sciences, and to domestic life; and it is a shrewd remark of Ram Kamal Sen, in the valuable preface to his English Bengali Dictionary, that the words for *pen* and *paper* are of Arabic or Persian origin, showing that the Sanskrit-speaking people did not know how to make paper.

I once made out a list of such words and phrases as appeared to me to be peculiar to Bákarganj, and sent it to the Commissioner of Dacca, but I am not aware that any use was ever made of it.

Mr Sutherland has given an interesting list at p. 192 of his report on Bákarganj (Principal Heads of the History and Statistics of the Dacca Division, Calcutta, 1868), and to this I beg to refer the reader. The following words and expressions are all I can give at present:—

Nisbat or *nisbati*, a brother-in-law (Arabic).

Kura, a bigha.

Mora, a basket of paddy.

Amiani, without settlement.

Badla, to work for another. This refers to an interesting usage of villagers mutually assisting one another by giving a day's plough-

ing or weeding. (See Mr J. Cockburn's evidence, ans. 458, p. 34 of evidence taken before Indigo Commission, and also paragraph 69 of the report, 1860.)

Bagchar, berm of road.

Khola (not *kola*, as in Sutherland), an open field.

Chár, a bamboo or supari bridge.

Ál, the raised edge of a moat.

When a boat has sunk, boatmen employ the euphemism of *bhala haiache*, literally, it is good.

When the peasantry take to firing homesteads, as they sometimes do in a dispute about rent with their landlord, they are graphically described as setting the red horse a-running (*lál ghora dauran*).

There is a curious expression for a mother-in-law in Bákarganj. She is called *diwanji—i.e., diwan* or manager. Probably this is in allusion to the fact that she is generally the real mistress of the house, the daughter-in-law being too often a mere child.

(F.)

Note to Page 75.

I have not printed the song about Kamala on account of the difficulty in procuring Bengali types.

Note to Page 142.

I believe that the Mr Thackeray here referred to was not the father of the novelist. The father of the latter appears to have been a Mr Richmond Thackeray, who died in 1815.

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